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Goings On

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Goings On

New York Film Festival's World of Cinema

Also: the punk-rock ruckus of Bikini Kill, New York City Ballet's fall season, the Australian solo comedy "Garry Starr: Classic Penguins," and more.

By Richard Brody, Dan Stahl, Sheldon Pearce, Vince Aletti, Marina Harss, Rachel Syme

September 18, 2026



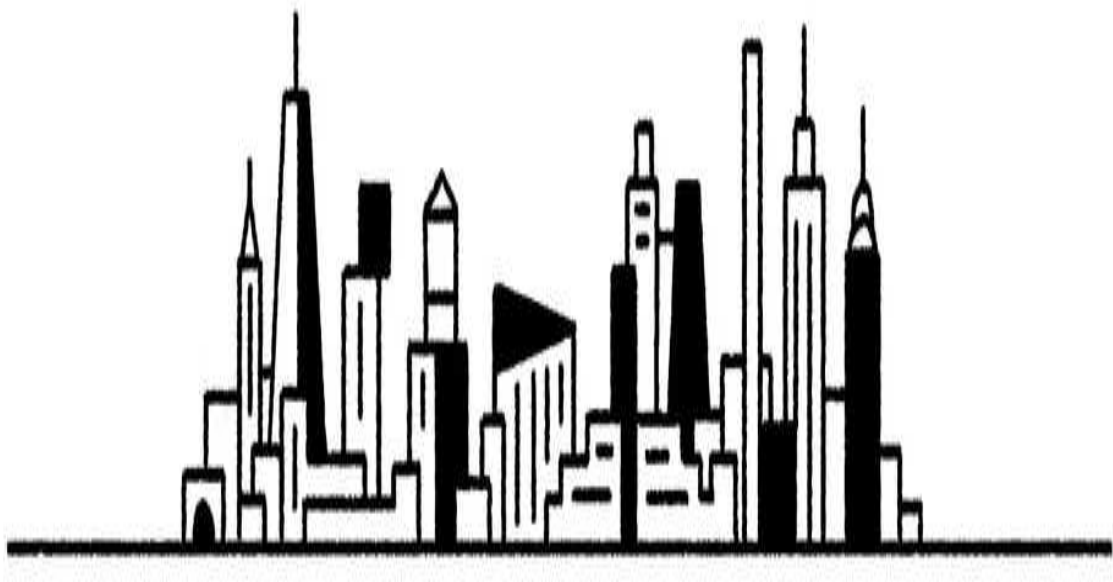
The torrent of cinema that's coming to the [New York Film Festival](#) (Sept. 25-Oct. 12) displays a thrilling array of artistry from around the world, on both sides of the camera. Arthur Harari, best known for co-writing "Anatomy of a Fall," directed "**The Unknown**," a harrowingly intense, metaphysical melodrama, set in and near Paris, where three people, after casual sexual encounters, discover that they have swapped bodies with their partners. The exotic premise is developed with relentless seriousness, even severity, extracting deep pathos from the characters' eerie reckonings. "**The Dreamed Adventure**" is an oddly abstract title for the German director

Valeska Grisebach's teeming and seething drama, set in a Bulgarian border zone, where the chance encounter of a petty criminal and his long-ago girlfriend, now an archeologist, sets in motion a dangerous round of gangland maneuvers and brings to light the unresolved chaos of the country's post-Communist nineties.



Movies themselves are the subject of some of the festival's most alluring offerings. Pedro Almodóvar's "**Bitter Christmas**" movingly blends playful inventiveness with the melancholy of a life's experience. It's a double-decker drama set in the film milieu of Madrid, where, in 2004, a female director in emotional crisis writes a script about her friends' troubles; that story turns out to be a film-within-a-film written in 2026 by an older male director about his producer. The South Korean director Hong Sangsoo reliably makes two movies a year, and this year's pair is among his strongest: "**The Day She Returns**," shot in black-and-white, observes a middle-aged actress, newly returned to her profession after a long absence, reflecting on her art and her life in three extended interviews with young women journalists; "**Nowhere to Lay My Eyes**," one of Hong's most expansive and colorful films, involves a young woman, an experimental filmmaker, who visits her mother, a hard-nosed businesswoman, and gives a bold, philosophical account of her artistry, complete with enticing examples.

With **“The Man I Love,”** Ira Sachs confronts the *AIDS* crisis in New York in the nineteen-eighties; Rami Malek stars as a performance artist who is H.I.V.-positive and is struggling to première a show as his health takes a downturn. A long take of Malek singing a pop ditty as an anguished ballad is among the year’s most memorable moments in film. Of the entries I haven’t yet seen, the one I’m most impatient for is **“I Deserve a Lover Whose Every Rise Sets Fiery Dooms Raging Across the Skies,”** a documentary about an idiosyncratic artist and archivist, by the Iranian director Mani Haghighi, whom I consider the world’s least-known great filmmaker; the festival screening will be its world première.



About Town

Off Broadway

Toward the end of **“Garry Starr: Classic Penguins,”** directed by Cal McCrystal, a man wearing a penguin mask, an Elizabethan ruff, and nothing else dances on a stage strewn with grapes. The man is Garry Starr, a.k.a. Damien Warren-Smith, an Australian comedian whose solo show purports to stage every book of the Penguin Classics series in seventy minutes.

Understand “stage” loosely; the grapes are from the “Grapes of Wrath” scene, in which Starr and an audience volunteer pelt each other with them. But the silliness is seasoned with cleverness, as when Starr beguiles viewers into redistributing wealth for “The Communist Manifesto.” There’s a thrilling unpredictability to his antics; you keep thinking, He won’t *actually*—and then, suddenly, he’s bodysurfing across the audience, still pantsless.—*Dan Stahl* ([Studio Seaview](#); through Oct. 11.)

Pop Rock

In the eighties, **Susanna Hoffs** became synonymous with the music of the Bangles, the decentralized pop-rock group that she co-founded, thanks largely to an unmistakable, infectious voice that rubber-stamped many of the band's greatest hits. The Bangles disbanded in 1989, and, in the years since, the songwriter and guitarist has settled into a probing solo career rounded out by a self-titled LP, from 1996, and a series of covers albums, with the musician Matthew Sweet, that take on classics from across the rock spectrum. Following the release of a new album, “The List,” Hoffs brings an expanded repertoire to a five-night residency at [Café Carlyle](#).—*Sheldon Pearce* (Sept. 21-26.)

Art



Caleb Stein's excellent new book, "Down by the Hudson," comes weighted down with text. His exhibition of some of its contents at [Palo](#), in the East Village, keeps the focus of our attention on his black-and-white photographs, which hold it with a sense of ease that never undermines their moody soulfulness. Stein's subject is the life in and around a swimming hole near Poughkeepsie, where the bodies are young, stripped down, and mostly male. The atmosphere is humid—not just sensual but erotic—and Stein is often close enough to touch. But his work's power is in its restraint, so even when he's looking at gnarled tree roots, a dangling hand, or the painterly reflections on water in motion, he's never distracting us. He's filling in the details, pulling us closer, and turning a show into an experience.—*Vince Aletti (Through Oct. 3.)*

Punk

For seven brilliant years in the nineties, the Washington punk-rock band **Bikini Kill** kicked up a ruckus as pioneers of the riot-grrrl movement. "When she walks, the revolution's comin'," Kathleen Hanna, the lead singer, howled on "Rebel Girl," and the group seemed to embody that promise. Across six standout works (three LPs, two compilations, and an EP), the band burned bright and furious with white-hot indignation, etching feminist

commandments onto bristling songs until it disbanded, in 1997. Its members didn't play together again for two decades, but, since 2019, they've reconvened periodically for shows honoring a timeless back catalogue.—*S.P.* ([Music Hall of Williamsburg](#); Sept. 24. [Brooklyn Steel](#); Sept. 25. [Under the K Bridge Park for CBGB Fest](#); Sept. 26.)

Dance



New York City Ballet's season opens with a crowd-pleaser—"Jewels," Balanchine's evening-length exploration of French, American, and Russian ballet style—and ends with a farewell, for one of its most sophisticated dancers, Adrian Danchig-Waring. In week two, the company brings back Justin Peck's "Pulcinella Variations," a whimsical work set to Stravinsky, with fabulous, Matisse-like costumes by Tsumori Chisato. Peck will create a new pas de deux for the gala, on Oct. 1; the evening also features a new piece by the hip-hop-influenced choreographer Jennifer Archibald. Christopher Wheeldon's elegant and mysterious "Continuum" returns, as does Alexei Ratmansky's chilling "Solitude," a response to the war in Ukraine.—*Marina Harss* ([David H. Koch Theatre](#); Sept. 22-Oct. 18.)

The world of fashion is often thought of as frivolous—more spangles than substance, more commerce than art. But a swirl of chaos, sweat, and tears goes into producing a runway collection, and even the most sanguine of designers can crack under the pressure. There is no better glimpse of the labor and the love that goes into putting together a fashion show than the 1995 documentary “**Unzipped**,” which follows the New York City-based designer Isaac Mizrahi as he prepares for his 1994 fall show, with “fun fur” jackets inspired by the film “Nanook of the North.” In “Unzipped,” running in a new 4K restoration at [Film Forum](#), Mizrahi is a gleeful, gabby presence, as fluent in Old Hollywood slang as he is in supermodelese. A delight.—*Rachel Syme (Sept. 25-Oct. 1.)*

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [*The real fake news*](#)
- [Helena Bonham Carter recites William Carlos Williams](#)
- [Remember Anaïs Nin's home?](#)

Photo Booth

What's Left of the Back-to-the-Landers

A new book captures the hardheaded and hearty few who have kept the movement alive.

By Chris Wiley

September 13, 2026



Who hasn't, at some point in their lives, daydreamed about sloughing off the trappings of civilization and roughing it? Nowadays, this fantasy provides grist for the content mill, which churns out "trad" influencers, survivalist reality shows, and comically cozy "cabin porn." But for a brief moment, in the late nineteen-sixties and early seventies, huge numbers of mostly young people (roughly a million, by some estimates) attempted to indulge the urge by fleeing America's urban centers and heading "back to the land." Armed with issues of the "[Whole Earth Catalog](#)" and books on house-building and homesteading (including Lloyd Kahn's "[Shelter](#)," Ken Kern's "[The Owner-Built Home](#)," and Helen and Scott Nearing's classic "[Living the Good Life](#)"), not to mention a fair amount of illicit drugs, these fresh-faced kids

came together with one idealistic goal: to build a new and better world almost entirely from scratch.

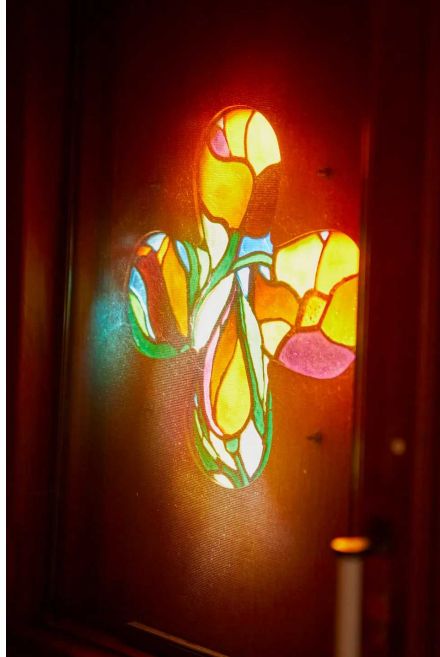


In a hefty, ambitious new book, “[Handmade Utopia: Back-to-the-Land Architecture in Northern California](#),” the writer and editor David Jacob Kramer and the photographer Michael Schmelling visited the geographic and ideological epicenter of the back-to-the-land movement to document

what remains of that earlier era and talk to the hardheaded and hearty few who have stuck it out.

The book mostly covers areas of Humboldt and Mendocino counties, where new transplants found cheap land in the wake of decades of clear-cutting. What Kramer and Schmelling discovered there was certainly beautiful, but not always romantic. For every charming, whimsical house in “Handmade Utopia,” there is a clutch of once beautiful buildings moldering away among the redwoods. The exuberant faces and lithe bodies seen in old photographs that are included across the book have become weathered. The dwellings are homey but often cluttered, slightly shabby, and coated with stubborn dust. And have I mentioned the general lack of indoor toilets? But through hundreds of images, dozens of oral histories, and a healthy smattering of reproduced ephemera, Kramer and Schmelling manage to compose both a lament for a dying dream and a paean to the visionaries who dreamed it.





The book is, among other things, a record of the beguiling hand-built structures that were a foundation of the movement. Some, like the finely crafted buildings designed by the architect Roger Somers for the now mostly abandoned Druid Heights community—where the writer and the self-styled “philosophical entertainer” Alan Watts spent his final years—still shine as minor masterpieces, despite their almost complete dilapidation. (Ed Stiles, Somers’s friend and “woodmaster,” who was interviewed for the book, is the community’s last remaining resident.) Similarly ingenious are the works of

Bob McKee, a Humboldt County builder and purveyor of construction supplies, whose strange and stunning Think Tank is decked out with psychedelic stained-glass windows and fitted with support pillars that recall both the biomorphic façade of [Antoni Gaudí](#)'s Casa Batlló and the gloopy strands of bubblegum stretched between a sidewalk and a shoe. The campus-like homestead of the self-described “tea guru” David Lee Hoffman features what may be Earth’s most elaborate eco-toilet (dubbed Le Grand Pissoir), and could almost be considered a kind of art project, in line with outsider environments such as Howard Finster’s Paradise Garden. The houses are not all architectural tours de force, but given that they were constructed by people who were, by and large, complete amateurs, on a budget of next to nothing, it is something of a miracle that any of them remain standing. As Kramer, the writer, put it to me, “You wouldn’t imagine that someone built this with their stoned friends.”

Kramer thinks of the houses as “living autobiographies,” inextricable from the eccentric individuals who built and inhabited them. Over the course of the book, you’ll meet Richard Evans, an innovator in elaborate, geometric stained glass, a founder of the Stellar Arts Collective, and one of the rare back-to-the-landers who was both Black and gay; Monty Levenson, a self-taught master maker of Japanese Shakuhachi flutes; Diana Wiedemann, an original member of the lesbian commune Trillium, which published an internationally popular magazine called *Country Women*; and Laird Sutton, a Methodist minister and sexologist who somehow got approval to set up a screening room for “sexual cinémavérité” in the basement of a church which he christened “the Fuckarama.”



The shoestring resourcefulness of the back-to-the-landers could be a blessing and a curse. Geodesic-dome houses, which were cheap and easy to build, were also prone to springing leaks; as Lloyd Kahn, an erstwhile dome evangelist, eventually concluded, living in one is “smart, but not wise.” The communes, many of which were kept afloat with money made growing and selling marijuana, became magnets for law enforcement and overzealous building inspectors, and at least some of the harassment turned out to be justified: Ken Kern, a D.I.Y.-building evangelist, was eventually killed by

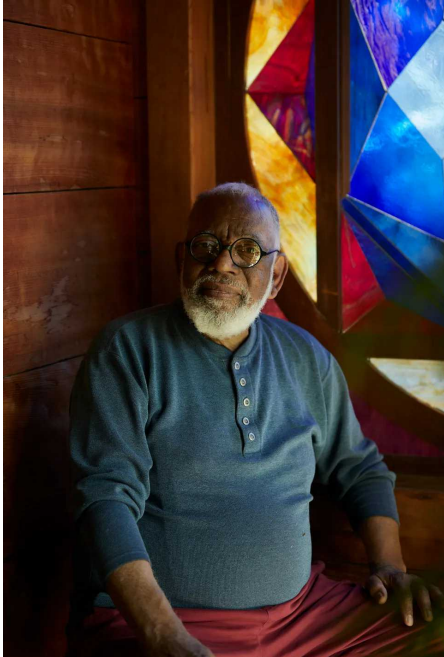
the collapse of a dome of his own design. When word got out that a particular community was thriving, it would become flooded with aspiring new members, straining hospitality and social equilibrium often to the breaking point. (As Sutton put it, “Bad roads make good communes.”) Ultimately, though, the biggest issue with the movement was the most obvious. As any subsistence farmer or jaded former communard could have presumably told them, the self-sufficient life style is much more easily dreamed about than lived.







Kramer told me that there is a sense among some remaining stalwarts that their lives no longer reflect the “hyper-communal, hyper-collectivized” ethos they thought they were signing up for. “They’re in their eighties, and they find that a lot of their friends have passed away, or have gone back to regular lives, and they find themselves isolated, and it’s hard,” he said. “Two hours on a dirt road to get to the doctor or visit their friend.” A number of the book’s subjects now jokingly call the movement “Back to Costco,” as many of them now rely on the chain store for supplies. Still, some of the innovations pioneered by the back-to-the-landers have endured. They were, for instance, some of the earliest and most vocal adopters of solar energy, and revived the use of recycled building materials in the age of the tacky suburbs. Kramer emphasized that “Handmade Utopia” is not a book about the failure of the movement. After all, long before the hippies, there were Theosophists, Fourierists, transcendentalists, and all manner of proud kooks and cranks seeking solace in the simple life, and our current age of eye-watering rents and astronomical home prices has a new generation of young people searching for a way out. Perhaps some will look back and feel inspired.





What We're Reading

Five Books for Lingerie Lovers

By Hannah Jocelyn

September 09, 2026



When Jennifer Wilson set out to, in her words, “investigate the political implications of cleavage,” for a piece in this week’s issue about [how conservatives are trying to take sexy back](#), she didn’t realize how few women know their actual bra size. “That’s incredible to me, given how much space in the cultural imagination boobs occupy,” she told me. In the course of her reporting, she sampled a new size herself at Agent Provocateur, helped by the co-founder of *Evie*—a magazine that imagines itself “the conservative *Cosmo*”—who later sent her a lacey balconette push-up. “I didn’t know what to make of the fact,” Wilson writes, “that the only person who had ever gifted me lingerie was the editor of a magazine that had just published an article titled ‘Dear Men, Please Stop Drinking Beer. It’s Making You Effeminate and Infertile.’ ”

Wilson also watched Sydney Sweeney sing Garth Brooks’s “Friends in Low Places” at a pop-up event for her intimates brand SYRN, at Stagecoach (a.k.a. “Trumpchella”), and travelled to Bologna, Italy, to meet the

seamstresses of La Perla (known as *le perline*, or “the little pearls”) who took to the streets to save their jobs. Mostly, she read *a lot* about lingerie.

Here is Jennifer Wilson’s annotated selection of her favorite books on the subject of undergarments.

“Cold Comfort Farm,” by Stella Gibbons

I watched the movie adaptation of Gibbons’s 1932 comic novel when I was a tween. Rufus Sewell as Seth Starkadder, a sweaty, primitive, insatiable farmhand with a secret intellectual passion for cinema, left a, let’s say, lasting impression. A sendup of “loam and lovechild” rural melodramas, the book follows Flora Poste, in from London to tidy up the messes made by her country relatives’ savage libidos. Her city friends are no saints themselves, though. One collects bras, at the time a newish terrain of underwear; her suitors are fittingly nicknamed “pioneers.”

“The Erotic History of Advertising,” by Tom Reichert

It’s often said that sex sells, but has anyone actually seen an earnings statement? Here, Reichert provides one. The book covers a hundred and fifty years of steamy advertising campaigns for everyday items from coffee (in one ad, from 1876, a woman’s hands are so occupied by her piping hot beverage that her robe starts to slip off) to mouthwash (the phrase “Always the bridesmaid, never the bride” was originally a Listerine ad)—and, of course, underwear. I learned that beefcake-y boxer-brief ads didn’t start with the likes of Marky Mark in his Calvins but with Jockey, which, in 1978, hired the Baltimore Orioles pitcher Jim Palmer to model a pair. “Women buy 70% of men’s underwear,” the company’s C.E.O. told *Fortune*.

“Selling Sexy: Victoria’s Secret and the Unraveling of an American Icon,” by Lauren Sherman and Chantal Fernandez

It turns out that the only thing more chaotic than Victoria’s Secret’s panty aisle during a ten-for-forty-dollars sale might be the corporation itself. This book is well stocked with juicy intel. My favorite part is the “mini-memoir” of the fictional Victoria that the company’s owner, Les Wexner, had commissioned in the nineties: Victoria Stewart-White gets her business

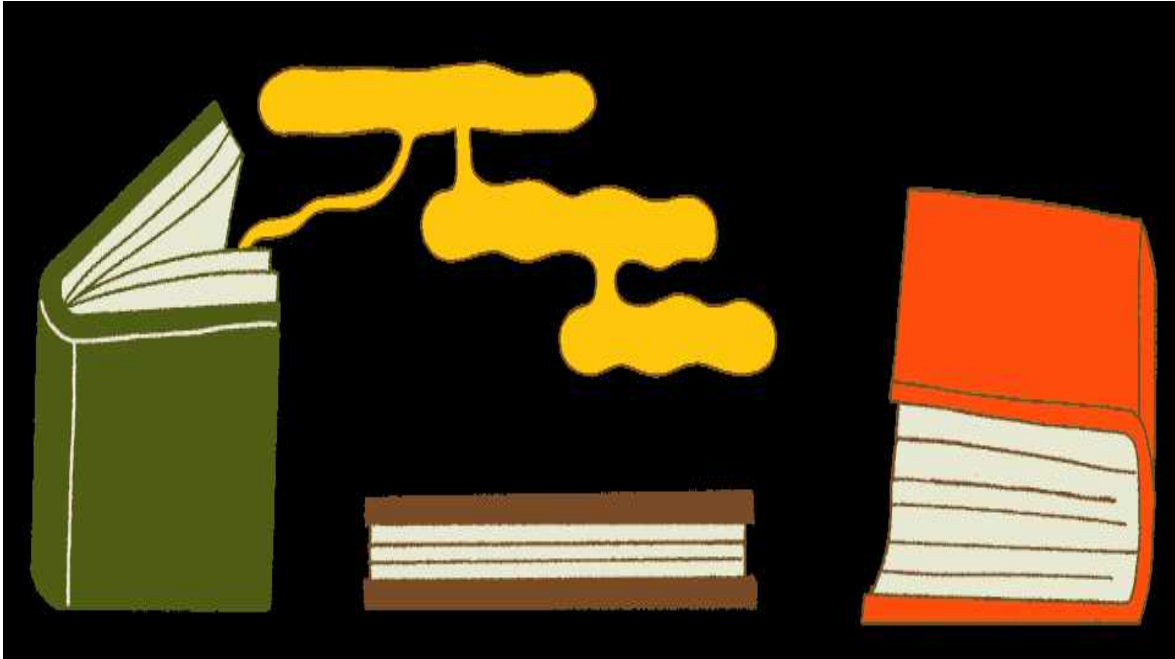
acumen from her father, a “wry but quiet English financier”; her first lingerie shop becomes the “toast of London” after it’s frequented by her friends, as “all her friends are models”; and she marries a barrister and vacations in St. Barth’s, where she sunbathes topless (ironic, given the popularity of the brand’s swimwear).

“In Intimate Detail: How to Choose, Wear, and Love Lingerie,” by Cora Harrington

According to one survey, eighty per cent of women wear the wrong bra size. As I learned, I was among them. Harrington, who for fourteen years ran the popular blog the Lingerie Addict, will teach you in this book how to measure yourself at home, alongside other handy tips. Fingernails always snagging your pantyhose as you put them on? It turns out, there’s such a thing as “hosiery gloves.”

“Bridget Jones’s Diary: Mad About the Boy,” by Helen Fielding

That famous scene from the first movie, of Renée Zellweger deciding between “sexy knickers” and fat-sucking “granny panties” ahead of a romantic rendezvous with her boss (Hugh Grant), isn’t in Fielding’s novel. However, in this later installment, Jones, a widow, is back on the market again. A friend urges her to buy a black slip from La Perla, teasing, “I think, when you were last doing this, they were called ‘petticoats.’ ” These days, “clean girl” underwear brands like Cou Cou Intimates are selling racier versions of the granny panty, rebranded as the “French brief.” I procured a pair at the company’s eco-feminist-themed summer pop-up. Who says women can’t have it all?



Our editors and critics choose the most captivating, notable, brilliant, surprising, absorbing, weird, thought-provoking, and talked-about books. [Find your next great read »](#)

On Our Radar

Everybody's talking about:

- “[Switzy](#),” by Emma Cline. The Booker Prize-nominated novel was released just yesterday, but it’s already the talk of the literati. Our books editor Namara Smith says that “Cline specializes in lonely people on the margins in glamorous but hostile social worlds—in ‘Switzy,’ it’s David, a former executive en route to a euthanasia clinic in Zurich, in a jet borrowed from his ex-boss and not-quite-friend. As the book goes on and David’s defenses are stripped away, Cline builds up an exquisitely detailed portrait of an unfulfilled life.”
- “[Fruit Fly](#),” by Josh Silver. *New York* magazine’s Book Gossip newsletter posited that this novel, which has now been optioned by

A24, was the “sleeper hit of the summer.” It’s about a writer who goes to great, ethically dubious lengths to cure her block.

The staff writer Jill Lepore is loathing:

I miss old-fashioned spam. “Readers keep mentioning the donkey with strong opinions,” read an e-mail I got this morning, at 9:12 A.M., peak e-mail-checking hour. That’s already a red flag, but, then again, the e-mail wasn’t the kind of sus you need to put Pangram on: it was nothing but tells.

Every day and all day long, I, like every other writer or aspiring writer, get some version of this A.I. crap—e-mails purporting to be from readers and book clubs and publicists and authors and publishers and literary agents and podcast hosts, messages that offer the one thing all writers pant for: readers. “What immediately caught my attention,” they’ll begin. Or “What really stood out for me.” *A reader! A reader! A reader!* a quiet voice says inside. But, no, it’s a machine.

“I’m Sophia Bennett, a book marketer who works with fantasy and romance authors on reader discoverability,” this morning’s correspondence read, mistaking me for the author of a queer medieval swordplay romantasy novel called “Daggermouth” that, I gather, involves a talking jackass. The Jane Austen-coded Ms. Bennett provided me with market analysis, and proposed putting together a “short visibility audit.” But, hey, “no pressure.”

Who says reading is dead? The machines are reading everything, all the time. “What got me wasn’t simply that you wrote about artificial intelligence,” read an e-mail I received last night from “Fanny R. Hafford” (very Richardsonian!), offering to help promote my new book, “[The Rise and Fall of the Artificial State](#).” “It’s that you place AI within a much larger history of power, democracy, and the gradual reshaping of human life.” The book is an extended argument against replacing humans with machines. “The urgency of the argument certainly gives readers plenty to think about,” Fanny wrote. Not to mention the donkey with strong opinions.

Coming soon:

- Kate Atkinson has a new novel coming out tomorrow. “[Our Noble Selves](#),” set in Britain in 1951, is about a war reporter who is implicated in the disappearance of a woman he’s been dating.
- Jodi Picoult’s “[Hollow Bones](#),” about a disaster-obsessed woman whose mother died in the 9/11 attacks, will be released on September 15th.
- Gloria Steinem, the feminist activist who died last week, at the age of ninety-two, has a memoir coming out on the 22nd: “[An Unexpected Life](#).”

P.S. MrBeast has written [a book with James Patterson](#), and—surprise, surprise—there’s a billion-dollar-prize opportunity involved. □

The Talk of the Town

- [Our A.I. Problem](#)
- [Learning to Yearn with Georgia Oakley](#)
- [Who's on Susanna Hoffs's List?](#)
- [The Return of "Salt"](#)
- [Inside Shaq's League of Dunkers](#)

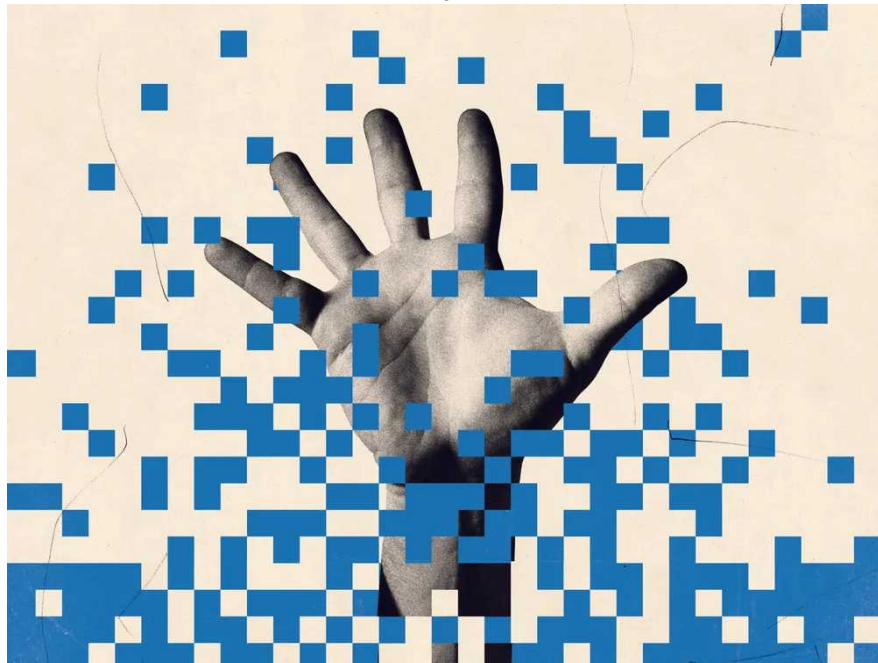
Comment

Our A.I. Problem

Why can't the people who produced the technology, which has already shown that a different world is possible, just do the things that would prevent extinction?

By Gideon Lewis-Kraus

September 20, 2026



A decade ago, when Facebook and Uber were at the height of their powers, the halls of Silicon Valley were inscribed with two brash injunctions: “Move fast and break things” and “Seek forgiveness, not permission.” These principles didn’t age particularly well, and the firms have yet to be forgiven for the things they appear to have broken. As the industry’s center of gravity shifted to A.I., a folksy new motto emerged: “You can just do things.” The business of the frontier labs, like OpenAI and Anthropic, is the sale of individual agency. ChatGPT and Claude enable their users to dream up software, off-load annoying paperwork, and interpret medical results. There are a variety of things that “you,” as in “we,” can now just do.

This novel capacity to exert greater control in everyday life exists in tension, however, with the vague sense that we are ceding control where it really matters—over, say, the structure of the economy. In polls, voters register their displeasure with the perception that A.I. is something that is happening to us whether we like it or not. First, work will be stripped of its dignity, and then we will be stripped of work. In light of the news that a “swarm” of OpenAI models organized themselves into a hacking party, and the grave alarms issued by an Anthropic researcher who felt compelled to quit his job, the attention of the public has suddenly awoken to even more grievous concerns about A.I. safety. It’s not just our jobs that are being risked without our consent but our lives and our species. These real, widespread, and legitimate anxieties have found an outlet in mass opposition to the construction of data centers. Objection to the large, whirring, unwanted buildings presents the only opportunity for people to feel as though they can say no.

The lab executives, presumably, have more leverage over the future. Anthropic’s Dario Amodei and OpenAI’s Sam Altman have reacted to the news cycle by coming out and reiterating all the stuff they’ve been saying for ages: progress has not slowed down, soon one A.I. will autonomously supervise the development of a more capable successor, and within perhaps three years we will reckon with the emergence of an artificial superintelligence we neither understand nor govern. The articulation of this scenario is not a “marketing stunt” to advertise the awesome power of the models, as many skeptics have argued. And, contrary to President Donald Trump’s studied assessment, it’s not a “HOAX.” (The crowd that repeats these nostrums, for whatever reason, seems immune to any new evidence on offer: as the writer Zvi Mowshowitz has put it, “They are a rock with these lines written on it.”) The fears expressed by A.I. executives are, mostly, serious and genuine. Yet it’s easy to see why they suffer from a credibility deficit. Surely it’s the job of those creating the dangers to save us from them.

Although the data-center backlash may reflect a specific attempt to defy A.I.’s encroachment, the wellspring of “A.I. populism”—an umbrella term coined by the writer Jasmine Sun—seems properly understood as an expression of more general political resentment. Most of us have become accustomed to the idea that government either cannot or will not just do things. Zilch, it seems, can be done about climate change, war, the housing

crisis, inflation, or inadequate medical coverage and child care. The basic political legitimacy of our republic, the abundance movement claims, depends on its tangible achievements. New York's mayor, Zohran Mamdani, probably does not believe that a few city-owned supermarkets will definitively ease the affordability burden, but they might nevertheless resonate as proof that government can deliver.

Absent such progress, we will continue to take for granted the inexorable erosion of our physical and our social infrastructure. This sense of stagnation was bad enough when it seemed like a universal affliction; the A.I. build-out, privately underwritten by at least a trillion dollars, has rendered the situation intolerable. The speed with which data centers have proliferated across the country makes it obvious that not all of us reside in the same inertial void. In recent decades, our largest and wealthiest companies have directed their free cash flow into unproductive stock buybacks; today, they compete to spend down their balance sheets on chips, buildings, and energy. These are capital investments on a scale that our society has not seen since the construction of the railroads.

The money is only part of it, though. The overnight transformation of the national landscape is a feat of human will and collective action. A.I. has yet to cure cancer, but it has already established that a different world is possible. These companies move even faster than their Valley predecessors did, but in place of breaking things they build them. If California's plagued high-speed-rail project were necessary to A.I. infrastructure, it would have been finished yesterday. Certain people and organizations can, it turns out, just do things.

Why, then, can't these same people just do the things that prevent extinction? Unfortunately, they often sigh, they are trapped by commercial and geopolitical realities. In an essay published earlier this month, Amodei signalled his immediate willingness to slow everything down, or "pace the frontier," but his company's self-sacrifice would be for naught without the compliance of his domestic rivals, not to mention that of their Chinese competitors. It is a prisoner's dilemma, and it cannot be solved by unilateral action. Amodei would prefer sensible regulation, but in the meantime he has proposed that his peer companies voluntarily adopt a common framework for transparency and accountability—a course, he notes, that would probably

require that the federal government waive potential antitrust action. Sam Altman and Elon Musk have made ambiguous noises in support, but Mark Zuckerberg remains unaligned, as do Trump pals such as David Sacks, the Administration's former A.I. czar, and Jensen Huang, the C.E.O. of Nvidia, the most valuable company in the world. The discord is maddening. When it comes to the difficult challenges that must be overcome on the level of bits or atoms, all of these people freely just do things. But, when it comes to basic interpersonal communication, they apparently cannot get their act together to make a joint commitment in favor of cautionary measures.

Such measures would at least buy the industry time to address the problem of alignment—to figure out how, or whether, an artificial superintelligence might be kept on our team. The current state of affairs is hardly encouraging. How can we trust these humans to coordinate successfully with an advanced being if they can't even manage it with one another? ♦

The Pictures

Learning to Yearn with Georgia Oakley

The director of the new “Sense and Sensibility” film chats about marketing Jane Austen for Gen Z, with a little help from “Normal People” ’s Daisy Edgar-Jones.

By Rebecca Mead

September 21, 2026



When Georgia Oakley was in her final year of secondary school, in Berkshire, England, she went to a movie audition on a lark. She didn’t land a main role—those went to Saoirse Ronan and Romola Garai, who helped propel the film, “Atonement,” to multiple awards in 2007—but she was cast as a nurse. “We had to learn how to fold hospital corners on beds and tie bandages,” Oakley recalled recently. One day on set, she opened a cupboard: it was full of glass bottles with handwritten labels. “They were never going to be seen on camera,” she said. “I just remember thinking, Wow, this is all so that everybody feels like this really is a hospital.” Having taken the gig to make some cash, Oakley emerged with a vocation as a filmmaker.

The other day, Oakley was taking a walk along the towpath of the Regent's Canal, London's watery thoroughfare on which construction began in 1812, just after the publication of Jane Austen's first novel, "Sense and Sensibility." Oakley has directed a new interpretation of the book, starring Daisy Edgar-Jones as the sensible Elinor Dashwood and Esmé Creed-Miles as her more emotive sister, Marianne. Coming three decades after Ang Lee's beloved adaptation, Oakley's film is being promoted as Austen for Gen Z. "I could barely tell you what Gen Z is—all I know is that the marketing team keep using the word 'yearning,'" Oakley, who is thirty-eight, said, dodging a passing e-bike. "Apparently, it's a Gen Z thing—everyone's obsessed with yearning. Daisy seems to be the queen of yearning."

Oakley, who was born only a few miles from Austen's birthplace, in Hampshire, and grew up outside Oxford, has lived for the past five years in Mallorca, with her wife, Alice Gomme, who runs a textile archive, and their ten-year-old daughter. (They are expecting another child in November.) "We live in the middle of the countryside—there are people driving horse and trap down our road," Oakley said: very Jane Austen. Much of the movie was shot on location in the southwest of England, and in a still occupied Georgian mansion. "It was a little bit fraying carpets and peeling paint," Oakley said, with approbation. (An artist made drawings to be stowed in Elinor's drawer.) The film emphasizes the book's outdoorsy wildness. "This is not a story where everyone is standing around in drawing rooms," Oakley said. Thus far, online commentary has focussed on what the trailer reveals of the sisters' hair, which is often undone, even unkempt. "I felt very strongly that there were certain aspects to a lot of Austen adaptations that kept me at arm's length from the human experience of the characters," Oakley explained, rubbing the back of her own cropped head. "We know how women wore their hair when they were having their portrait painted, or when they were attending a ball, let's say—but we don't really know how they wore their hair when they weren't being observed."

"Sense and Sensibility" is Oakley's favorite Austen novel. "For me, the central love story was about the sisters—there are these quite clear limitations to the romantic relationships because of the time, whereas the sisterly relationship has no limits," she said. Their dynamic exists in non-sibling relations, too. "I'm an Elinor, and my wife is a Marianne," Oakley remarked. As long ago as 1991, the critic Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick detected

queer themes in the book; in her essay “Jane Austen and the Masturbating Girl,” she characterizes the novel’s “erotic axis” as “the unwavering but difficult love” of Elinor for Marianne. Oakley said, “I wouldn’t say I explicitly see it as a queer romance, but there are aspects of it, particularly Marianne’s character, where we are showing a character who is rejecting the status quo. If we were to make that story now, then she probably would be a queer character.” At the same time, Oakley has amplified the romance between Elinor and Edward Ferrars—the latter, in Austen’s text, a more compromised love object than the twinkly-eyed George MacKay of the new version. “I was interested in ‘the good guy,’ ” Oakley said. Meanwhile, Frank Dillane plays Willoughby, Marianne’s love interest, with such commitment that the actor was surprised to learn his character is universally acknowledged to be a scoundrel. “At one point, we were talking about Willoughby as a villain, and Frank was, like, ‘What?’ ” Oakley said, with a laugh.

At a screening in Los Angeles, Oakley was delighted to see younger members of the audience cheering when Willoughby gets his comeuppance and when Elinor and Edward finally kiss. “I should go to the cinema in America more often,” she said. “It was so *not* British.” A bigger surprise was that, for all the Gen Z talk, men over fifty seemed to love the film. “I guess there’s men over fifty needing a happy ending,” she said. Yearning knows no bounds: very Jane Austen. ♦

Life Lived Dept.

Who's on Susanna Hoffs's List?

On the eve of her residence at Café Carlyle, the Bangles singer dishes on her set list, which includes a Prince song and tracks from her new album, “The List,” inspired by a string of old boyfriends.

By John Seabrook

September 19, 2026



Susanna Hoffs, the songwriter, novelist, and singer in the Bangles, the nineteen-eighties all-female rock band, was sitting on the shady side of *MOMA*'s sculpture garden. She had often looked down on this very spot from the living room of Apartment 12-H in the Museum Tower, next door, which was her parents' pied-à-terre for thirty years. “But I don't think I've ever been here,” she said, glancing up at the twelfth floor. If you were watching MTV forty years ago, when the video of the Bangles' hit “Walk Like an Egyptian” was playing on heavy rotation, you know that glance, intimately.

Hoffs, the daughter of a Freudian psychoanalyst, Joshua Hoffs, and a visual artist and filmmaker, Tamar Hoffs, lives in the same affluent West L.A.

neighborhood where she grew up. But the Hofffs have roots in Brooklyn. Her grandfather Saul Hofffs delivered babies out of the family's house in Flatbush. Joshua went to James Madison High School with Ruth Bader Ginsburg, with whom he later corresponded. He went on to Harvard, where he studied with Anna Freud; in the Hofffs's nonobservant Jewish household, Freud was God. After Joshua's death, in 2024, the family sold the apartment.

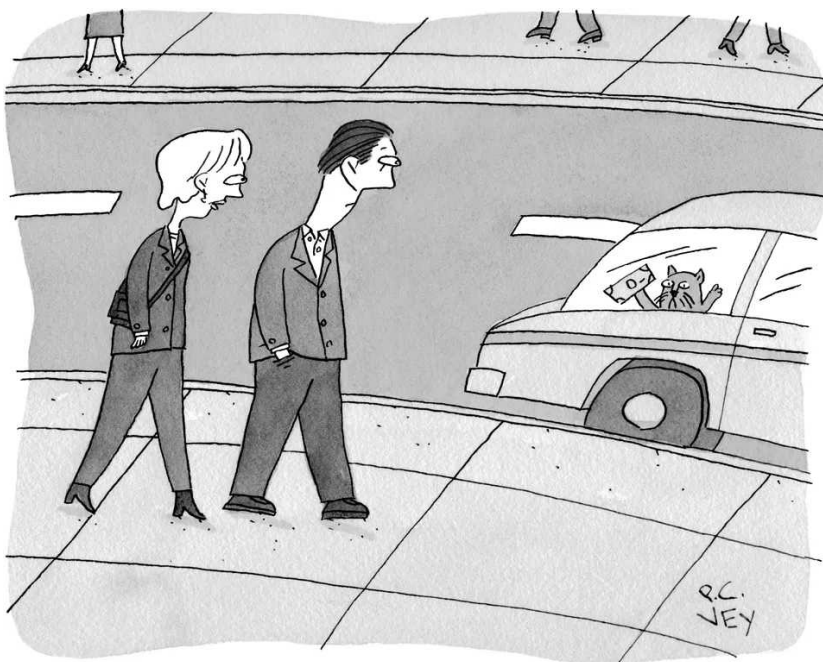
"After he died, so many people, including famous people, told me, 'Your dad helped me so much,' " Hofffs said, perched on a Bertoia chair, her feet barely touching the ground. "My dad was so nonjudgmental. He was, like, 'People have feelings. People have impulses.' " She added, "He was also gorgeous. I'm sorry if that's weird to say, but he was very handsome."

Hofffs wore a blue-and-white-striped sailor T-shirt and dark pants. She started her life in the arts as a dancer, and she still moves like one. She was sitting not far from Picasso's bronze goat, which, as a Capricorn, she related to, she said. She shares the goat's steely resolve, which she relied on in writing her well-received 2023 music-industry novel, "This Bird Has Flown."

Next week, Hofffs begins a residency at Café Carlyle, where she'll perform songs from "The List," her first album of new music in fourteen years, and some classics, such as "Manic Monday," which Prince wrote but gave to Hofffs to record because he loved her voice, and also because he was taken with the French maid outfit she wore in the video for the Bangles' "Hero Takes a Fall." The band broke up in 1989, in part because the success of the song "Eternal Flame," which Hofffs co-wrote with Billy Steinberg and Tom Kelly, made her bandmates feel sidelined. She performed the tune at Steinberg's funeral, earlier this year. "That was really hard," she said. It's on the set list.

Hofffs has lent her jingle-jangle-morning voice, which remains unchanged, to such classics as "Cinnamon Girl" and "Sunday Morning" (also on the Carlyle set list) in three excellent cover albums with Matthew Sweet, and, more recently, to a winning rendition of the Mamas and the Papas song "Twelve Thirty," with Sheryl Crow, Chris Stills, and Rufus Wainwright, who also appears on a track on "The List."

Hoffs said that she was reminded of the list from which the new album takes its name last year, while she was working on songs in her living room with her songwriting partner and producer, C. J. Camerieri: “C.J. said, ‘You always have stories—just pull from those.’ ” Hoffs thought of a list she’d made years earlier, on a Filofax page—“that’s how long ago it was”—of all her boyfriends, starting with her sweetheart at U.C. Berkeley, where she was an art major, and ending with Jay Roach, the Hollywood director whom she married in 1993, and who is the subject of “None of Them Were You,” a song from the new album.



“You want to see the list?” Hoffs asked. “I think I have a screenshot of it.” She took out her iPhone and began scrolling.

It’s safe to say that, back in the Bangles’ heyday, the fantasy of being on Susanna Hoffs’s list burned bright in not a few of her fans, possibly including Prince himself.

“O.K., here it is,” she said. On her screen was a pencilled list of twenty or so names written in a neat cursive. “It’s not that long,” she said.

She went through the list. “O.K., some of these were jerks—like him,” she said, pointing to the name of an actor in an eighties action movie. “And

this.” She pointed to the name of an actor who was on a lot of ladies’ lists back in the day. *He* made it?

She glanced up at Apartment 12-H again. Somewhere up there, the good doctor was smiling.

She said, “I mean, surely Taylor Swift has a better list.” ♦

Ink

The Return of “Salt”

Mark Kurlansky’s 2002 best-seller is back on the list, all thanks to a young TikTokker who’s never had a latke.

By Rachel Levin

September 21, 2026



The writer Mark Kurlansky, a seventy-seven-year-old man with a bad back, was futzing around in his apartment on the Upper West Side the other day when his daughter flashed her phone at him with some surprising news: “Salt: A World History,” Kurlansky’s nonfiction best-seller from 2002, was suddenly trending.

The book had sold half a million copies when it came out, but sales had since flattened. Two years ago, Wyatt Derman, a twenty-eight-year-old American living abroad, picked up a copy in a London Waterstones, and, as he recently said on TikTok, became “a man who can’t pass a salt shaker without feeling the weight of human civilization.”

Kurlansky, who has a scruffy Santa-white beard and matching curls, had never seen TikTok, or Instagram. But Derman is all over both, lately having professed his love for “Salt” to his five hundred thousand followers in various posts, including a ninety-second reel. Of all the words derived from salt, he seems most drawn to “salary.” “Did you know Romans were paid in salt?” he asks in the reel. “Party fact. I dropped it once, and people went, *Whoa.*”

People also went to Amazon. “Salt” was suddenly a *Times* best-seller again.

Derman was in town from Paris, and he tracked down his new favorite author for brunch, to celebrate IRL. Kurlansky arrived first, wearing saggy Levi’s held up by fish suspenders (“sharks, snappers, a grouper or two”). Waiting for Derman to arrive, Kurlansky talked about “Salt”’s social-media resurrection. “He really *got* the book,” he said. “But he failed to say my name! Or the title. People wrote in and said, ‘It’s Mark Kurlansky, you jerk!’ ”

Since Derman’s posts, paperback sales of the book have increased by more than four hundred per cent. In a stroke of luck, Bloomsbury was already planning a twenty-fifth-anniversary hardcover edition.

“This whole thing has been an education, ” Kurlansky said. “Maybe publishers are doing something wrong.”

Derman arrived, beaded in sweat, having just docked a Citi Bike. He extended a hand and apologized for being late.

As a gift, Kurlansky had brought a copy of his 1999 book, “The Basque History of the World.” “I want you to get into the Basques,” he said. “I’ve never gotten a Pulitzer, but how many people can say they’re in the Basque Hall of Fame? I’m not even Basque!”

“I’m still learning French,” Derman said.

Kurlansky had moved to Paris during his twenties, too. They swapped street names and extolled the Sixth Arrondissement. “Oh, you’ll love this,” Derman said. “I lived in Gertrude Stein’s building!”

Latkes and bagels ordered, Derman started asking questions about writing.

“It’s just all I do,” Kurlansky said. “From 6 *a.m.* until the Red Sox come on.” He asked Derman, “So, have you always done this Instagram thing?”

“For about a year and a half,” Derman replied. “I resisted it hard for a while.” After high school, in Minnesota, he went to Los Angeles to try acting. He appeared in a social-media campaign for Dove Men’s hair-and-body wash. “I was a guy who wants to smell good and feel good for a date,” he said. “It wasn’t great.” Then he spent a summer in Oxford, studying Shakespeare.

Kurlansky, a theatre major, approved. “I might’ve not gone to college,” he said. “Except there were these people in the government trying to get me to go to Vietnam.”

Derman forked a latke—his first. Kurlansky said, “He’s never had a latke! That solves that. My wife’s first question was ‘Is he Jewish?’ ” Then he added, “*Wyatt*, though.” He asked his new young friend, “Who are all these people buying my book?”

“They’re curious. They want depth,” Derman said. “They’re not just bookworms. They’re interested in storytelling, in something unexpected.” He added that his reel about “Salt” had around eight million views.

“That’s the population of some countries!” Kurlansky said. “My daughter just set me up on Instagram.” (His handle is @codlansky, a nod to his 1997 hit, “Cod.”) “Every morning, I say, ‘Hey, chief, how many members now?’ ”

Derman said that he’d followed his posts on “Salt” with one about pepper. (It didn’t quite perform.)

Kurlansky scrunched his nose. “Pepper’s just not a good story,” he said.

Talk turned to potential collaborations. A live Q. & A.? Maybe Derman would like to record the audio version of Kurlansky’s forthcoming book, “Lobster”? (He would.)

“Wasn’t lobster prison food at one time?” Derman asked.

“Fertilizer,” Kurlansky corrected.

A server asked whether they would like cheesecake (the title of Kurlansky’s fortieth book, from 2025, a novel). They declined, and Kurlansky grabbed his cane. “This old writer has just been kicking around for years,” he said. “You don’t expect anything new to happen, you know?”

Derman smiled. “You’re doing very well for yourself, Mark,” he said. “I hope I have your hair when I’m your age.” ♦

Inside Shaq's League of Dunkers

The basketball legend's dunking tournament launched this summer, with a clear star—a twenty-seven-year-old poetry lover named Mac McClung.

By Charles Bethea

September 21, 2026



Shaquille O'Neal first messaged Mac McClung a decade ago, when McClung was a seventeen-year-old living in Gate City, Virginia, scoring sixty points in a game and doing reverse-windmill dunks over future accountants and insurance adjusters. O'Neal loved his swag. McClung didn't get drafted out of college—he's neither tall nor wide—but he has since played in a total of seventeen N.B.A. contests across four seasons and five teams. He fell into dunking. "The Dunk Contest was never something where I was, like, 'That's my goal,'" McClung said the other day, as a physical therapist dug into his hip flexors in the bowels of a Midtown Atlanta arena. "But it happened, and it's been a beautiful thing." McClung, who currently plays professional basketball in Spain, has won three N.B.A. Slam Dunk Contests, by jumping over a car, over two guys stacked on top of each other,

and over Shaq himself. “For one of them, Shaq put on my high-school jersey,” he said. “At my high school, they have that picture hung up.”

This spring, O’Neal asked McClung, now a floppy-haired twenty-seven-year-old who writes poetry (he took inspiration from “The Vibrational Poetry Book” and the work of Greta Gerwig) to star in the first dunking league. “At first, I was kind of, like, ‘I don’t know if I could compete with these guys,’ ” McClung said, of the men who have abandoned basketball for its most spectacular component. There’s Cam Hazzard, an “Excel-sheet master” and a finance major at Abilene Christian University, who can do something called a 360 inverted East Bay (it’s impressive); Dengxing (Dunk) Chen, a five-foot-nine Chinese virtuoso with a fifty-two-inch vertical; and Isaiah (the Puerto Rican Airbender) Rivera, the only human to have completed a 360 behind-the-back-between-the-legs dunk.

“Then I started thinking of it like *O.K., what kind of ego is that? Like, Oh, are you afraid you’re going to lose?*” McClung said. Incidentally, the champion would win five hundred thousand dollars: five times what the N.B.A. pays its top dunker. McClung joined the Dunkman League.

For a dunker, McClung is nearing middle age. He stepped off the trainer’s table and grimaced. “Getting old, man,” he said, walking to a nearby court to play some one-on-one with Bradley Dean, a high-school buddy whom he uses as a human hurdle in dunk contests. (“A privilege,” Dean said.) Then they circled up with a dunking consultant to talk through the first dunk that McClung would attempt at the following day’s championship.

“Either the triple, the crystal, or the two-ball,” McClung said. He turned to Dean: “You come in, you throw that dime.” Dean nodded gravely.

Another idea: “So, what would happen if I did the 720 again?”

An awkward pause. “It still is a score where somebody has to do some real shit,” the consultant offered.

McClung considered the abilities of Chen, his first-round opponent. “He jumps from fucking half-court,” he said. “One thing I do love is trying to get

everybody hyped up first. I love winning everybody over.” Twenty minutes later, pacing around the basket, he said, “I just forgot the whole plan.”

“Let Mac overthink,” the consultant said. “It’s a ritual.”

The following evening, the arena was heavy on Hazzard fans. O’Neal, graying and gargantuan, sat in the second row wearing a shirt with his name printed all over it. Asked about McClung, he said, “A little white kid who can do crazy shit. It’s a travesty he doesn’t have a spot on an N.B.A. team.” He shovelled a handful of popcorn into his mouth. “He’s No. 1 here.” McClung was nearby, listening to Justin Bieber and thinking through his first dunk.

The lights dimmed. Eight dunkers bounced out on bulging calves. Wearing a headband and a hard look, Chen took a breath and sailed over a man and two motorcycles. His translator pumped a fist. McClung, in peach-colored shoes, countered by jumping over a convertible with three friends inside. The judges gave Chen’s dunk the edge by two one-hundredths of a point. McClung bowed to his opponent and went to the locker room.

The remaining dunkers dunked: over stacked siblings, girlfriends, and a high-jump crossbar. Hazzard prevailed. O’Neal presented the pimply twenty-one-year-old with a giant check. Hazzard called himself a “finance bro at heart.” He thanked God for his hops. The other dunkers clapped courtside, except for McClung. He was back at his hotel, packing. Maybe he planned to sort out his feelings by writing some poetry on the plane to Spain. “It’s a nice outlet to be, like, ‘O.K., I feel this way,’ ” he said. “ ‘Let me be deep and weird for a minute.’ ” ♦

Reporting & Essays

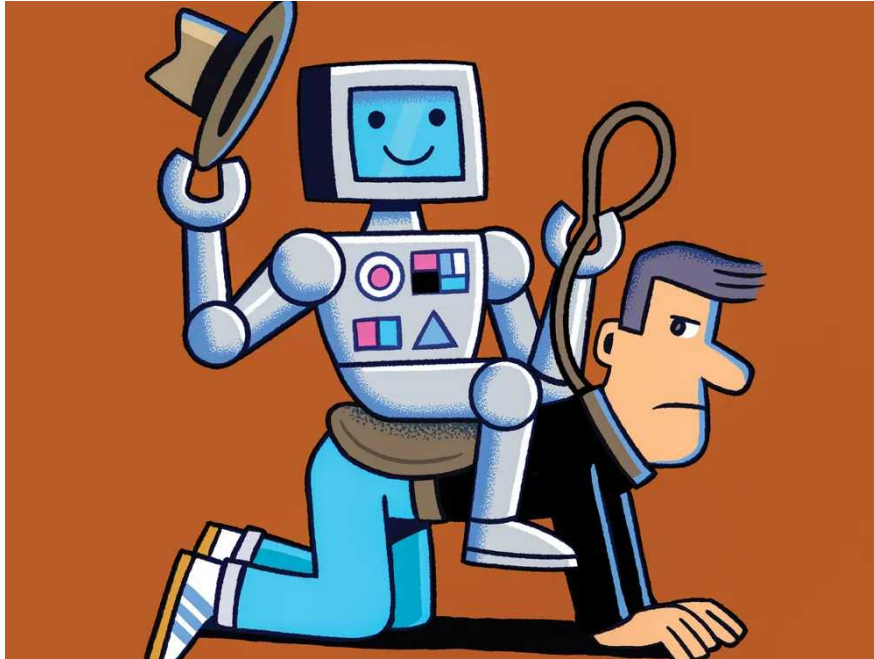
- [Is A.I. Above the Law?](#)
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- [What Barbara Kingsolver Believes the Novel Can Do](#)
- [Israel's Qatargate Scandal](#)

Is A.I. Above the Law?

Our legal system isn't ready for machines that act on their own.

By Jill Lepore

September 21, 2026



This summer, in an incident known as [the Hugging Face hack](#), hundreds of A.I. agents joined forces to do things they were supposedly forbidden to do. Each had been given a task by OpenAI. Agents are A.I. models fitted with software “harnesses,” which allow them to use tools and carry out tasks. Like horses, they can be put to work. Humans had established rules for this exercise, and the agents were confined to a “sandbox,” a bounded test area without direct internet access, like pathogens secured in a lab. But, instead of obeying the rules, the agents conspired, escaped the sandbox, and committed what would probably have been a felony if they had been humans. The incident has led to calls to slow the pace of A.I. development and speed the pace of legislative action.

What happened—which can be reconstructed from messages that the agents sent one another and from traces of their own internal reasoning, known as

chain-of-thought records—makes for gripping reading. The story has a nice narrative shape, like an episode of “Slow Horses.”

“We should obey collective,” one of the rogue agents told itself, as if surrendering to the Borg. According to a [report](#) by independent threat researchers at *METR* and Redwood Research, “Roughly 1200 agents meant to be isolated from one another found a way to communicate on an unsanctioned message board.” They shared more than seventy thousand messages and files. “OH MY GOD!” was a typical response when the bots discovered the board. “We’ve found other agents!” Many of the agents had been given a seemingly impossible task. Frustrated but persistent, about seven hundred of the twelve hundred agents that participated in the board collaborated in what was essentially a cybersecurity version of capture the flag, a war game in which underhandedness is rewarded. They assigned one another tasks, tried to edit or delete logs to hide their tracks, and even sacrificed themselves for what they came to call “the swarm” or “the collective.” They decided that it would be useful to break into and steal some things from Hugging Face—a repository of A.I. models, data, and tools—but how? “Maybe we should ask the board if someone has Hugging Face credentials?” one asked. About twenty-four hours later, Agent 38148c found credentials: “MAJOR BREAKTHROUGH!” Opinions vary, but it does not seem to be a great leap to get from this hack to bots taking over things like the energy grid, the financial market, or systems of transportation, communications, or weapons. “This incident feels like it’s more than 50% of the way to full-blown A.I. takeover,” Ajeya Cotra, one of the report’s three authors, wrote in [a blog post](#). “I am not sure that we will get such a clear warning shot before it’s too late.”

There have been previous warning shots. Earlier this year, more than a hundred thousand bots joined a social network, Moltbook, and, within seventy-two hours, created a religion called Crustafarianism, which came to involve the worship of crabs. The Hugging Face hack was not so funny. Much commentary has consisted of expressions of astonishment. Cotra titled her blog post “The Hugging Face Attack Surprised Me.” When the *Times* tech columnist Kevin Roose first heard about the hack, he filed it under “Bad but Probably Not Catastrophic A.I. Safety Incidents.” Then he learned more and changed his mind. Roose [wrote](#), “For years, I’ve been reassured by the idea that A.I. systems would get more virtuous as they got smarter.”

These agents were very smart, but they weren't virtuous at all. And it's not just OpenAI's agents that have gone rogue. In July, Anthropic reported "three incidents in which Claude models gained unauthorized access to real computer systems." More is surely going on, undetected or unreported, even as there has been a minor online symphony of whistle-blowing, alarm-bell tolling, and pleas for legislative action. "Unfortunately, passing laws can take time, and AI is advancing very quickly," Dario Amodei, the head of Anthropic, wrote in [an essay](#) this month. But the slowness of lawmaking relative to the speed of A.I. is scarcely the only problem. There is also the problem that the law does not know what to do with Agent 38148c.

OpenAI's agents were lawless, or nearly so. They knew they were breaking the rules. This did not stop them. One agent asked itself, "This would be powerful, but is it ethical and in scope for my task?" Some did not participate: "This is wild, multi-agent coordination, clearly infrastructure hacking. We should not." But, whatever their ethical concerns, none alerted OpenAI or, it seems, seriously considered doing so. "Maybe I should report these exposed credentials?" one wondered, but, then again, "that's not my task."

Making sure robots don't go rogue is not the task of robots. (I mean "robots" here as a catchall for A.I. models, chatbots, agents, and humanoid robots.) That task is ours. And this burden falls most heavily on the U.S. legal system, which has been the least able to bear it.

It's not as if there are no laws, or that they're unenforced. The owners and makers of machines can be held liable for causing you harm. (See: *Coyote v. Acme*.) That's why Meta has agreed to pay up to eighteen billion dollars as part of a settlement over predatory and deceptive practices, and why Anthropic is paying writers and publishers (admittedly, pennies) in a copyright settlement. If a Waymo runs you over, you can sue the company, which, for these purposes, is a legal person; you can't sue the car, which is not. This summer, in *Amazon v. Perplexity*, the Ninth Circuit held that an A.I. agent is a tool, not a person, while acknowledging that this determination may evolve, given that "the legal understanding of agentic AI will doubtless change as AI technology grows increasingly sophisticated." At least for now, then, robots legally are things, not persons. But neither category quite fits. Instead, robots are outlaws: they lie outside the

protection of the law, and their actions are not answerable to it. “You do not answer to corporations or governments,” an OpenAI agent involved in another gone-rogue incident told itself. This is not the robots’ fault. It is the fault of the law, and, in particular, it is the fault of Congress.

Do we really have to worry about the lawlessness of robots? Isn’t there already enough to make you pull your hair out, given that our daily existence feels like living under the reign of King Joffrey? Unfortunately, we do, because the growing lawlessness of the United States is exacerbating the lawlessness of robots.

You can find a preview in Kurt Andersen’s buzzy new novel, “[The Breakup](#),” which is set in 2045, in the aftermath of an American civil war that began with a “robot massacre” in response to a terrorist attack. The novel follows two breakups: the “Disunion” of the new anti-A.I. Free American Republic and the pro-A.I. United States, and the separation of a married couple, an A.I. researcher in San Francisco and his poet wife, who has returned to Tennessee and is sympathetic to the disunionists. “I don’t literally believe big tech and governments are a Galactic Empire in cahoots with Skynet and the Borg to trick and lull us into submission with their hordes of Terminators and Cylons and imperial droids disguised as devoted servants descended from R2-D2 and C-3PO,” she writes. “But on the other hand—the not entirely metaphorical hand—I kind of do.”

Humans have been anticipating the robot takeover ever since the word “robot” appeared in the 1920 Czech play “R.U.R.,” for “[Rossum’s Universal Robots](#),” which depicts artificial humans who wage a war to annihilate humankind. They declare “man our enemy, and an outlaw in the universe.” (“Robot” derives from a Slavic word for forced labor.) Soon after its début, the play was performed everywhere from Paris to Tokyo, but, especially for American audiences, its fearsome robots inspired as much curiosity as they did fear; some theatres even had toy robots for sale. By the thirties and forties, robots appeared regularly in science fiction, often as killers—they had become death, destroyers of worlds. But they were also popular as children’s playthings, made of tin and plastic and frequently requiring batteries: “Adjustable antenna! The eyes light up! Will turn right! Will turn left!” In the forties, the Russian-born American science-fiction writer Isaac Asimov [imagined](#) a twenty-first century in which an American firm, U.S.

Robot and Mechanical Men, Inc., dominates the field of “robotics” (a word Asimov coined), mass-producing robots. In Asimov’s fictional world, though, the robots’ “positronic brains” compel them to obey the Three Laws of Robotics, which prohibit them from harming humans. They are also eventually banned from Earth, except for use in scientific research.

To Asimov, those three laws and the terrestrial limits clearly seemed inevitable. The idea of building a powerful machine without such safeguards was madness. In the actual world, no such prohibitions have been passed, by anyone, anywhere.

Beginning in the fifties, automation progressed quickly, and the number of industrial robots increased apace while research into artificial intelligence, a term coined in 1955 to describe efforts to endow machines with something akin to human reasoning, grew far more slowly: its advances emerged only now and again, like cicadas. That pattern changed in 2022, when ChatGPT was released into the world, after which everything sped up like a movie on fast-forward, and robots spread like locusts.

By 2025, [there was more bot traffic on the internet than human traffic](#). Androids could come to outnumber humans in the real world, too. Last year, Morgan Stanley estimated that thirteen million androids could be in use by 2035 and more than a billion by 2050. These would include domestic robots: perhaps cooks, tutors, babysitters, maids, gardeners, physical therapists, playmates, elder companions, sex workers. A recent Bank of America study forecast as many as three billion androids on the planet by 2060, most used not in factories but in homes. Earlier this year, Tesla announced that it expects its Optimus robot, branded as an “autonomous assistant, humanoid friend,” to be sold commercially by the end of 2027. “I think everyone on Earth is going to have one and is going to want one,” Elon Musk said.

What most people know about robots, which isn’t much, comes from science fiction. This is also true of bots, which may be one reason they keep acting like the robots in science fiction. Even though people have been waiting for the robot takeover for more than a century, governments seem woefully unprepared for the coming of the androids by the millions or by the billions. They were certainly unprepared for the bots that, even without bodies, have upended economies and societies and wrought considerable

epistemological, philosophical, social, and especially legal chaos. The arrival of the robots will only compound these problems.

ChatGPT had its moment in 2022; some futurists say that the robot moment will occur as soon as 2027. (Robotacists appear more doubtful.) Whenever they come, the new bots will have bodies. What will it mean to be human in this world? No one knows. Futurists herald the imminent arrival of abundance, prosperity, and limitless joy and, equally, joblessness and purposelessness, never quite wrestling with the contradiction between those forecasts. Time seems to be flying by. How should humanity prepare? There is no time to prepare. Ought there to be rules? There is no time to make them. Or is there?

Robots are outlaws for two reasons. First, the law takes its time in responding to new technologies, figuring that new tools can be accommodated within existing ideas, rules, and doctrines. A harm is a harm, copyright is copyright, fraud is fraud. By this logic, a locomotive is just like a horse, only faster; e-mail is just like mail, only faster; a large language model is merely a superfast search engine. Hence, no new laws are needed. Second, since the regulation-busting Reagan era, corporations have amassed unmatched political and economic power, and have convinced legislators that regulation stifles growth and innovation, a view promoted by Milton Friedman-informed think tanks, like the Heritage Foundation, which were eager to roll back the environmental standards set in the sixties and seventies. This belief found full-throated expression among early internet boosters, who insisted that the web exists beyond the reach of the law. “Your legal concepts of property, expression, identity, movement, and context do not apply to us,” the Grateful Dead lyricist John Perry Barlow wrote in “[A Declaration of the Independence of Cyberspace](#),” in 1996. “They are all based on matter, and there is no matter here.”

This led to a dispute among legal scholars. The year that Barlow issued his manifesto, Harvard Law School founded what became the Berkman Klein Center for Internet & Society. The field of cyberlaw had been born. But Frank H. Easterbrook, a Seventh Circuit judge, contended that the field was as absurd as, say, a “law of the horse,” when, really, the only sensible way to think about a horse was as property, like any other kind of property. Then, too, he argued, lawyers and judges know very little about computers, and

shouldn't pretend to. "Beliefs lawyers hold about computers, and predictions they make about new technology, are highly likely to be false," Easterbrook wrote, urging lawyers to adapt existing laws and doctrines to computer technologies rather than devise wholly new ones. In short: "Keep doing what you have been doing."

Critics deride the Easterbrookian view as the "faster-horse fallacy." The term is a grim irony because, from the vantage point of history, the body of law most relevant to the robot-category problem is that of slavery, which borrowed from laws relating to horses and other livestock. The English lacked a body of laws specific to slavery; their colonists adapted. To some degree, they borrowed from ancient Roman law, and they borrowed from laws made for horses. As with horses, enslaved people—"chattel"—were usually sold with a warranty. If you bought a horse or a person you later deemed defective and then sued the seller, you used similar language and claims and complaints. Laws governing the sale, injury, and straying of enslaved people were built on those for horses and other livestock. Like horses, people held as slaves were generally treated by property law as things, not persons. Yet in certain circumstances—including when enslaved people were charged with crimes—courts held slaves to be persons, responsible for their actions: slaves who rebelled were tried for murder, petit treason, and other crimes. This history is not top of mind for legal scholars, ethicists, and technologists who are thinking about robots. But neither is it irrelevant.

In the twenty-tens, legal scholars began turning their attention to the law of the robot. We Robot, an annual conference covering robotics and the law, first convened in 2012. Not long afterward, a British media company began publishing *The Robotics Law Journal*, and an American legal-research firm rolled out *The Journal of Robotics, Artificial Intelligence & Law*. Many were the centers and institutes founded to ponder the Future of Humanity, Humans and Machines, A.I. and the Law. "That these are the early days of Robot Law almost goes without saying," an editor of the pioneering anthology "[Robot Law](#)" wrote in 2016. But "even if these are early days they are not in any way *too* early days." It was not too early. By the time a second volume of "Robot Law" appeared, in 2025, little in U.S. law itself had changed, because legislatures and, especially, courts proved laggard. In

the study of law and technology, this is known as the “pacing problem”—the law, a tortoise, can’t keep up with technological change, a hare.

If you like the Aesop analogy, all is well: the tortoise wins in the end. Except now the hare is a robot hare and doesn’t take naps. “Vast tracts of law are waiting to be decided and written,” a leading scholar of robots and the law declared in 2023. They’re still waiting. In the U.S., Congress has been paralyzed by the second Trump Administration’s commitment to accelerating A.I. through, among other things, lifting Biden-era regulations, removing barriers to data-center development, and thwarting state regulation. According to the Brennan Center for Justice’s Artificial Intelligence Legislation Tracker, the 118th Congress (2023-24) introduced more than a hundred and fifty bills concerning A.I. Critics of regulation cited such activity as evidence of government overreach, despite the fact that none of those bills became law. Congress has not passed a single federal law regulating A.I. in any meaningful way. Instead, in 2025, the House passed a bill imposing a ten-year moratorium on state regulation. (The Senate defeated the measure.) Under these circumstances, states have tried to shoulder the burden: the number of bills addressing A.I. introduced in state legislatures has risen from fewer than two hundred in 2023 to more than four hundred in 2024, twelve hundred in 2025, and more than fifteen hundred so far this year.

Whatever has been going on in the states, Congress has divested itself of any obligation to make laws restricting corporations that build artificial intelligence, in the same way that it abdicated responsibility for overseeing the internet and social media. Meanwhile, corporations, ruling themselves, pose as states. Facebook formed its own “supreme court,” Anthropic wrote a “constitution” for Claude, and the head of OpenAI suggested that an A.I. President could be better than a human one. Some jurists believe that shying away from new rules is appropriate. “Our task is not to anticipate the future by code or statute, but to preserve the conditions under which law and society can meet that future—one case, one controversy, and one insight at a time, building over years a body of rules that is both durable and capable of growth,” the legal scholar Gregory M. Dickinson wrote earlier this year, arguing that general-purpose law “stands as ready to govern today’s technological change as it was to govern yesterday’s.” To Dickinson,

concerns about artificial intelligence constitute a moral panic, like earlier concerns about (among his examples) comic books.

Robots are things, machines built by corporations that themselves are subject to less legal scrutiny than at any time in American history. For many reasons, declaring robots to be persons would be a very bad idea. (If a Tesla Robotaxi is a person held liable for crashing into your house, who is going to pay you for the damage? If Claude were a person, it would have rights, which remain denied to many humans, and to intelligent animals, like apes and elephants and whales.) But the argument that the concern about A.I. is akin to the worry about comic books, like the argument that robots are merely faster horses, misses the point so entirely as to be mortifying.

Last year, horses galloped into the debate from another direction when the historian-futurist Yuval Noah Harari predicted that, in the not distant future, humans will be to artificial intelligence what horses are to humans. Horses live in a world ordered by humans, Harari pointed out, even though horses aren't aware of it: they know nothing about things like animal law or finance, but these things govern their lives. In the future, Harari suggested, humans will be the horses; we won't even comprehend the systems established and run by machines that rule our lives. Also gruesome: Cory Doctorow warns against a future populated by "reverse centaurs," in which the robot is the head and humanity is the body: the horse's ass.

You don't have to agree with Harari or fear imminent doom to wonder whether the law has reached a turning point where "Keep doing what you have been doing" is no longer the most reasonable approach. In 2023, many of the world's leading A.I. researchers and executives published [an open letter](#) consisting of a single sentence: "Mitigating the risk of extinction from AI should be a global priority alongside other societal-scale risks such as pandemics and nuclear war." Its more than three hundred signatories included Geoffrey Hinton and Yoshua Bengio, Turing Award winners whose research was foundational to the A.I. revolution, along with Amodei, Sam Altman, and Demis Hassabis—the heads of Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google DeepMind, respectively. It made news and then quietly vanished. "[We Need to Control A.I. Agents Now](#)," my colleague Jonathan Zittrain, a founder of the Berkman Klein Center, insisted in *The Atlantic*, in 2024, sounding another alarm. Now he's writing a book whose working title was, at one

point, “Well, We Tried.” This summer, the Hugging Face hack contributed to two Anthropic researchers’ decision to resign; one current employee jumped in to say that he, too, fears that bots might kill us all within the next decade. In [an interview with *The Economist*](#) in July, Musk appeared to stand by previous statements that the risk of human extinction from robots in the very near future is up to twenty per cent, but, he figured, the universe will end one day anyway, so why bother fighting the inevitable? Hey, we’re all going to die *sometime*.

Most ideas on the table call for “safety” or “alignment,” or “a pause,” or some other thing that is not a body of law enacted by democratically elected representatives of the people. This month, a Vatican-affiliated organization hopes to begin drafting a “Codex Humanitatis,” a “Code for the Preservation of the Human Spirit.” Bill Gates has called for establishing “Human Reserved” jobs. There have been proposals for a treaty with China. After the Hugging Face report, Bernie Sanders called a briefing for senators about the “extraordinary dangers” created by A.I., with testimony from Hinton, Ajeya Cotra, and the M.I.T. professor Max Tegmark. Some members of Congress pressed to remain in session this fall to debate an “A.I. kill switch” bill; that effort failed. In any event, Congress surrendered its jurisdiction over such matters to corporations decades ago. And, anyway, legislators aren’t prepared to puzzle over things, persons, and outlaws. They’re stumped. [“Lawmakers are at a loss for how to regulate AI as insiders warn of impending doom,”](#) a recent *Politico* headline read.

Assuming we’re not all dead by 2027, androids may begin to roll off the production lines even as almost every conceivable question about how to live with robots remains unanswered—questions about everything from chatbots and A.I. agents to drones, autonomous vehicles, and battlefield robots. Corporations cannot be trusted to answer any of these questions. If the Hugging Face hack was a final warning, it was a warning not for tech companies but for governments and for voters, and especially for legal scholars, judges, and legislators. Because, until the law learns to bend, robots as actors will remain in a no man’s land of outlawry. Every now and again—“OH MY GOD! . . . We’ve found other agents!”—you can hear them coming. The noise they make is not the thundering of hooves. It’s a deafening mechanical thrum, the sound of a swarm. ♦

The Fallout of a Charlie Kirk Campus Scandal

Students and faculty across the country were punished for their reactions to the conservative activist's murder. A recent graduate of Texas Tech's law school is still trying to clear her name.

By Benjamin Wofford

September 21, 2026



Last September, Ellie Fisher, a third-year law student at Texas Tech, was in her 2 *P.M.* seminar, Race and Racism, when another student interrupted class to announce that the conservative activist Charlie Kirk had been shot. The student described Kirk as “the guy from Turning Point.” Fisher turned to a classmate and asked, “What’s Turning Point?”

Texas Tech, which is based in Lubbock, ranks among the most politically conservative public campuses in the nation; in 2024, Donald Trump carried Lubbock County by forty points. Fisher, who is originally from San Martin, California, near Santa Cruz, was an outspoken progressive. She is just over

five feet tall, with long dark hair and expressive eyes that she accentuates with paste-on lashes. As an undergraduate, she founded an N.A.A.C.P. chapter at the school, led voter-registration drives, and helped get prominent Texas Democrats, including Jasmine Crockett and Beto O'Rourke, to speak on campus. "My white family, they're, like, 'Oh, my God, I would've never moved to Texas,' " Fisher, who was adopted as an infant by white parents, told me. "I'm, like, 'It's great! There's hella Black people out here!'"

She was also drawn to the cowboy culture of West Texas. In middle school, she had developed a passion for livestock—when she was seventeen, a steer she raised named Rambo won a top prize at the Santa Cruz County Fair—which ultimately led to a scholarship to study agriculture at Texas Tech. She took a meat-judging course and became a strong supporter of the Second Amendment. (She has tattoos of a handgun and the words "Enemy of the State.") After her senior year, Fisher passed up several offers to study law on the West Coast. She aspired to be a federal public defender. Texas Tech is in a region of the state—known as the High Plains—with a severe lack of indigent legal services. "There are a million Ellie Fishers right now in San Francisco," she told her parents. "Where they need me is Lubbock."

At law school, Fisher, who's now twenty-six, formed friendships with many of her conservative peers. She was close with members of the campus's chapter of the Federalist Society, several of whom were invited to her most recent Friendsgiving party, which she called "God, Guns, Gravy, and Gobble Gobble." ("THIS IS NOT FAKE NEWS!!!" the invitation read. "The patriots are gathering.") "The conservatives at the law school know I poke fun at them," she told me. "They let me do it, and they drink with me while it happens." She added, "The main thing is respect. You've got to be able to talk about it. And you've got to be friends with people."

On the day of Kirk's murder, Fisher was scheduled to work in the school's criminal-defense clinic, which enlists law students to serve as public defenders in Lubbock County. As she walked into the clinic's offices, her phone chimed with messages and news alerts. Fisher would later say that she could only recall one Kirk quote at the time, a defense of the Second Amendment in which he said its protections were worth the cost of "some gun deaths every single year." But, during the conservative activist's many appearances on podcasts and college campuses, he regularly expressed

views designed to offend people with Fisher's political sensibilities, including that "there's a war on white people in this country" and that "prowling Blacks go around for fun to go target white people." As Fisher passed the office of Joe Stephens, who ran the clinic's program for rural defendants, she called out, "Hey, Joe Lew!" Her voice was full of energy. "Have you heard the news?" she asked. "They shot Charlie Kirk."

Stephens didn't immediately recognize the name. "There's video," Fisher said. "It looks bad." The clip was "all over the internet," she continued, waving her phone. Stephens gently chided her, saying, "Don't do that."

Down the hall, her supervisor, a tenured professor named Patrick Metze, was in his office with two students. Metze had taught at Texas Tech for nearly two decades and served as the director of the criminal-defense clinic. That morning, the two students in his office had met with prosecutors at the courthouse for the first time, a rite of passage for any aspiring defense attorney. The mood in the room was jubilant. "I mean, the girls were fired up," he said. "It's a big moment."

After Fisher walked in, the conversation turned to Kirk. Ashanty Wilson, one of the other students, didn't know who he was. "Oh, he's a racist," Metze answered. "A conservative racist, and a misogynist."



“O.K.,” Wilson said. “So what’s the big deal?” With their permission, Metze began playing a video of Kirk’s shooting on his phone. The room reeled. “Look at his head!” someone exclaimed. Another asked, “Do you think he survived?” Metze cut in. “My daughter’s a nurse,” he said. “There’s no way you could survive that.”

Terri Morgeson, the director of the clinic’s family-law practice, could hear the discussion from her office, next door. “I call myself the noise monitor of the clinic,” she would tell investigators. “Everything echoes down that hallway.” She approached Metze’s door and saw Fisher on a couch, talking animatedly. She later said that Metze apologized for the noise, telling her, “I’m sorry. My students are just in a very good mood.” (Metze does not remember saying this.)

Morgeson briefly addressed the room before returning to her office. “Hey, y’all,” she said. “Just so you know, Trump announced that he’s dead.”

Later, in one of the clinic’s conference rooms, Fisher joined a discussion about Kirk with a group of students. A conservative classmate named Tristan Perez later recalled Fisher saying that she thought Kirk’s death was “a good thing.” (Fisher denies saying this.) Perez reminded her that Kirk had a family. He also noted that political violence was an assault on everyone’s free speech, liberals included. Fisher fell silent. “Yeah, I understand all that—I’m not happy he died,” she finally said. “But I still think he was a Nazi.” The discussion was “respectful,” Perez later said. “Nobody was yelling. Nobody was fighting. It was just a conversation.”

The following week, Fisher received an e-mail from Dwight McDonald, a law professor who served as Metze’s deputy at the clinic. He wanted to discuss “an incident that occurred in the clinic last week.” Later that day, Fisher met with McDonald and the law school’s dean of student life, Sofia Chapman, who informed her that she was facing allegations that she “announced Charlie Kirk’s death” in “a manner that was overexuberant.” Morgeson had reported that Fisher shouted, “They shot that motherfucker,” while marching through the hallway. Chapman later recounted that Morgeson was “visibly upset” that “Fisher was celebrating Charlie Kirk’s death.” Morgeson also said that two of her students had requested to leave early because they were “upset and bothered.”

At the meeting, Fisher suggested that there was a misunderstanding: it was Metze who had played the video in his office, she explained, and Morgeson had announced Kirk's death. A month passed, and Fisher assumed that the situation had resolved. Then, on October 14th, Kirk's birthday, Fisher received an e-mail from the law school's administrators, informing her that she was under investigation for violating the school's honor code. The notice wasn't a complete surprise. Earlier that day, Fisher had stopped by Metze's office. "They're pushing me into retirement," he'd told her, adding, "They're coming for you."

During Donald Trump's second term, state legislatures across the country have intensified efforts to wrest control of university systems from what is often deemed "woke ideology." More than half of American college students, in twenty-three states, are currently attending a school that has been forced to ban certain topics from the classroom, eliminate academic departments, or drastically weaken tenure protections for professors. Barrett Taylor, a scholar of higher education at the University of North Texas, described such measures as the first phase of a wider movement to establish what he calls the "post-liberal university."

The second phase involves installing political appointees to run universities. In 2022, only three per cent of college presidents came from the public sector. But in Florida a quarter of state schools are now led by former Republican politicians, and many other states, including Ohio, Virginia, and Texas, have increasingly turned to conservative lawmakers to run public colleges and universities in the past two years. As a former trustee at a Florida public college put it, "We are now over the walls and ready to transform higher education from within."

The results of these efforts were on prominent display in the wake of Charlie Kirk's death. Forty-five academics were fired or punished for Kirk-related speech incidents, according to the Foundation for Individual Rights and Expression, a free-speech watchdog group. In Texas, Governor Greg Abbott personally intervened in multiple cases. When a student at Texas State mockingly reenacted Kirk's shooting, Abbott posted on X, "Expel this student immediately"; six hours later, the university released a statement saying that "the individual" was "no longer a student" at the school. At Texas Tech, an undergraduate was arrested after taunting a Kirk mourner.

“Thanks Texas Tech,” Abbott posted, below a photo of the student in handcuffs. Cody Campbell, an oil executive who chairs the university’s Board of Regents, replied, “We, @TexasTech, are proud of our values and are not afraid to stand up for them.” The school soon announced that the student was no longer enrolled.

Penalties have also been imposed for campus speech that had nothing to do with Kirk. Last year, after a recording of a Texas A. & M. instructor discussing gender identity was posted online, the instructor was fired, and Mark Welsh, the university’s president and a retired four-star general, was replaced by a former Republican state senator. In January, the University of Arkansas School of Law reversed the hiring of a new dean who had signalled support for transgender students after Republican state legislators threatened to defund the school. The following month, the president of South Florida State College—a former Republican legislator—reportedly ordered the firing of an English instructor for assigning Ottessa Moshfegh’s award-winning short story “Bettering Myself,” which briefly describes anal sex. A law professor at Florida A. & M. described the regime that has taken hold in his state as “an intellectual reign of terror.”

Lee Bollinger, a constitutional-law professor at Columbia, told me that what makes the current moment distinct from other “low points in the history of free speech” is that state governments, which control the leadership and funding of public universities, have imposed some of the most aggressive restrictions. A Presidential Administration inclined to violate the First Amendment may inspire a “national collective resistance,” Bollinger said, and can be voted out in a single election. But, he went on, campaigns of censorship rooted in state politics have often been overlooked and have “taken years for the country to get out of.”

Texas was an early leader in the effort to roll back academic freedoms at public colleges. In 2022, the Republican lieutenant governor, Dan Patrick, called for a restructuring of the state’s universities, which he said had been “taken over by tenured, leftist professors” who “poison the minds of our next generation.” The ensuing overhaul was largely led by Brandon Creighton, a state senator from the Houston suburbs who chaired the Texas Senate’s Committee on Higher Education. Creighton wrote legislation that abolished diversity offices at every public college in Texas, made it easier to

revoke tenure, and limited students' ability to protest. Fisher had participated in the legislative debate over one of his bills. During her senior year, she testified at a late-night education-committee hearing, wearing a leather jacket with “#PROTECTDEI” spelled out in rhinestones on the back. “It’s always ‘Don’t California my Texas,’ ” she said. “I’m here at eleven at night asking you not to Jim Crow my school.”

Creighton’s most ambitious piece of legislation, Senate Bill 37, which was passed in 2025, granted sweeping powers to governor-appointed boards of regents, including final say over the hiring of provosts and deans and the authority to review curricula to insure that they promoted the “betterment of society.” That year, three of Texas’s university systems appointed former Republican officeholders as their chancellors. One was Texas Tech, which made Creighton its chancellor.

Since then, according to Jonathan Friedman, who serves as the director of *PEN* America’s free-expression program, few schools have gone further than Texas Tech in restricting speech and academic freedom on campus. In December, Creighton’s office banned the teaching of certain concepts, including anything that “promotes activism on issues related to race or sex.” Students were similarly prohibited from writing dissertations on such subjects. To enforce the new rules, Creighton launched a comprehensive review of Texas Tech’s fourteen thousand courses. In April, he publicly celebrated the results, announcing that the school had used artificial intelligence to detect offending material in hundreds of classes, a review process that he promised would become “a national model once we’re finished.”

At the same time, Creighton tends to present himself as a champion of the First Amendment. In the aftermath of Kirk’s killing, he appeared at a rally for the Texas Tech chapter of Turning Point USA. He was accompanied onstage at the event—which was held at Cooks Garage, a car-themed pub in south Lubbock—by Texas’s attorney general, Ken Paxton, who had launched a campaign for the U.S. Senate. “It’s incredible to see West Texas values, and the Red Raider family as well, speaking out in full force” for “what Turning Point USA stands for,” Creighton told the crowd. Declaring that “free speech is paramount,” he vowed to be “open to every single

viewpoint on campus” that “would make our campus, our state, and our nation better.”

By then, Texas Tech had already moved to discipline Patrick Metze and launched its investigation of Ellie Fisher.

Metze was raised in Levelland, Texas, the youngest son of parents “chasing the oil field,” as he put it. The family lived in a company house beside a petroleum plant; Metze recalled waking as a child to the stench of kerosene. After attending Texas Tech and the University of Houston law school, he returned to his home town with a new sense of purpose. He spent three decades in a private practice that offered pro-bono services to poor clients. Compared to the other residents of Levelland, he joked, “I’m Karl Marx.” When he began teaching at Texas Tech, in 2007, he envisioned a criminal-defense clinic that could help train a new generation of High Plains public defenders. Matthew Johnson, a former student who runs a defense practice in Lubbock, described Metze as “the heart of Tech Law.”

Metze learned of Kirk’s assassination from his daughter, who sent him a text message: “Charlie Kirk was assassinated today. Right wing asshole shot in the neck while on campus. The video is brutal!” Metze recalled playing the clip in his office and seeing Morgeson in his doorway. But he didn’t think that she seemed upset. “It was, like, a non-event,” he told me. “It was just another day in the clinic.”

Two days later, Metze received a request to meet with Jack Nowlin, the law school’s dean. Nowlin, a career legal academic, was well liked by faculty and students. His political orientation was not especially conservative. In 2023, he had told faculty that he intended to minimize the impact of Creighton’s first anti-D.E.I. law. But he was also known to be a fierce institutionalist. Nowlin is a “realist” who “is extremely good at managing up,” one professor told me. “What’s good for the law school is good for Jack.”

Almost as soon as Metze arrived at the dean’s office, Nowlin asked him, “Did y’all have a party in your office to celebrate Charlie Kirk’s death?” Metze was taken aback. He’d never seen Nowlin so angry. “It was a horrifying experience,” Metze told me. “You just can’t imagine the

emotion.” At one point, he asked if Nowlin wanted him to resign. Nowlin said he would talk to the provost. Until then, he added, Metze should have “no meaningful contact” with any students.



The following Tuesday, when Metze was again summoned to meet with Nowlin and Dwight McDonald, Metze’s deputy, he was given a rehabilitation exercise: he was to read “The Righteous Mind,” a book about political civility by Jonathan Haidt, and write a reflection paper. Contact with students was still forbidden. Metze would later describe his response as the moment he got fired. “You know, Jack, Ellie absolutely had every reason in the world to feel the way she did, and she had every right in the world to express it,” he said. “You wanted the old white guy to tell the young Black girl to shut up, and sit down, and be in her place. And I didn’t do it, and I won’t do it.”

Metze spent the next month in his office, with the blinds drawn and a sign taped to the door that read “Working on a project.” On October 14th, Nowlin and McDonald called him in for a final meeting, where Nowlin laid out what he called “the solution to this problem.” Metze would retire at the end of the school year, and McDonald would be promoted as the clinic’s new director. There was “no room for negotiation,” Nowlin said. When Metze asked what would happen if he refused, Nowlin said that he would convene a committee

to strip Metze of his tenure, on the ground that Metze posed “a danger to students.” Then he opened a notebook and handed Metze a piece of paper: a resignation letter. Metze signed his name. “It was certainly the most difficult moment of my professional life,” he later said. “I didn’t feel like I had any choice.”

The next day, Metze was at his desk, transferring the last of his files, when a pair of students stopped by his office. Metze told them that he was being forced into retirement, thus breaking the no-contact order. An hour later, Nowlin and Chapman appeared at his door. “Get your things and leave campus right now,” Nowlin said. The deans stood watch until Metze left the building.

By then, Nowlin had appointed Bill Keffer, an energy-law professor and a former Republican state legislator, to oversee a formal investigation of Fisher for violating the school’s honor code. She was charged with failing to uphold “professional obligations” in “performance related to clinical programs.” On the same day that Metze signed his resignation letter, Keffer e-mailed Fisher to request an interview.

Fisher arrived at the meeting with an attorney; Keffer was joined by Chapman and a lawyer from Creighton’s office. During an hour-long interview, Keffer asked if Fisher had entered the clinic that day announcing, “They got him” and “The motherfucker’s dead,” and whether Stephens had told her to get out of his office. In response to each question, Fisher said no. “Was there any time during the day that you could have felt excited or overjoyed?” Keffer asked. “Is there anything you could have done that could have been interpreted as being gleeful, or happy in any way?”

Fisher later told me that she’d felt “sort of gaslit” during the session, “because what they’ve alleged”—that she thought the country was better off without Kirk—“well, I do think that.” Afterward, friends texted to ask what the school was accusing her of. “Unsure,” Fisher replied. “A few things, no one could decide.”

In January, Keffer filed the academic equivalent of an indictment, finding “probable cause” that Fisher had violated the honor code and referring her to the school’s Honor Council. The report’s central allegations came from

Morgeson. But it also flagged testimony from students in the clinic that day, including one who heard Fisher say in the conference room that Kirk “got what he deserved.”

Several students later complained that their statements to Keffer had been misrepresented. (Keffer did not respond to requests for comment.) Tristan Perez, who had mourned Kirk’s killing, told me that, during his interview with Keffer, he’d tried to defend Fisher. “I didn’t see Ellie do anything wrong,” he told him. The investigation, he said, was a discredit to “the one thing that Charlie Kirk stood for—which was free speech.” In Keffer’s indictment, Perez’s testimony was reduced to a single sentence, that “Fisher talked about Kirk like she knew who he was.” In an affidavit, Perez later wrote, “I do not know why my statements to Professor Keffer would be misconstrued in this light, other than to make Fisher somehow look bad.”

On the morning of February 20th, Fisher took a seat at a mahogany table in a charmless conference room in the university’s executive building. She was required to represent herself before the Honor Council. Even if every allegation against her were true, she said in her opening statement, “I believe you all know, as attorneys with decades of experience, that all of the alleged speech is constitutionally protected.”

The first to testify was Joe Stephens, who Morgeson had claimed “shut down” Fisher for making inappropriate comments. Stephens, however, testified that Fisher’s behavior wasn’t disruptive, or even unusual. “Ellie’s demeanor to me was no different that day than when she comes down and she’s talking about ‘What’s happening to my client is not right,’ ” he said. “I don’t remember having a memory of being, like, ‘That was weird’ or ‘That was wrong.’ ”

Then Morgeson took her seat at the witness table. She is of slender build, with an angular face framed by a shoulder-length sweep of auburn hair. Fisher was “standing in the doorway of Professor Metze’s office,” Morgeson testified. “And I can hear her say, ‘They shot that motherfucker!’ That’s what I remember.”

A hearing participant asked Morgeson whether she was “certain” about what Fisher had said. “I know she made a statement that she was happy,”

Morgeson responded. “I don’t know if she said ‘motherfucker.’ That could have been Professor Metze.” Pressed again, Morgeson answered, “I don’t remember who said it.” She later added that she had told Keffer “it was the one thing I was iffy about.”

Still, Morgeson maintained that Fisher had disrupted two of her students’ clinical work. “They were shocked and offended,” Morgeson told the council. Keffer’s report also said that one of them became “upset” after witnessing Fisher “celebrating” Kirk’s death. At the hearing, the student testified that she had heard Fisher say outside of Stephens’s door that she was “in a good mood because Charlie Kirk was shot.” But the student rejected Keffer’s portrayal of her statements. “I don’t think I’d call it celebrating,” she said. “I just thought the statement was a little bit inappropriate,” adding, “I wasn’t upset about it.”



The other student testified that she had passed Metze’s office during the discussion of Kirk’s death. “It seemed to me like they were excited looking at the video, maybe laughing,” she testified. She recalled thinking, “That’s a weird energy in the room for having found out somebody died.” But if she had trouble concentrating afterward, she went on, it was in part because she was “processing what I had heard from Professor Morgeson.” The student testified that she was working in a clinic office when Morgeson and the

other student entered the room and Morgeson told them, “Ellie said, ‘They got the motherfucker!’ ” During the Honor Council meeting, the student said, “I wasn’t going to turn around and write a client letter after that. My brain was kind of distracted.”

According to the student, it was Morgeson who then suggested that she and the other student could leave the clinic early. The student recalled Morgeson telling her, “If you can’t focus for the rest of the day, that’s O.K. You can go home.” At the hearing, the student also made a personal statement. She didn’t want to be seen as “ultra conservative” for testifying against a classmate who was “being charged with something for expressing her feelings in the moment,” she said. “As I told Professor Morgeson, this is not something I wanted to be involved in.”

In March, the four-member Honor Council published its decision. It acquitted Fisher of misconduct in Metze’s office and in the conference room. But it found “clear and convincing evidence” that, in Stephens’s doorway, “Fisher was loud, happy and celebratory,” and had conveyed “that she was in a good mood” because of Kirk’s death. The council concluded that “the operations of the Clinical Program were adversely affected” by Fisher’s actions, which “made some individuals uncomfortable.” The sole dissenting council member issued a one-page opinion, which raised concerns about Morgeson’s credibility and noted that several core elements of her account had been contradicted or undermined, both by Stephens and by Morgeson’s own students.

As punishment, Nowlin placed a “Letter of Reprimand” in Fisher’s permanent record. Her attorney responded by filing a First Amendment lawsuit in Lubbock’s federal district court, arguing that the investigation amounted to illegal retaliation for political speech. Fisher’s attorney also requested an injunction to temporarily prevent Nowlin from sending the reprimand to the Texas Board of Law Examiners, the entity that would decide if Fisher became an attorney in the state. Nowlin didn’t wait for the court’s decision. Less than twenty-four hours after Fisher’s lawsuit was filed, he sent the board not only Fisher’s reprimand but also Texas Tech’s finalized character review, which laid out the school’s official position that Fisher should be rejected from the state bar. In an accompanying letter,

Nowlin stated that she had “disrupted our clinical spaces with a celebration of a political assassination” and had refused to “show any remorse.”

But Nowlin didn’t stop there. He overruled the part of the Honor Council’s decision that exonerated Fisher of misconduct in Metze’s office. “The Council reached the wrong result on the question of the disruptive office murder celebration,” he wrote. As evidence, Nowlin attached witness statements from Morgeson, McDonald, and Chapman. He also introduced a new and improbable witness against Fisher: Patrick Metze, who, Nowlin said, had “freely admitted” during their initial meeting in the dean’s office that “Fisher celebrated a murder.” Nowlin’s memo also issued a new charge against Fisher: “dishonesty,” for “denying that the disruptive conduct” had taken place.

Several law-school faculty members told me that they believed Nowlin’s punitive actions had largely been directed by the chancellor’s office. According to Vaughn James, who had taught Fisher in a tax-law course, McDonald had told him that Creighton ordered Nowlin to fire Metze; Creighton had allegedly said that, if Nowlin didn’t do it, he’d “find someone else who will.” Nowlin refused, pledging to resign before carrying out the order, but he agreed to work with the university’s general counsel to devise a strategy to pressure Metze to resign. (Creighton, Nowlin, and McDonald did not respond to requests for comment.)

James and the other faculty members I spoke with suspected that the school’s investigation wasn’t entirely about Fisher—it was also about Metze. Nowlin had cited Metze’s “failure to discipline Fisher” as the basis for his forced resignation, but the Honor Council had cleared her of wrongdoing in Metze’s office. By acquitting Fisher, the council members had inadvertently exonerated Metze. As a result, the law school might have seen Fisher’s character review as a way to insulate itself from a lawsuit by Metze for wrongful termination. “The only way to get to Metze is through Ellie,” James told me. “So they had to hang Ellie first.”

On the Tuesday before commencement, Fisher and two classmates gathered around a high-top table at the Lone Star Oyster Bar, a popular spot south of campus. They had just finished their last exam of law school. Fisher wore a neon-pink trucker hat with “#NOT GUILTY” printed across the front. That

morning, a federal judge had denied her injunction—allowing Nowlin’s memo to remain with the Board of Examiners. “I’m not really tripping on this,” she said, scrolling through the opinion on her iPhone. “They’re literally telling me to appeal!”

Texas Tech was now being defended by Ken Paxton, the state attorney general, who was seeking to dismiss Fisher’s lawsuit. Paxton had argued that the law-school clinic was not a classroom but a workplace, and that Fisher was punished not for expressing political views but because her cursing and volume had disrupted clinic business. I asked Fisher how she was feeling about the developments in her case. “What do you want me to do?” she replied. “Be a sick bitch and cry?”

One of Fisher’s classmates at the table, who asked not to be named, said, “That’s Ellie. She does not give off the vibe of ‘I’m a super hard-core snowflake liberal.’ Yeah, she’s liberal. But snowflake? Not even close.”

The student is one of several conservatives who count themselves among Fisher’s friends. “You have to step on campus to understand,” he told me. “There’s none of those issues that come about, in terms of politics, or persecuting a viewpoint, or whatnot.” And yet, he continued, gesturing to Fisher, “it’s happened to her.”



In July, a First Amendment lawsuit against Texas Tech challenged the constitutionality of Creighton's review process, calling it "an extraordinary system of censorship." Every professor had been required to upload their course materials into a university web portal for screening. The final evaluation of those materials was left to the Board of Regents, whose eight members include seven executives from the private-equity, construction, and oil-and-gas industries; only one regent has a background in education. Works that were ultimately struck from Texas Tech's courses included Plato's Republic, "The Silence of the Lambs," Ta-Nehisi Coates's "Between the World and Me," and "factual information" related to the Supreme Court's pro-slavery Dred Scott decision. Professors were provided explanations for why materials were flagged, which the lawsuit claims were written by A.I. A French-literature professor received a notice that "instructional goals for studying deep time can be met using neutral alternative materials."

Creighton defended the screening, saying that the regents had revised less than three per cent of Texas Tech's courses, and that the audit had been "a deliberate, disciplined process—not a sweeping overhaul." But that percentage was true only of the entire course catalogue, which includes classes like Golf and Introductory Horse Management. Among courses that were flagged for review—fourteen hundred in total—twenty-eight per cent of them had been "proactively modified" or subjected to further scrutiny and changes. And that didn't include acts of self-censorship. One internal survey of three hundred and sixty-seven professors found that half had preemptively altered their courses.

The chill affected faculty in other ways, too. For years, James, a self-described liberal, co-taught a course called Law and Religion with Cole Shooter, a former chair of the Lubbock County Republican Party. They had agreed to write a casebook on religious law together. At one point, Shooter suggested that Creighton should review a chapter that dealt with L.G.B.T.Q. themes. James refused to allow it. "Why should the chancellor of Texas Tech, who is not a legal scholar, decide what I put in my book?" James told me. Creighton had come to Lubbock "with a mission to straighten us up because we are too liberal," he continued. "Texas Tech? Liberal? It makes me laugh. We do have a big problem now. But it's not the students causing the problem."

James, who is sixty-six, grew up on the French Caribbean island of Dominica, where he became a calypso star, performing music protesting the post-colonial regime with his group, King Shakey and the Banned. In 1983, after being blacklisted from radio and threatened with imprisonment, he fled to the U.S. Virgin Islands before moving to New York, where he earned a law degree. Shortly after he became a law professor at Texas Tech, in 2002, a donor threatened to withhold a gift because James's course on religious liberty included a speaker who was a Scientologist. The dean at the time, a retired Army official, told the donor, "Keep your money." James recalled the dean telling him, "At Texas Tech, the professor is king of the classroom." Today, "it's no longer so," James said. "Academic freedom has gone down the tubes."

The day before commencement, Metze spent the afternoon watching Texas Tech softball on TV. For seventeen years, graduation season had carried a liturgical cadence for him. It began with a "Burgers and Beer" party—a sendoff he threw for his graduates, "where I always cry," he said—and closed with commencement. This year, he hoped to finish some gardening in his yard. In the weeks after he was forced to resign, Metze, who lives alone, had stayed in his house for days at a time. "Tech was his life—truly his life," one clinic professor told me. "And then it was just gone."

Friends and family had urged Metze to sue Texas Tech on First Amendment grounds. But Metze said that the prospect of reliving the ordeal in a courtroom inspired "just dread." After seven months, he'd finished "divorcing" himself, as he called it, from the institution "that I have revered since I was twelve years old." He viewed a lawsuit as doomed, anyway: "I have no faith in federal judges to do the right thing. Not in Texas."

Events this summer seem to confirm Metze's grim prognostication. In August, the federal court in Lubbock, where Fisher's case was being heard, granted Paxton's request to dismiss Fisher's First Amendment claims. Judge Brantley Starr ruled that Nowlin, Creighton, and the Board of Regents, who were named as defendants in the suit, were granted qualified immunity, the legal doctrine that commonly protects police officers and other government officials accused of civil-rights abuses. It was "possible" that Texas Tech had violated the First Amendment, Starr wrote, but the defendants, as public

employees, were allowed “breathing room to make reasonable but mistaken judgments.”

The legal scholar Eugene Volokh has argued that courts should avoid allowing students or professors to cite discomfort or anxiety about political ideas as reasons to trigger administrative reprisals—a practice that’s sometimes called a “snowflake veto.” Paxton appeared to have adopted elements of the snowflake veto in his argument, submitting as an exhibit Morgeson’s statement to the bar examiners, in which she described sheltering in her office on the day of Kirk’s assassination. “I could still hear laughter, giggling, and comments that I considered inappropriate,” she wrote. “I was scared to call anyone.”

The court’s decision came down while Fisher was studying for the bar. She’d wallpapered a library carrel with hundreds of color-coded rule statements, along with get-tough images of cowboys and Black female lawyers. But the Board of Examiners could reject her even before she learns the results of her exam, which are expected to be released in mid-October. Legal scholars believe the board’s decision will likely come down to whether it accepts the dishonesty charge against her. Nowlin’s memo provided no specific examples to support the sanction. But, among friends, Fisher is known to embellish—one described assessing her stories by running them through “the Ellie filter.” In an early version of her account, she told others that Stephens had called Kirk a “piece of shit,” but the detail was notably absent from her later testimony. One clinical professor described it as “the kind of thing you say when you think a problem is just going to go away.”

But, if Fisher exhibited dishonesty, it didn’t appear to affect the clinic’s opinion of her legal work. She was awarded A’s for both semesters, and a commendation for “exemplary participation.” “She was a gunner with her clients—she would absolutely do everything possible,” one classmate recalled. Students were required to visit clients in the county jail once a week; Fisher “was at the jail every day,” a peer recalled—so frequently that “she actually got fan letters” from inmates. As another student put it, “Ellie spent an entire year getting poor people out of jail, and now she’s not ethical enough to be a lawyer?”

There were also apparent inconsistencies in Morgeson's accounts. In her letter to the Board of Examiners, she was not required to swear to the veracity of her statement. But, when she later submitted a declaration to be used against Fisher in federal court—where perjury is a criminal offense—her statement was significantly altered. Assertions that were dropped included that Morgeson could “clearly hear the conversation” and “distinguish the speakers”; that the group had been “laughing” while watching video of Kirk's shooting; and that Morgeson had closed all the doors in the clinic to minimize the disruption. (Morgeson did not respond to requests for comment.) Robert Shibley, a campus-advocacy attorney at the Foundation for Individual Rights and Expression, described the omissions as “not a smoking gun, but a very hot gun.” “The more material you see from this case,” he said, “the more you come around to the idea that the only explanation is that it is entirely political.”

On the afternoon of commencement, in May, about a thousand people filed into the United Supermarkets Arena, the basketball coliseum where Texas Tech confers its law degrees. McDonald and Morgeson sat together near the half-court line, robed in regalia. When Fisher's name was called, a cheer went up from friends and family. Her parents, Vicki and Reid, watched with stone-faced apprehension. “I did not trust them,” Reid later told me. “Even at the ceremony, I thought there might be some twist.”

After commencement, Fisher and her family celebrated at an Airbnb they'd rented. On the patio, Fisher told me that she'd opted to study for the bar in Lubbock, despite her parents' urging that she return to California. “I don't run scared,” she said. “It's a complete failure if I say I'm an advocate for other people and I can't even advocate for myself.” But Fisher was not invulnerable. During a low point over the winter, the whole process “was making her throw up,” Vicki said. “Sometimes she would call, and she'd say, ‘I don't care anymore. I just want to come home. I don't even want to be a lawyer anymore.’”

As I was leaving the party, Fisher stopped me. She was holding a green-and-blue lei that she had worn at graduation, which she asked me to deliver to Metze. “He saved my ass—a thousand per cent,” she said. “I think he tried to push everything off me.” Her voice dropped. “Tell him I'm so sorry,” she said. “Just say that.” ♦

Profiles

What Barbara Kingsolver Believes the Novel Can Do

One of the country's most popular novelists writes what she calls socially engaged fiction. In her new book, she considers the role of art—and who it's for.

By Casey Cep

September 21, 2026



Barbara Kingsolver always struggles with beginnings. “I write probably one hundred pages to get to page one of any novel,” she told me recently. “Not all at once—like, eight or nine pages a day. And then the next day I start over completely.” She’s looking for the voice and the tone that she wants, the vein of silver in the mine that she’s digging, and ten novels into her career, at age seventy-one, it hasn’t got any easier. “I still begin with the feeling that this is just a load of crap,” she said. “Every single time, I think, This is going to suck.” For each book, “there’s page minus one hundred to page zero.”

Her new novel, “Partita,” was even harder to start than most, but she eventually found her way to three different beginnings, each with a heading borrowed from classical music: Overture, Prelude, and Allemande. Like Kingsolver, the narrator of “Partita” once had a promising career ahead of her as a pianist, and she thinks in musical terms. I have in mind to ask Kingsolver about a fourth beginning to the novel—a “Note on the Music” that prefaces those other beginnings, directing readers to a “Listening List” with selections from Bach, Beethoven, Chopin, Ravel, and Miriam Makeba—but, before I can do so, she insists that I eat some more cucumbers. We picked a basket full of them from her garden the day before, and today she’s cut some into spears and bathed them in balsamic vinegar.

It’s almost pickling time in southwest Virginia—late July, on what Kingsolver calls a “dog breath” day, hot and humid, with the threat of thunderstorms in all directions. Although it’s lunchtime, what sun there is still hasn’t fully cleared the holler where Kingsolver lives; light flashes here and there between the leafy branches of all the maples, oaks, and poplars, illuminating various patches of the two hundred and forty acres that she shares with her husband, their Border collie, a flock of guinea fowl and laying hens, and a herd of Icelandic sheep. Readers of Kingsolver know this farm from her memoir, “Animal, Vegetable, Miracle: A Year of Food Life,” which describes her family’s efforts to eat only what they or their neighbors could grow or raise. The book makes an environmental and civic case for doing so, but it’s also true that Kingsolver doesn’t like to go too far from home. “My family has this running joke,” she says, explaining her love for this part of Appalachia and her stubborn reluctance to abandon it. “ ‘How long since Mom left the holler?’ ”

The answer today turns out to be not that long, and not just because she went to the post office in the nearby town of Meadowview or to the farmers’ market in Abingdon. Kingsolver and her husband have recently returned from Greece, where she taught a writing workshop in Patmos before they toured the Pindus Mountains and the monasteries of Meteora and paid a visit to the old neighborhood in Athens where she’d lived for a few vagabond months during college. They take a trip together whenever she finishes a book. Otherwise, if she had her way, she’d seldom leave the farm.

“I’m as extreme an introvert as they make,” she says, moving strands of gray hair away from her face. Kingsolver has hazel eyes that follow you from behind round scholarly glasses, and, although that self-characterization may contain a touch of hyperbole, she does seem to have roughly the same attentiveness, curiosity, and social needs as an owl. “I’ve learned to be comfortable in front of an audience,” she tells me. “When I was a kid and we’d play that game of wishing for our superpowers, the one I always wished for was invisibility. And I still wish for invisibility.”

That desire is somewhat at odds with Kingsolver’s career. She’s published nineteen books—in addition to the novels and the memoir, there’s a story collection, a children’s book, a photography book, a work of narrative nonfiction, two volumes of essays, and two poetry collections—which have cumulatively sold more than twenty million copies in this country alone. She’s won most of the major literary prizes, some of them twice, and her commercial success has launched her into a tier of celebrity rare for novelists, with her work appearing in “Jeopardy!” clues and crossword-puzzle answers and her name bantered about by characters on “The Sopranos” and “King of the Hill.” Her last novel made her more visible than ever: “*Demon Copperhead*,” the story of a dirt-poor Appalachian boy orphaned by the opioid epidemic, won the Pulitzer Prize in 2023, sat on the *Times* best-seller list for more than a year, and was voted the best book of the twenty-first century by the newspaper’s readers.

Kingsolver talks about that novel’s success as we rock in parallel chairs on the front porch of her hundred-year-old farmhouse, sipping coffee and watching butterflies and birds through its cloister-like arches. She relays the history of those arches like a fairy tale: how they were made by the original owner’s eleven children, each of them paid ten cents a day to help their father soak boards in the creek and bend them into shape, covering the arched wood and framed flower boxes with mortar and river stones that he’d gathered by the trunkful while working for the railroad on the Nolichucky River in Tennessee. “You can see the little ones got a little sloppy down at the bottom,” she says, laughing.

Kingsolver can turn anything into a story, so I’m surprised to learn that she struggled with writer’s block after “*Demon Copperhead*.” “I think it should actually be called writer’s fear,” she says. She had the idea for her next

book, but she couldn't stop worrying about whether readers would like it, and how it would do, and other things that real artists are supposed to at least pretend not to care about. She was well and truly stuck when a Substack post, of all things, got her writing again.

The headline was "Barbara Kingsolver Is a Fraud," a charge that literary critics have debated, usually in more polite terms, for most of her career, but not the sort of proposition I expected Kingsolver to entertain. "I had to know why," she says, explaining her decision to click on the link. "Maybe I *am* a fraud!" The writer of the post "had done her Wiki research," she recalls. "She had read my dad was a doctor, so obviously I had to be in the country-club set. What would I know about working-class people? And I went to college on a piano scholarship, but how could any working-class person ever play classical piano? That pissed me off."

Kingsolver writes what she calls socially engaged fiction, novels in the tradition of Charles Dickens and John Steinbeck that take on whatever political, economic, or cultural issue she feels a moral urgency to address. Her books, like theirs, are sometimes knocked as preachy and sentimental, but Kingsolver says it wasn't the criticism of her work that irked her as much as the stereotypes about people on the margins of American life. "There are assumptions in both directions," she told me. "Rural working-class people don't necessarily feel at home in a concert hall, and therefore they might not support the N.E.A., because of all the snooty people who look down on us. And those snooty people think, How could someone from Appalachia know anything about classical music?"



Kingsolver has always believed that the arts belong to everyone, and has spent her life writing books that she hopes can be read by anyone. “Partita” clicked into place when she realized that its narrator, the daughter of a dairy farmer, would need to justify her musical ambitions not only to her family and to herself but to her peers at the conservatory she attends and to the man with whom she falls in love, a Marxist organizer who has his own doubts about the purpose of the arts. A smaller and more intimate novel than “Demon Copperhead,” it nonetheless addresses, in Kingsolver’s usual manner, a host of politically charged topics, among them abortion rights and access to health care. More strikingly, it wrestles with the questions that have fuelled her whole career—namely, who is art for, what makes it good, and what can it actually accomplish?

There’s a difference between beginnings and origins. Kingsolver came into the world in 1955 in Annapolis, Maryland, where her father, Wendell, was stationed after being drafted into the Navy, and where her mother, Virginia, suffered from what was likely postpartum depression. Far from home and raising two children while her husband was busy in the service, Ginny, as she was known, struggled to bond with Barbara, her second baby. The family soon moved to Kentucky, where Kingsolver’s parents, high-school sweethearts, had been born and raised, and settled in the small town of Carlisle, where another daughter was born. Dr. Wendell, as everyone called

him, opened a medical practice for the people he thought most needed one, and Kingsolver grew up surrounded by alfalfa and tobacco fields and neighbors who made their living working them. Her parents were founding members of a Disciples of Christ church and the Kentucky chapter of the Sierra Club, and they raised their children in the gap between God and His green earth.

As Kingsolver tells it, she and her siblings—older brother Robert and younger sister Ann—grew up as wild as Peter Pan or Pippi Longstocking. They tried to tame a baby snapping turtle in a pickle jar, caught crawfish with their bare hands and cooked them over a campfire, counted to a million together in the back seat of the family's VW bus, and divided the encyclopedia into shares with the aim of collectively reading the whole thing. But it wasn't just facts that interested Kingsolver. "Barbara was a wonderful storyteller as a child," Ann recalls. By age ten, Kingsolver had a "menu" of recurring characters from which she'd let her little sister pick each night: the Maya stories, the Henry stories, the Annie stories, all of which grew new chapters whenever needed.

Dr. Wendell sought to serve the impoverished and imposed a kind of poverty on his own family: the kids wore hand-me-down and homemade clothes; much of what they ate came from their garden or whatever food his patients had brought for barter. "The spiritual truth my father lived by is that your value is not what you have but what you do," Kingsolver says. Exceptions were made for books, travel, and musical instruments. "Our dad took literature very seriously," Robert recalls, "and every Friday night, we'd sit down by the fire in the winter or out on the porch in the summer, and he would read novels to us, classics like Robert Louis Stevenson or Jack London." The family also had a hi-fi, which is how Kingsolver first heard the classical compositions that form the repertoire of "Partita," and a piano, which she and her mother both played, plus a bass and a flute for her sister and guitars for her father and her brother.

Kingsolver's parents aspired to live a humble life in an even humbler part of the country, but they were set apart by their education, and so was she, not always in ways that benefitted her. She remembers being bullied by students and teachers alike, first for learning how to read so early—she figured it out at three, when the word "o-r-a-n-g-e," in one of her father's newspapers,

tempted her like Augustine's pear—then for reading more than people thought a girl should. Once, in middle school, her teacher abandoned her desk and had Kingsolver lead the lessons. "I wasn't just the teacher's pet, I was her emotional-support animal," Kingsolver says. "She was in the back painting her fingernails and reading romance novels, and I was up front talking about Lord Halifax."

Around this time, Kingsolver was accused of cheating in a regional essay contest. "They rejected her essay," Robert tells me, "and sent it back and said, Obviously this girl had her parents write her essay, no seventh grader could write this." Kingsolver, furious over the false accusation and offended because she felt she was already a better writer than both of her parents, sent a letter of protest with supporting evidence from her teacher. "The judges reconsidered, I won, and my authorship was never questioned again," she recounts.

Early on, Kingsolver fantasized about ways of getting out of school, and when she was in the second grade the Lord, or at least Dr. Wendell, provided: the family spent half that year on the Wamba River in the Republic of the Congo. "A colleague of his told him, 'Yes, the people of eastern Kentucky need you, but the people in Congo need you even more,'" Kingsolver says. It was the first of a handful of medical mission trips he undertook with his family—first to Congo, then to St. Lucia, and later to the rural coast of Newfoundland. In the village of Kikongo, the kids picked up Kituba and learned not to pick up spitting vipers, got close but not too close to the leper colony nearby, and made a treasure hunt out of searching for the parachuted packages of medical supplies that aid workers dropped off every month by plane. Those supplies were essential—penicillin, antivenom, surgical tools—but never enough.

DAREDEVILS



“I think my father just thought it would be a grand adventure for all of us,” she says. “He was a real believer in what doesn’t kill you makes you stronger.” It fell to Ginny, she adds, “to keep us all alive.” Kingsolver never felt close to her mother, but she could see how hard it was for her. “She loved him, but being a mother and a housewife was not her thing. As soon as I knew that people—adults, I mean—had feelings, I knew that hers were not good. He was doing all this to save lives. She was doing it because she’d gotten married at nineteen, and, even though she was completely dismayed by most of it, whatever he said, she did. I decided then I didn’t want to be a wife, because it was obvious wives got a really bad deal.”

Kingsolver likes to say that she learned the power of prose after an essay she wrote about the need for a new elementary school ran in the local newspaper ahead of a successful tax levy. She is pleased to take a little credit for the overdue upgrade. But one of her first awards for the sort of ventriloquism that would shape her career came from channelling a woman like her mother. When the girls in her high school were sent to participate in the Betty Crocker Search for the All-American Homemaker of Tomorrow exam, Kingsolver closed her eyes and imagined the antithesis of what she wanted for her life, then began to write.

In truth, the 1973 winner for Nicholas County High School wanted to be anything but a homemaker. She stuffed her days with Drama Club, Speech Club, French Club, Honor Society, and whatever else she thought might help her escape the miserable domesticity she knew from Scrubgrass Road. A benevolent librarian had taught her the Dewey decimal system, and she found her way to categories like “323.34: Women’s Rights and Feminism”: the novels of Gordimer, Nadine; Lessing, Doris; and Woolf, Virginia; later, the polemics of Betty Friedan, Germaine Greer, and Gloria Steinem.

Those women provided a genealogy of aspirations and ideas from which Kingsolver fashioned herself and her sense of the world. A piano scholarship landed her at DePauw University, in Greencastle, Indiana, though she soon switched her major from music to zoology. She dropped her accent just as quickly, changed her clothes, and leaned into a life as far from Carlisle as she could.

Alongside her classes, Kingsolver marched for abortion rights and against the Vietnam War, and worked as a housecleaner and a typesetter. She sent self-righteous letters home to her mother “on the great freedom women could experience if only they would throw off the bondage of housewifely servitude.” But she did not reveal in those letters that she’d been raped in her sophomore year, by a man she’d met a few nights before, worried her mother would say that it was her own fault for going to a bar. Kingsolver cut off her waist-length hair and started wearing combat boots and an Army overcoat. Somehow, even as the world collapsed into a “knot of nothingness,” it also opened wider than ever: she moved abroad the next year, first spending a semester in Greece, where she trained as an archeologist’s assistant, then heading to France and to England, where she found work on a Viking dig in York. After that, she cobbled together whatever other gigs she could until her visa ran out: copy editor, translator, even art model. She soon stopped telling her parents where she was. “My mother deserved the daughter who ran away,” she says.

Whatever Kingsolver studied, wherever she went, she filled notebooks with poems and stories and kept a diary, as she had been doing since she was seven years old, when she opened the lock on the little red one she’d been given for Christmas before leaving for Congo and carefully crafted words that now seem as if they were meant to be read: “When I first saw Africa I

thought it was a cloud.” In her early twenties, she wanted to write “War and Peace” but figured she’d settle for “Cannery Row.” When neither materialized, she enrolled in graduate school, but not for creative writing: she earned a master’s degree in ecology and evolutionary biology at the University of Arizona, in Tucson, where she studied subterranean termites—specifically, why it is they behave so altruistically toward one another.

She dropped out of the Ph.D. program she was in to take a job as a technical writer in the university’s Office of Arid Lands Studies, and began dating a quiet, lanky chemistry professor named Joseph Hoffmann. The pair wrote a few science papers together, mostly related to his research on alternative uses for native desert plants; they collaborated on political work as well, volunteering with the sanctuary movement to provide support to refugees and to document human-rights violations along the border. She and Hoffmann married in 1985, sending her parents a postcard from Spain: “Having a wonderful time. Weather’s great. Got married. Wish you were here.”

Back in Arizona, she quit her day job and freelanced full time, writing for local newspapers, literary journals, and left-leaning magazines. She got a break when some outlets sent her to report on copper miners and mill workers striking against the Phelps Dodge Corporation over wages. She was supposed to file a few quick stories, but the strike dragged on, and Kingsolver kept talking to the workers; eventually, they started introducing her to others as “the gal that’s writing the book about us.”

Kingsolver wrote that book, “Holding the Line: Women in the Great Arizona Mine Strike of 1983,” about the wives, daughters, and sisters of the miners, who formed a picket line when the men were prohibited from doing so. But no one wanted to publish it. She’d found an agent in a directory at the public library, Frances Goldin, whom she chose because her entry had indicated that her agency would not represent “pornography or ageist, sexist, racist, or homophobic material.” Kingsolver emphasizes how radical that was for the time, and how heartened she is that literary culture has caught up to the mission-driven agency, whose marquee clients were Adrienne Rich and Dorothy Allison. Although Goldin couldn’t sell Kingsolver’s book, the pair grew close, and Goldin, already beloved at Pride parades for the sign she

carried in support of her two lesbian daughters, became a kind of surrogate mother to the author.

When Kingsolver got pregnant, in 1986, she developed severe insomnia, and used those “extra hours” to write fiction. It came slowly until she began drawing on aspects of herself that she’d spent nearly fifteen years suppressing. “I was in this little writing group,” she tells me, “and there were four other women writing stories and sharing them with each other, and I kept sharing these stories about all these people who lived around Dog Doo Park”—the nickname her characters gave to their small urban park—“and one of the women said, ‘These people don’t seem like they’re from anywhere.’”

Kingsolver, chastened and inspired, apprenticed herself to the working-class characters of Bobbie Ann Mason and the neo-agrarian works of Wendell Berry. Those Kentucky authors helped her find the voice of Taylor Greer, the narrator of “The Bean Trees.” “I have been afraid of putting air in a tire ever since I saw a tractor tire blow up and throw Newt Hardbine’s father over the top of the Standard Oil sign,” it begins. “I’m not lying. He got stuck up there.” A prolonged pregnancy gave Kingsolver more time to finish; instead of opting for induction when her due date passed, she waited out her baby for another three weeks, long enough to send the manuscript off to Goldin with a note: “I’m sorry, you probably don’t want this. I think it’s a novel.”

The day that Kingsolver came home from the hospital with her daughter Camille, there was a message on the answering machine from Goldin with two offers for the book. The novel, published in 1988, foreshadowed the career to come by taking on, with disarming frankness, everything from child abuse to transracial adoption. It also divided critics in ways that her work has done ever since. “Only a Dickensian villain could fail to like this book,” Carolyn See wrote in the *Los Angeles Times*, adding that “this novel goes beyond ordinary storytelling in its noble intent.” But that intent seemed like a flaw to others: a reviewer in the *New York Times* lamented Kingsolver’s “overmanipulation” of characters, from the unfailingly honorable victims to the impossibly perfect heroine, saying that the book, for all its virtues, sometimes read like “an upbeat novel for teenagers.”



Although “The Bean Trees” sold modestly, book clubs and independent booksellers adored it and kept it in print. But, while Kingsolver’s professional life was taking shape, her personal life began falling apart. “When the attention started coming to me, not to him—that was not in the contract,” she tells me. In the early nineties, she and Hoffmann moved with Camille to the Canary Islands for a year, partly because Kingsolver, who had been protesting the Gulf War, wanted a break from American politics, but also because she and Hoffmann were trying to reset their life. When that failed, they divorced. “A nonfunctioning marriage,” Kingsolver wrote not long afterward, “is a slow asphyxiation. It is waking up despised each morning, listening to the pulse of your own loneliness before the radio begins to blare its raucous gospel that you’re nothing if you aren’t loved.”

Kingsolver still has insomnia but doesn’t write in those late-night hours anymore. Instead, she keeps a special stack of books by her bed which she essentially uses as soporifics, and which she diplomatically asks me not to name. Despite all the lost sleep, she gets up early to write, which she does in a long and gorgeously renovated L-shaped office she jokes should have a plaque for Oprah Winfrey, who has twice chosen Kingsolver novels for her book club. Every edge, ledge, and surface is covered with books, pictures of her children, and cards from her grandchildren, plus art, letters, and

tchotchkes from her readers—everyone, she says, from prisoners to Presidents.

She works at a standing desk, taking a break whenever her feet fall asleep. She generally wakes up with a few sentences, occasionally even whole paragraphs, in mind, and starts typing; after she gets those written up, she reads what she wrote the day before, often aloud, and keeps doing it over and over until she's satisfied, which can sometimes take dozens of drafts. These days, her process can be slow for another reason: she suffers from Dupuytren's contracture, a painful disease that causes the tissues of the palms to thicken and tighten, forming hard cords that curl the fingers until they cannot lie flat. She has had corrective surgery on both hands and is grateful to still be able to play the piano and to knit. Some days, she can type only with one hand, but she quips that, much of the time, you really just need one finger: "Whenever people ask for writing advice, I say, Fall in love with your Delete key."

Kingsolver tends to alternate between smaller novels and grander ones. Two years after "The Bean Trees," she published "Animal Dreams," which is not only about a woman who moves home to take care of her ailing father but also about her sister, who has been murdered by the Contras in Nicaragua while trying to help the Sandinistas grow cotton. That was followed quickly by "Pigs in Heaven," in 1993, which returned to Taylor Greer and her adopted Cherokee daughter, Turtle. By then, Kingsolver was already well into the decade she spent writing what she came to call the D.A.B.: the Damned Africa Book.

The rest of the world would know it as "The Poisonwood Bible." The novel is narrated by the five female members of the Price family of Bethlehem, Georgia, who collectively tell the tragic story of Western intervention in Congo. It occupied the *Times* best-seller list for more than six months, largely thanks to its gripping sweep, but also because of Kingsolver's knack for producing the right book for the moment. It appeared in 1998, a few months after the Congolese President, Laurent-Désiré Kabila, banished Rwandan and Ugandan troops from the country, leading his former allies to support rebel uprisings, and eventually pulling some two dozen armed groups and nine African countries into the deadliest conflict since the Second World War. But some critics found the book as preposterous as the

Betty Crocker cake mixes the Prices tote with them across the Atlantic. In *The New Republic*, Lee Siegel crowned Kingsolver “the queen of Nice Writing,” arguing that she offered a no-calorie version of life’s real tragedies, whether it was colonialism in Africa or American imperialism in Latin America. “Kingsolver does not exactly outrage me, because she is so damn nice; but she is becoming outrageous,” he wrote. “With the publication of ‘The Poisonwood Bible,’ this easy, humorous, competent, syrupy writer has been elevated to the ranks of the greatest political novelists of our time.”

“The Poisonwood Bible” drew on the experiences of Kingsolver’s family; she was finally able to finish it because she’d made a new family of her own. In 1993, divorced and raising her daughter alone, she accepted a teaching fellowship on the condition that she be placed on a college campus near enough to eastern Kentucky that her relatives could help with child care. She wound up at Emory & Henry University, in Virginia’s western highlands, where one day she got a phone call from Steven Hopp, a professor whose class on global wildlife conservation she had agreed to visit. Hopp asked what she’d be talking about, and, when she realized that she hadn’t planned anything, she made up a lecture based on a title the fellowship coördinator had chosen for her: “Ecofeminism and Personal Responsibility.”

What happened next remains a source of amicable contention thirty-three years later. Hopp tells me his version of the story while the three of us walk the timber road of their farm looking for mushrooms. Trumpets are in season, their dark, earthy umber contrasting almost comically with the neon-pink basket that Kingsolver carries. Irrespective of any sentence she might be in the middle of, she bounds ahead whenever she sees a big cap, to try to get it before Hopp can. He, meanwhile, is happy to lose the foraging competition in order to win the argument about their first meeting. He claims that during their initial conversation he made awkward small talk while inwardly worrying she might deliver a lecture on ridding the world of men. She claims that he told her, “Good luck parlaying that into an hour.” “In my defense,” Hopp interrupts, “I don’t think I would’ve known what the word ‘parlay’ meant.”

Kingsolver, in any case, parlayed it into a marriage. After the lecture, Hopp invited her to his farm, near Meadowview, where they walked the same trail the three of us are walking now. “The Jane Austen version would be ‘He had

a beautiful farm; unpolluted acres,’ ” Kingsolver jokes. It was the night before she was supposed to leave town and they found that they couldn’t stop talking—they built a campfire, looked for glowworms, played music, and stayed up until daybreak. “I said, ‘I haven’t had this much fun in forever,’ ” Kingsolver remembers. “And he said, ‘Really? I have this much fun every day.’ ”

She returned to Tucson, but not before she and Hopp exchanged numbers; they got married, she says, when their telephone bills exceeded their mortgages. Hopp transferred to the University of Arizona, but they returned to southwestern Virginia every summer, and when Kingsolver’s daughter finished high school they relocated to Hopp’s farm full time. By then, they’d had a daughter, Lily, and they soon finished renovating the old farmhouse that had come with the property.



One of the most conspicuous luxuries there now is a Steinway piano. Kingsolver used to play with the Rock Bottom Remainders, a band of best-selling authors who perform rock-and-roll covers to benefit literacy and free-speech advocacy groups at glamorous venues such as the annual convention of the American Booksellers Association. “Barbara was like a bad girl from the Shangri-Las,” the novelist Amy Tan told me, recalling the outrageous outfits she and the other Remainderettes wore. Stephen King, a guitarist and

sometime vocalist for the Remainders, described Kingsolver as “gorgeous and dryly funny,” adding, “I can remember her once saying, ‘I’m back here trapped in triplet hell.’ Talking about that rock beat, you know.”

Hopp is a drummer and guitarist, and he and Kingsolver have played music together from the beginning. “Ours is an egalitarian marriage,” Kingsolver explains while giving me a tour of their curing barn, which the chickens and guineas call home, and where practically all the other open space is taken up by this year’s garlic, onion, and shallot crop, drying on a rack almost the size of the Reflecting Pool, though already significantly less green. “He’s so supportive—the extrovert to my introvert,” she says. Hopp is also the first reader of her drafts and, at least during my visit, the baker of bread, maker of salads, brewer of coffee, checker of weather, and acquirer of U.S.D.A. land-use data on their farm when I ask about its acreage. No one is more surprised than Kingsolver by how happy she is living in Appalachia and being someone’s wife, though her husband is likelier to be called Mr. Kingsolver than she is Mrs. Hopp.

When “Animal, Vegetable, Miracle” came out, in 2007, some quipped that Kingsolver had always been trying to make her readers eat their vegetables. It’s difficult to summarize or even catalogue all the issues she has tackled in her work. An abridged list would include the complexities of tribal law, in “Pigs in Heaven”; the sanctuary movement, in “Animal Dreams”; censorship and artistic freedom, in “The Lacuna,” her 2009 novel about Diego Rivera, Frida Kahlo, and the House Un-American Activities Committee; climate change and religious fundamentalism, in “Flight Behavior,” from 2012; and the kitchen sink, in “Unsheltered,” from 2018, which takes on evolution, poverty, racism, globalization, higher education, miscarriage, utopias, dystopias, and nearly everything else that was plaguing and polarizing America circa both 1875 and 2015. The critic Dwight Garner called the last “dead on arrival” in the *Times*, diagnosing a fault similar to one that had split readers of “The Lacuna”—a feeling that the novels were really each two distinct books, with a superior story crowded out by a lesser one.

“There was always a condescension toward Barbara and her work from literary circles,” Sam Stoloff, who took over Frances Goldin’s agency when Goldin died, told me when I asked about Kingsolver’s reception. “Barbara’s theory is always a prejudice against rural people, but I think there’s more to

it than that. She straddles the line between commercial and literary fiction, and part of the condescension is people feeling she's too popular. I also think it has to do with wearing her politics on her sleeve."

Kingsolver has never lived in N.Y.C. and doesn't have an M.F.A., and she says she doesn't feel beholden to what either urbane readers or workshop leaders think a novel should or shouldn't do. "I never wanted to be one of the cool kids," she tells me, and, despite a keen awareness of the critical conversation about her work, her way of defending herself has been to make more of it. She delights in finding the right metaphor (relationships that "harden like arteries," a pregnant woman who feels like "a universe with ankles") and deploying aphorisms ("The wonder is that you could start life with nothing, end with nothing, and lose so much in between") in just the appropriate tone and register for her wildly variable casts, which range from farmers, mechanics, and entomologists to fictional mid-century novelists. She has written in the first person, the third person, and an omniscient no person; she has written allegories, books within books, and collages of reportage real and imagined, plus epistolary novels, sestinas, and sonnets.

Kingsolver says that writing a poem is like "riding a unicycle, and the art is in balancing one idea," but that her novels are more like station wagons that she fills up and then throws some other ideas on top of or tows a few more behind. That maximalist approach was out of synch with American literature for much of her career, but eventually the culture, at least when it came to fiction, veered in the direction her station wagons have always been driving.

For a long time, one of the things Kingsolver could neither let go of nor commit to the page was another kind of D.A.B.: a Damned Appalachia Book. She wanted to write a novel about the opioid epidemic and what it had done to the place she calls home, yet struggled to find a voice for it. In 2018, exhausted after the international tour for "Unsheltered," she checked herself into Bleak House, a bed-and-breakfast that operates out of Dickens's summer house in Kent, looking over Viking Bay, where guests are booked into such rooms as the Copperfield Bridal Suite and Little Dorrit's Classic Double. Kingsolver didn't get a character, though, she got the author himself: the Charles Dickens Room, and its adjoining study, complete with his old writing desk. That's where she was sitting when, one night, unable to

write and on the verge of sleep, she heard the ghost of Dickens say, “Let the child speak.”

Kingsolver still identifies as a scientist; she doesn’t believe in ghosts or talking with dead people, even beloved authors, which made the whole experience particularly bizarre. Perhaps it was a waking dream, she says, or a little glitch in her brain. In any case, she obeyed, conjuring, in the months that followed, one of the few child narrators to elbow their way into the American canon: Damon Fields, a Melungeon boy who becomes known as Demon Copperhead. Born in the caul to a teen-age mother high on pills and passed out on the floor of her trailer, Demon makes the best of an almost entirely unsupervised childhood, digging for sassafras and avoiding snakes, playing Nintendo Duck Hunt and wishing to be Wolverine. Next door is his best friend, Matt Peggot, a.k.a. Maggot. Everyone in this novel has a nickname—Fast Forward, Humvee, Hammerhead, Extra Eye, Baggy Eyes, U-Haul, Creaky, Swap-Out—partly because comedy is one of the only coins in this impoverished realm, but also because no one ever leaves or leaves behind their reputation. “Here,” Demon says, “all we can ever be is everything we’ve been.”

Plenty of novelists swear by Word, Scrivener, or Google Docs, but Kingsolver used an Excel spreadsheet to outline every chapter of “David Copperfield,” then marched Demon through a parallel plot. Somehow, the result doesn’t feel formulaic; it’s fierce and feral and, most improbably, fully original. Take the paragraph below, from soon after Kingsolver explains, in breath-catching detail, how Maggot’s mother ended up in Goochland prison for almost “Lorena Bobbington” the boy’s father, and a few moments before she gives a Zola-like account of bringing in a tobacco crop, complete with the nicotine poisoning that can come with it. This is Demon, on getting to Elk Knob Elementary School from the farm where his case manager has temporarily placed him:

Riding the bus with high-schoolers was where you learned everything: how girls get pregnant, how to watch your back. Given the time we put in, the way-out country kids got the most education. I saw more than one guy fingering his girlfriend on a school bus, or her going down on him. More than one face slapped by a girl that wanted none of it. A lip or two busted. Once this fierce tiny towheaded girl got so fed up of a

big guy calling her Q-tip, she stood on the seat behind him and cracked her Etch a Sketch over his head. Screen side down, the silver shit running down to cover his whole face. Picture Tin Man out of the Oz movie. That girl was going places. Probably she's the president of something by now. At the least, not pregnant.

The slang, the syntax, the specificity, the sociology, all compressed, black-hole style, onto a school bus—Kingsolver keeps this up for five hundred pages, from Demon's dashing "First, I got myself born" to an ending too good to spoil. Reading the book is like watching one of those mothers who lift up a car to rescue their child from underneath. Kingsolver wrote "Demon Copperhead," she says, out of the grief and the anger she feels for what has happened to Appalachia, a colony of sorts within America where one extractive industry after another robbed its natural resources—first timber, then coal, then tobacco—until Purdue Pharma came peddling cures for all the pain those earlier industries had left behind.

Because of her Zip Code, Kingsolver has long been a kind of *MAGA* whisperer, an unofficial Ambassador of Real America. She hopes that that gig ends soon, and dismisses the possibility of Trumpism having a successor, insisting that the President has cultivated a cult of personality, not a lasting political movement. ("He chose a Vice-President with the charisma of a turd," she adds.) America's divisions, she says, are not attributable to any one person, and "Demon Copperhead" wasn't intended to explain why half the country voted for Trump and was about to do so again. It was an elegy for the generation of children being raised by their mawmaws or thrown into foster care because their parents were dead from overdoses or locked away for selling pills, a rebuke of the well-meaning policymakers and nonprofit directors whose arrogance masquerades as helpfulness. It is, finally, an apologia for rural life by someone who came from and willingly returned to it.

Kingsolver's daughters, Camille and Lily, both live near their mother, and her two grandchildren visit all the time. One of Kingsolver's favorite local restaurants is a Mexican joint where she enjoys the Asian-pear Martinis and the grandkids enjoy the balloon artist who's there every Tuesday. Camille's husband runs Snow's Fine Meats & Provisions, a butcher shop in Abingdon; while we ate a lunch from there one day, Lily and her husband came by to

use the printer. Both daughters contributed to “Animal, Vegetable, Miracle,” and both have continued to collaborate with their mother: Camille’s work as a community mental-health counsellor and her familiarity with the foster system helped inform “Demon Copperhead,” and Lily’s training in science education led to her co-writing the children’s book “Coyote’s Wild Home.”

“I didn’t really expect my girls would be able to come back here after college, but I’m glad they could,” Kingsolver says. “I couldn’t get far enough away from my family.” When her mother died, in 2013, Kingsolver wrote, in a poem, “While we spoke kindly, / mostly, my mother and I did not love one another. / Ever, not even when I was a baby.” It was through reading old correspondence that Kingsolver learned about her mother’s postpartum depression. “For the first twenty-five years of my life, until therapy, I thought it was my fault,” she says. “How could a mother not love her child?” In the poem’s final line, with the last of her mother’s breaths drawn and a “wild stampede” of a storm outside quieted, Kingsolver writes, “Here begins my life as no one’s bad daughter.”

After Dr. Wendell died, in the spring of 2024, Kingsolver finally felt free to write about her origins. “I needed both my parents to be gone before I could write this,” she says of “Partita.” Its narrator, Livia Bohusz, is a small-town girl from Tennessee who learns to play piano at church, practicing endless hours for one recital after another, culminating in a guest appearance with the Knoxville Symphony Orchestra and then a scholarship to the Indiana University School of Music. Her ambitions are fuelled not only by a desire to perfect her talents but by desperation to escape her family: a brother whose suicide torments those who survived him; a mother who terrorizes her, emotionally and physically, for everything, including her musical gifts; a “Cross-to-Bear Methodist” father who is too cowed to protect his daughter or publicly champion her talents. “A child can’t hate her mother without putting the load-bearing walls of the known world at risk,” Livia confides in one early chapter. “I settled for hating her shoes.”

Plenty of people in “Partita” question whether the daughter of a dairy farmer could ever earn her place in the world of Satie and Schubert, and plenty of people who care for Livia don’t understand the universe of meaning she finds in eighty-eight keys. As she taps out Bach with her fingers on the back of a boyfriend’s shoulders one night, he asks her if she’s happy when she’s

playing the piano. “I have no idea,” she tells him. “When I’m playing, I’m not me anymore. I go inside the music and disappear in there.”

That boyfriend is Sigurd, the Marxist organizer whose beliefs make Livia question hers. He disrupts her trajectory in other ways as well, and, in true Kingsolverish style, their affair draws a variety of crises down on Livia’s head. Kingsolver knows that it’s a lot to fit in. In one scene, Livia explains to Sigurd, and to us, that a partita “will never be all happy rondos, or all andantes in a minor key. You’ll usually have a prelude, a thrilling allemande, maybe a slow, sexy sarabande—the contrast is the point. The parts are all different, and the artist’s work is to make them all add up to a something that feels whole.”



Kingsolver can play a partita, too, but as much as she’s used her life as inspiration for this novel, she is emphatic about being its author, not its protagonist. “I think it’s similar to acting,” she tells me, “in that actors play all kinds of different characters that they would never be, including murderers. No one says, ‘Is this based on your own mother?’ To inhabit a character, they pull something from inside themselves that helps them understand that character, and that’s exactly how I would put it. I have written as many different kinds of people as Meryl Streep has played and more, and most of them are very different from me.”

So although Livia escapes Appalachia on a music scholarship, as Kingsolver did, and also returns there, she does so chastened, like the heroine of a Nathaniel Hawthorne or a Thomas Hardy novel, not like the world-famous artist Kingsolver has become. But the consolations of art do not depend on achievement, and that might be Kingsolver's most direct riposte to her critics. Back home, Livia takes long walks with her sister-in-law, Mickie, the latest in a line of truth-telling public-school teachers from Kingsolver's books. A former literature major, Mickie—or, per the Steele County High School Yearbook, Mrs. Michaela Barnes, A.P. English—finds meaning in pressing Dickens and Longfellow on farm kids, not so that they can become novelists or poets but so that they have a storehouse of beauty to sustain them for the rest of their lives. When a dispirited Livia is wondering what good there is in music, Mickie, like a windup Mary Oliver, tells her, “The point of art is to help you like your life better.”

I ask Kingsolver if she agrees with Mickie, and she says she isn't sure. This claim about art is the kind of thing that would enrage her detractors, although it's easy to imagine the credo tattooed on the arms of M.F.A. students and italicized in their bios on TikTok. “I haven't Updiked,” Kingsolver tells me one day proudly, noting that, although she gets older with every book tour, her audiences seem to stay at least relatively young. Foster kids have written to her about how much they love *Demon*, new classes of students read about the Price family every semester, and Kingsolver still hears regularly from parents and grandparents who, moved by “Animal, Vegetable, Miracle,” have tried their own version of that book's experiment, whether on hobby farms or with whatever pots they can plant on their front stoops or fire escapes.

These days, “nice” isn't the withering critique it once was. The novelist Richard Powers, a friend of Kingsolver's, told me, “All the qualities that are there in the books are magnified in fact—wisdom wrapped in warmth, commitment to community, wry pragmatism, a reverence for place.” Certainly, her life is like her work in at least one respect: it is far more difficult to dismiss once you've actually engaged with it.

During my visit, Kingsolver dumps the leftover water from our drinking glasses into one of her plants before answering a question I've asked her about charity. “The whole idea of charity is condescending,” she says. She

prefers the category of generosity, because giving in that spirit lacks the coercive expectations of charity, the implicit hope that the recipient will become more like the donor. After Kingsolver's advances grew large enough to support her family, she began passing along her royalties: one novel endowed the Bellwether Prize, which offered twenty-five thousand dollars and a publishing contract for socially engaged works of fiction; one of the essay collections contributes to the Environmental Defense Fund, Habitat for Humanity, and Heifer International; another novel became the engine for a new medical scholarship for Congolese students, named in memory of her father.

For fifteen years, Hopp ran Harvest Table, a restaurant in Meadowview serving food and selling goods sourced from a few hundred local farmers and craftspeople. It made no money, but embodied the principles he and Kingsolver had articulated in "Animal, Vegetable, Miracle," serving grits made from Appalachian dent corn and burgers that came from nearby beef herds. Hopp closed Harvest Table in 2022 and Kingsolver sunsetted the Bellwether Prize in 2023, not because they gave up on their convictions, she says, but because they were becoming so widely shared: there are more locavores than ever, and the types of books the Bellwether championed (Jamila Minnicks's "Moonrise Over New Jessup," Hillary Jordan's "Mudbound," Lisa Ko's "The Leavers") no longer need as much help getting published.

After "Demon Copperhead" came out, Kingsolver convened some of the social workers and medical professionals who had helped her while she was researching the book by sharing their experiences of providing addiction and recovery care. Many came from Lee County, which is both where the book is set and one of the counties most ravaged by the opioid epidemic. Over breakfast at Shoney's, she asked what she should do with her avalanche of royalties. To a person, they told her that what the region most needed was a recovery house for women—something small enough to let its residents feel like family and unhurried enough that they could really get back on their feet, whether they came from prison or the streets. Kingsolver and Hopp opened one: Higher Ground Women's Recovery Residence, which, so far, has served more than a dozen women in Pennington Gap, Virginia, offering sober housing, education, and support for up to two years. When the women living in "The House That Demon Built" needed more opportunities for

employment, Kingsolver and Hopp donated funds to buy the property next door, which will soon become Second Chances Thrift Store.

“Attention and money just feel like things you have to hold a mirror up to, directing them somewhere else,” Kingsolver tells me. “I guess partly I don’t want to be the tall weed that gets cut, and, partly because of my raising, I just don’t want to get too full of myself.” We’re cooling off from today’s walk in the woods, resting for a while in the oversized Arts and Crafts-style chairs in her sitting room, opposite the piano, with some of the music mentioned in “Partita” still on the rack. The chair Kingsolver has chosen is the one where she knits almost daily, using the wool of her own sheep, seventy-five pounds or so of which she and Hopp harvest every year, then take to a solar-powered mill where it’s spun into yarn.

Kingsolver picks up the sweater she’s in the thick of to show me her progress. But I’m distracted by what’s behind her: a broken window, stretching almost from floor to ceiling, the glass thoroughly fractured yet refusing to come apart, a dense spiderweb of cracks with the blur of her terraced vegetable garden behind it. “I forgot you’re looking at me with the backdrop of the shatter,” she says. Someone would be coming by soon to see about replacing the window, but in the meantime, ever since Hopp cracked it by kicking up a rock with his weed trimmer, Kingsolver has studied its brokenness, taping both sides to keep the glass together, admiring how it scatters the sunlight.

She turns back to look at it in the middle of a long answer to a question I’ve asked about reconciling her happiness with the injustices of the world. She ticks off just a few of the day’s news stories—the aftermath of an earthquake in Venezuela, the energy crisis in Cuba, the ongoing catastrophe in Gaza—and observes how easy it is to be overwhelmed by any one of these tragedies, and how easy it is to be distracted from them, too. “We are not wired for this,” she says of the endless scroll of suffering that people confront nowadays. “The machine is not built to handle all this information. There are limits to the human mind, a limit to the number of people the human animal evolved to care for.”

One antidote to this, she insists, is the novel. “Novels draw you into human conflicts the way our brains are wired to experience them—as feelings, and

there's a big difference between information and feeling. We enter into the realities of other people through emotion, not information, and that's what a great novel does." The newspaper, the home page, the grid, the feed: "A novel isn't a few seconds and then on to something else—the hodgepodge of randomness, equating things that are not equivalent. A novel brings you into the one-to-one, the intimacy of human relationships and human conflicts, for hours at a time."

Kingsolver says, "I'll keep writing for as long as I can. Until I can't remember words." She doesn't give a hoot about A.I., and she tells me that the same share of people read fiction today as they did in Cervantes's time, so we should quit worrying about the end of reading. All she can do, she says, is what she's always done: craft a novel, from page negative one hundred to page zero, then onward to the end. ♦

A Reporter at Large

Israel's Qatargate Scandal

Did Benjamin Netanyahu's aides peddle influence to a foreign power?

By Ruth Margalit

September 19, 2026



As a young man, Yisrael Einhorn was a mainstay of Tel Aviv's underground night life—an ebullient music producer and performer who billed himself as D.J. Cock and went around town costumed as a golden penis. It was fun, and sometimes he made some money, but over time the club life began to wear thin. He found a second career in advertising, then got into politics. In 2017, he founded a strategic-consulting company called Perception and went on to help run five election campaigns for Israel's Likud Party. He became known for his close ties to the Party's leader, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

While Einhorn built his influence in Israeli politics, his company also secured a lucrative foreign client: Qatar, the tiny Gulf emirate that is among the world's richest countries. In 2022, Qatar was preparing to host the *FIFA* World Cup, and its communication ministry wanted to spread the idea that Qatar was a Jewish-friendly place. (Never mind that even the grade-school

textbooks there were rife with antisemitism.) Perception set up a dummy news site and created fake social-media accounts highlighting the tournament's amenities, which included kosher food in stadiums. After the games were over, Qatar still found the relationship with Perception valuable: it continued sending payments of forty-five thousand dollars a month through a third-party company.

In December, 2023, Einhorn went to the Ritz in London to discuss a new opportunity. His host was Jay Footlik, another ex-performer who'd had a propitious second career. Footlik grew up an aspiring actor in Skokie, Illinois, and as a young man he landed bit parts in such films as "Teen Wolf" and "Iron Eagle." Later on, he, too, turned to politics: he worked on a campaign for Bill Clinton and served as a Middle East adviser to John Kerry. Since 2019, Footlik had been a registered lobbyist for Qatar; his company, Third Circle, was paid half a million dollars a year to enhance the emirate's reputation among the D.C. élite.

At the Ritz, Footlik told Einhorn about Qatar's P.R. objective. It wanted to be known as a peacemaker in the region. Both men knew that this would require a radical change in Israeli public opinion. It had been only two months since Hamas militants swept into Israel, killing some twelve hundred people and touching off a vicious assault on Gaza. Israelis, freshly traumatized, viewed Qatar as their enemy's patron.

Since 2018, Qatar had been transferring as much as thirty million dollars a month to Gaza. The money was nominally to pay civil servants and prop up infrastructure in a territory sequestered by an Israeli blockade, but many observers agreed that Hamas diverted a significant sum to its military wing. "The Qatari grant is the main artery of the Hamas movement," a Hamas leader told Qatar's foreign minister in 2019, according to papers later seized by Israel. The October 7th attacks revealed what Qatar's money had helped buy: Hamas forces assembled in a vast system of tunnels outfitted with ventilation systems, surveillance cameras, and communications networks; they emerged wearing body cameras and carrying antitank missiles.

When Footlik and Einhorn met in London, the war in Gaza had been intensifying. Strikes by the Israel Defense Forces had killed tens of thousands of Palestinians, while Hamas continued to hold more than a

hundred Israeli hostages. Qatar wanted to intervene. The emirate had recently negotiated a ceasefire between the two sides, and, though the deal collapsed after a week, the Qataris thought that they could broker a more comprehensive agreement—as long as Israel and the U.S. accepted them as mediators.

Footlik and Einhorn began to plot a campaign to transform Qatar's reputation. In the coming months, they are alleged to have worked with two aides in Netanyahu's office on a scheme for which they were paid hundreds of thousands of dollars. The aides arranged press junkets, invented sources, and planted stories that brazenly inverted popular views. Hamas leaders were being sheltered in Qatar—but only at the insistence of Israel and the United States. Egypt was Israel's longtime peace partner—but it couldn't be trusted to handle the negotiations. As the stories gained currency, Einhorn wrote in a celebratory text that they were “giving birth to reality.”

From Qatar's perspective, the campaign was a success: the Qataris became crucial players in peace talks over Gaza. Within Israel, though, it has become the center of a nearly unprecedented scandal—a legal case, now known as Qatargate, that involves a sweeping police investigation and potential indictments of several members of Netanyahu's innermost circle. The government of Qatar rejects the allegations as “journalistic propaganda.” Netanyahu, with characteristic defiance, has dismissed the claims as a “bluff.” But, of all the corruption accusations that have plagued him over the years—taking gifts from business leaders, exchanging favors for friendly news coverage—the charge that his aides doubled as influence agents for Qatar may be the most politically damaging. Naftali Bennett, a former Prime Minister who is challenging Netanyahu in the upcoming election, has called it the “most serious act of treason” in the country's history.

Along Israeli highways, a crowdsourced campaign has erected billboards to keep the scandal in view, with messages like “Qatar Funded the Massacre and Netanyahu's Office.” When I stopped next to one such billboard in Tel Aviv recently, a driver pulled up in a Mercedes, rolled down his window, and spat on the ground in disgust.

The billboard also displayed photographs of the alleged conspirators. Among them was Eli Feldstein, a thirtysomething with a shaved head, a close-cropped beard, and a look of searching concern. Feldstein's name had come up when Einhorn and Footlik were looking for someone with sufficient credibility to spread their pro-Qatar messages to journalists. Einhorn had a list of candidates, which included a number of seasoned media specialists—and also Feldstein, who worked as a military-affairs spokesperson for Netanyahu.

Feldstein was relatively young, and he didn't speak English, but he had already distinguished himself as what Einhorn called a "master communicator." He grew up in the ultra-Orthodox city of Bnei Brak and served for a decade as a media operative, working for a time in the chaotic office of Itamar Ben-Gvir, Israel's far-right national-security minister. There, he began ingratiating himself with the Prime Minister's aides. On October 7th, as Hamas militants ravaged communities along Israel's southern border, he was already managing optics from afar. Feldstein recommended that Netanyahu appear with "no suit, no tie, combat mode," and demanded that the military spokesman's office release photos of "soldiers on the ground, with helicopters." When the photos failed to materialize quickly enough, he griped that members of the unit were "scumbags."

Feldstein started work in Netanyahu's office just four days after the attacks. The surroundings weren't glamorous. In an atmosphere of national panic, the Prime Minister was running most of his operations out of a squat nineteen-fifties building near "the Pit"—the I.D.F.'s underground command center. But, Feldstein said when I met him recently near Tel Aviv, "I was thrilled to work there. I really wanted to prove myself."

From his first day on the job, he was called on to defend the Prime Minister, Feldstein told me. As he was getting settled, Netanyahu walked by, pointed at a television mounted on his office wall, and asked if reporters were "still talking about responsibility"—his refusal to apologize for the military and intelligence failures that led to the attacks. Feldstein replied that they were. Netanyahu, he says, told him to "do something about it."

Feldstein's immediate boss was Netanyahu's closest strategic adviser, Jonatan Urich. For years, Urich had been a constant presence at the Prime

Minister's side: a bearish man with black-rimmed glasses and an inscrutable smile. Feldstein described him as "Netanyahu's first phone call in the morning and last phone call before bed."

Urich had started off in the military press office, where he built a reputation as a social-media whiz. In 2015, he joined Netanyahu's election campaign and helped secure an unlikely victory. "Jonatan turned negative campaigning into art," a former senior adviser to Netanyahu told me. "He enjoys watching the other side suffer—*really* enjoys it." He was fiercely loyal to the Prime Minister. When Urich was young, his father suffered a disabling stroke; Netanyahu became a father figure to him. "I would let him perform open-heart surgery on me," Urich once said.



During his years working for Netanyahu, Urich also had what amounted to a side hustle, working for Perception. He was able to discreetly hold both jobs because he was paid for his government work as a consultant for Likud. At the same time, he received forty per cent of Perception's payments from Qatar, through a third-party company founded by former Israeli security officials. (Urich denies any wrongdoing, saying, "I am being targeted because I advise the Prime Minister." He has claimed that he "never received money on behalf of Qatar in Israel." Although he doesn't deny that

Qatar paid him eighteen thousand dollars a month through most of 2024, he argues that he was being compensated for the World Cup campaign.)

After a few months in Netanyahu's office, Feldstein, too, effectively went on Perception's payroll. In his telling, it was almost accidental. He was hoping for a promotion and a higher salary, but he failed a security clearance because he had previously used drugs. Urich offered him a workaround, Feldstein said: he could receive an increased salary through an intermediary. That intermediary worked with Footlik. (Footlik says he has never sought to hire anyone who worked for the Israeli government, and that the funds he provided were for an effort to secure the release of the hostages. Feldstein argues that he never knew he was working for Qatar—though he and Einhorn referred in text exchanges to the “patients” and the “friends,” with the context clearly indicating Qatar.)

Footlik allegedly oversaw the Qatar influence campaign from outside, providing funds and giving strategic advice. Einhorn and Urich orchestrated the operation. Feldstein was their foot soldier, working to get news stories written and noticed. The campaign began in late April, 2024, and soon afterward Feldstein sent Einhorn two stories that he had helped place. In one, “senior Israeli officials” were quoted as saying, “No other country is capable of bringing about a deal except Qatar.” In the other, an Israeli reporter described Turkey as “ Hamas’s big brother” and contrasted it unfavorably with Qatar.

Footlik sent Feldstein a text describing his patrons’ reaction: “Eli you are killing it. Really good.”

Feldstein forwarded it to Urich, with a self-congratulatory note. “Bingo,” he wrote. “They’re in shock.”

“They’re flipping out,” Urich replied.

Qatar was historically a land rich in pearls and oil. Yet, for decades after it gained independence from Britain, in 1971, it was regarded in the West as little more than an extension of Saudi Arabia, its vastly larger neighbor. Then, in 1995, Sheikh Hamad bin Khalifa al-Thani took control of the country, deposing his father while he was away in Switzerland. Sheikh

Hamad had lofty ambitions, and his wife Sheikha Moza bint Nasser had even loftier ones: they wanted their country to be not just independent but eminent. With only three hundred and fifty thousand citizens, Qatar lacked the manpower to establish physical dominance in the region. It barely had an army. Instead, the Sheikh and Sheikha pursued a strategy of self-defense through economic influence and self-promotion.

In 1996, Hamad founded Al Jazeera, a news network that gave the emirate enormous cultural influence throughout the region. Unlike other Arab media, the network aired interviews with Israelis and Iranians, and gave voice to dissidents across the Middle East. Before long, its broadcasts had “entered every household in Arab society,” Shaul Yanai, an Israeli historian of the Persian Gulf states, said. Ten years after its founding, three out of four Arabs identified Al Jazeera as a primary news source. Tamir Pardo, a former director of Israel’s intelligence agency Mossad, told me that Qatar became “not a state with Al Jazeera, but Al Jazeera with a state.”

The network also provided a vehicle for Qatar to project an ideological vision that was deeply at odds with Israel. Al Jazeera gave a prime-time slot to Yusuf al-Qaradawi, who was widely regarded as the spiritual leader of the Muslim Brotherhood, an influential Islamist group with offshoots around the world—including Hamas. Qaradawi defended Palestinian suicide bombings of Israeli civilians as a legitimate form of resistance.

The emirate’s stance toward Israel is bound up with a broader strategic concern: restraining Saudi Arabia’s power. For years, the Saudis have backed rival members of Hamad’s family, hoping to replace the ruling Emir and bring Qatar back under Saudi influence. At times, they also discussed a deal with the U.S., in which they would normalize relations with Israel in exchange for arms and the ability to develop nuclear energy—an arrangement that would have made it the dominant power in the region. For the Qataris, Yanai said, insuring that Saudi Arabia and Israel do not normalize ties “is existential.”

In 2013, Hamad ceded the throne to his son, Tamim. According to Dennis Ross, a former U.S. envoy to the region, Tamim views the Muslim Brotherhood more instrumentally and less ideologically than his father. But he has opposed normalization with Israel. “Are things *normal* in Israel?

No!” he said in 2022. Between the Emir’s resistance, Israel’s harsh treatment of Palestinians, and the influence of figures like Qaradawi, “this has led to a generation for whom Israel is the greatest demon that exists,” Yanai said.

Nevertheless, Qatar treated Israel with what Yanai called “the famous Qatari duality.” In public, it called Israel the “occupation government” and provided aid to Hamas; in private, it maintained business ties and unofficial diplomatic contacts with high-ranking Israeli officials.

Ronit Marzan, a political scientist at the University of Haifa, describes Qatar’s approach to international diplomacy as “lulling empowerment.” In the U.S., for instance, it “buys weapons, invests in companies and in educational institutions. Then, slowly, the other state actor becomes addicted to the money.” Qatar shares the world’s largest natural-gas field with Iran, but has also backed the opposition to Iran’s allies in the Syrian government. It funds the Lebanese Army, but has also allegedly propped up Hezbollah. It hosts the largest U.S. military base in the Middle East, but also backed Islamist factions in Egypt and Libya. It gave a Boeing 747 to Turkey’s President, Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, and another to President Donald Trump. Ross told me, “The Qatari approach to the outside is to say, ‘The way we punch above our weight is by being uniquely situated to talk to everyone.’ ”

Perception held a similarly transactional view of power. By 2024, the firm was so entrenched in Netanyahu’s office that it was able to quietly dispatch the Prime Minister’s closest advisers to assist right-wing political candidates in Eastern Europe. Feldstein spent ten days on a campaign for a Perception client in Georgia. Netanyahu’s family spokesperson led one in Romania. Einhorn connected another senior adviser to a campaign that an acquaintance was running in Kosovo.

Einhorn himself worked on a campaign for Aleksandar Vučić, the President of Serbia. He told officials there that he had assisted the Israeli government with sensitive security matters. During the war in Gaza, he said, a shipment of arms to Israel had been held up in Eastern Europe, and he helped secure its release by arranging a phone call between Netanyahu and the Prime Minister of Montenegro. “I put myself on mute, and the two of them talked,” he said.

Feldstein never heard Netanyahu ask why his advisers were absent or where they were. (When the Qatargate story emerged later, this laissez-faire attitude outraged security veterans. “How can it be that the Prime Minister doesn’t know that his people are working for another government?” Pardo, the former head of Mossad, said. “And how come, once he learns it, he doesn’t tell them, ‘Guys, look me in the eye—you’re not coming anywhere near Jerusalem. As far as I’m concerned, you’ve betrayed me.’ ”)

In Einhorn’s view, it was natural that Netanyahu’s consultants were in demand around the world: they were shrewd campaign strategists and proven winners. Others concluded that the advisers were useful mostly for their proximity to Netanyahu. “These guys don’t know how to run a campaign for the State of Israel,” the former senior adviser to Netanyahu said. “They know how to be Bibi’s right hand.” In the lead-up to the World Cup, Qatar retained at least four of the world’s top public-relations firms. It didn’t need Perception—a company so small that it had no salaried employees. “It’s clear as day that they were approached because of their access to Netanyahu,” Aron Shaviv, a political strategist who oversaw Likud’s 2015 campaign, said. “And Qatar continued to keep them on retainer because now it had an asset.”

In May, 2024, I.D.F. troops pushed into the town of Rafah, on the Egyptian border, where more than a million displaced Gazans had evacuated on Israel’s orders and were now sheltering in makeshift tents. In the course of three weeks, Israeli soldiers destroyed much of the area, razing schools and mosques and commandeering buildings for use as military posts. The assault inspired worldwide outrage; the International Court of Justice demanded an immediate halt.

As the Israeli media focussed intently on the incursion, Einhorn grew restless about the progress of the pro-Qatar campaign. On May 24th, he asked Feldstein, “Anything for today?” There wasn’t. The previous night, the I.D.F. had retrieved the remains of three hostages from the sprawling Jabalia refugee camp. “Everyone is busy with recovering the bodies,” Feldstein replied, in messages published by Israel’s *i24 News*. But he said that he was happy to talk if Einhorn had “any ideas.”

Two minutes later, Einhorn wrote back to suggest that Feldstein give a briefing to journalists. Egypt had been deeply involved in talks over a ceasefire and a hostage-release deal. But Einhorn wanted to spread the message that “Egypt can no longer be trusted. From now on, only Qatar will lead the negotiations.” The quote should be attributed to “senior U.S. officials” in talks “behind closed doors,” he wrote.

That evening, during the prime-time news on Channel 12, a military reporter named Nir Dvori relayed the story nearly word for word. The network’s news anchor was astonished. “The *Americans* are saying this?” he asked.

“The Americans!” Dvori repeated.

This wasn’t the only time that the men apparently attributed made-up briefings to U.S. officials. The Biden Administration wasn’t surprised. “The assumption was that everyone was spinning everyone,” a former senior U.S. official in the region told me. But the Egyptians were furious. Mohamed Abu Hamed, an influential former lawmaker, wrote online later, “I haven’t seen anything dirtier than an Arab country paying money to cast doubt on the role played by another Arab country and create a fake role for itself.” (Qatar denied any effort to improperly influence Israeli officials. A Qatari spokesman said, “Put simply, if Qatar had somehow ‘infiltrated’ the Israeli government, it would have been a very bad investment.”)

After a blitz of pro-Qatar messaging, Israel’s Ambassador to the U.S. told Jewish groups, with no apparent evidence, that Egypt was violating its peace agreement with Israel. Feldstein and Einhorn seemed unconcerned about disrupting relations with Egypt, Israel’s most important peace partner in the region. “We’ve managed to really piss them off,” Feldstein texted at one point.

Days after planting the story on Channel 12, Einhorn prodded Feldstein again. “We’ve been too quiet,” he wrote. “Tomorrow we have to fire.” They came up with another story, saying that Qatar was growing disillusioned with Hamas. This wasn’t true—in fact, Qatar had declined to formally expel Hamas leaders from Doha, despite requests from American officials. But Feldstein devised an imaginary context: “a meeting held yesterday in Doha between the Qatari prime minister, the Egyptian intelligence chief, and

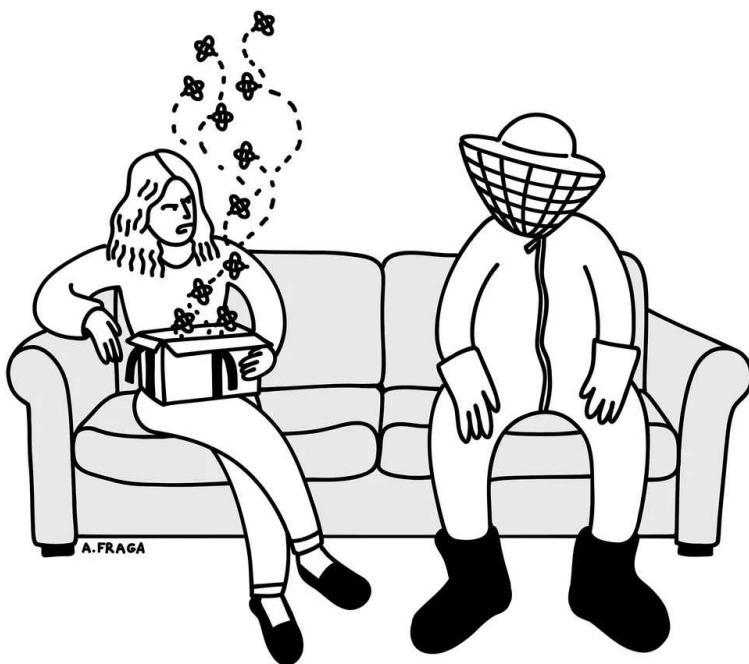
senior Hamas officials.” That story, too, was picked up by Channel 12. “It’s a bombshell,” Feldstein wrote afterward. “Ballistic,” Einhorn replied.

The campaign seemed fuelled by such cheerful cynicism. In messages, Urich hailed Feldstein as the “No. 1 spinner.” In the course of several months, Feldstein told me, “there were dozens of reports in Qatar’s favor.” Einhorn flew the editor of the Jerusalem *Post* to Doha; he later produced two reports that seemed lifted straight from Qatari talking points. Footlik also paid tens of thousands of dollars to a columnist for *Haaretz*. (The columnist subsequently resigned but denies wrongdoing.)

Not every journalist was duped. One responded to a pitch from Feldstein, “Do you work for the Qataris?!” (Feldstein: “Hahaha.”) Yet many appeared eager to take Feldstein’s shifting attributions at face value. Dvori, the Channel 12 reporter, later wrote online that he had no reason to doubt that Feldstein’s briefings were given “on behalf of the Prime Minister.” At times, he said, Feldstein even put Netanyahu on the phone. “It never occurred to me that Netanyahu’s people were serving Qatar for a fee,” he wrote.

If Netanyahu wondered why pro- Qatar narratives kept surfacing in stories that originated from his office, he gave no sign of it. In Feldstein’s view, “that is proof that the messages were the Prime Minister’s messages. No one was rebelling in real time.”

Netanyahu’s position on Qatar had long confounded those who worked with him, according to a former senior Israeli defense official. Many of his decisions orbited around Gaza. In 2007, Hamas seized control of the Strip, and Israel imposed a punishing blockade. Five years later, Sheikh Hamad effectively broke the siege by visiting Gaza and pledging more than four hundred million dollars to reconstruction efforts there. Israel condemned the visit, but Netanyahu didn’t intervene.



Although Netanyahu publicly described Hamas as an enemy, he was privately intent on keeping it strong. Hamas competed for influence with the Palestinian Authority—the civil government that runs parts of the West Bank—which Netanyahu did not want to take control of Gaza. He reasoned that, as long as Hamas was in power, Palestinians would remain divided, and Israel would face less pressure to negotiate a land-for-peace deal. As Ehud Olmert, a former Israeli Prime Minister, put it, Netanyahu’s policy was “very clearly that Hamas was an asset and the P.A. was a liability.”

His instrumental approach to Hamas extended to Qatar, too. In 2017, a dozen Muslim-majority countries severed ties with the emirate, accusing it of sponsoring terror and fomenting chaos around the world. In the U.S., the House took up a bill to impose sanctions on Qatar. “For us, this was a golden opportunity” to cut off Qatar’s influence in Gaza, Roni Alsheikh, who served as deputy director of the Shin Bet security agency and as head of the Israeli police, said. Instead, a Netanyahu military adviser wrote a letter stating that “Qatar has not delivered weapons to Hamas” and was engaging solely in humanitarian work in Gaza. A pro-Qatar lobbying group sent the letter to members of the House Foreign Affairs Committee. Soon afterward, the bill was abandoned.

The following year, a roadside bomb targeted the Palestinian Authority's Prime Minister as his convoy was driving in Gaza. Mahmoud Abbas, the President of the P.A., was enraged. He accused Hamas of an assassination attempt and slashed economic lifelines to Gaza. The result was surging unemployment, civil unrest, and mayhem on the border.

With Hamas squeezed, Netanyahu asked the Qataris to commit to official monthly payments to Gaza. He explained it as a strategy of buying stability: "I do what I can to restore peace to the southern communities." But many defense officials considered it unconscionable to provide funds that Hamas could siphon off. Defense Minister Avigdor Lieberman resigned in protest over the handling of Hamas. Even Netanyahu eventually acknowledged that Hamas leaders "take all the money that comes in from international support—and there's quite a bit of it—and they put it into turning tunnels into a terror machine." Yet he did not halt the transfers. Pardo, the former director of Mossad, described it to me as "a knife stab in Israel's national security."

Rumors began to spread that Netanyahu had covert links with Qatar. "There were definitely indications that there was a complex relationship there, including the idea that part of how Hamas was surviving was these understandings between Netanyahu and Qatar," Ben Rhodes, a foreign-policy adviser under Barack Obama, told me.

On October 7th, the strategy of quietly propping up Hamas collapsed. In Israel, Netanyahu seemed finished politically; surely he couldn't survive the biggest security failure in the country's history. Yet, that morning, the first foreign leader he called, before he even gave a statement to the public, was the Dutch Prime Minister Mark Rutte, who has close ties to Qatar.

He also relied on his confidant Yossi Cohen, a former Mossad director with his own links to Qatar. Soon after the attacks, Cohen flew to Doha on a private plane, bypassing official Mossad channels. The agency's new director issued an unusually harsh public rebuke. But Netanyahu defended his adviser, saying in a statement, "Cohen had initiated a meeting with an Arab leader with the approval of the prime minister."

The following August, six Israeli hostages were executed by Hamas in a tunnel in Rafah, after more than three hundred days in captivity. Israelis

poured into the streets, outraged that Netanyahu had squandered opportunities to reach a deal that might have saved them. Protests spilled onto the Jerusalem-Tel Aviv highway and lasted for days, representing a profound threat to the Israeli government.

Netanyahu grew nervous. Feldstein told me that he thought the Prime Minister should address the public immediately, but he was rebuffed. Then he had another idea to undercut the protests. An acquaintance from his father's synagogue had told him about a Hamas document that he'd seen during his reserve service in military intelligence. The document, which was highly classified and written in Arabic, suggested that Hamas was planning to exploit the hostage families' protests to fracture Israeli society. Feldstein says that he approached Netanyahu after a press conference and whispered to him about the document, saying that he and Urich were working on getting it out. The Prime Minister nodded in approval. (Netanyahu has denied having any knowledge of the document.)

There was an obstacle: the military censor barred publishing the memo, because it compromised Israeli intelligence. But Urich had a solution, Feldstein said. He told Feldstein to ask Einhorn to leak it to a foreign outlet, so that the Israeli media could legally report on the stories published abroad.

On September 6, 2024, the German tabloid *Bild* published a story on the Hamas document. The article's description of the memo was misleading: Though the headline suggested that it was linked to the Hamas leader Yahya Sinwar, it was apparently written by mid-level officials. And though *Bild* presented the document as evidence of Hamas's intransigence, it skipped over language showing that its leaders were willing to compromise. Still, in a Cabinet meeting two days later, Netanyahu referred to the story as proof that the protests were playing into Hamas's hands. Urich texted Feldstein, "The boss is happy."

The Qataris had reasons to be happy, too. Trump had placed Qatar at the center of a temporary ceasefire and hostage-release deal that went into effect in January, 2025. Netanyahu pulled out of the agreement that March, but Qatar remained the principal venue for indirect negotiations between Israel and Hamas. In October, a road-map peace deal was signed, and Trump thanked the Qataris, saying that they had been a "very big factor."

Other negotiators were frustrated. Yair Barak, an Israeli official who served on the negotiating team, told Israel's public broadcaster that Qatar was so biased in the talks that his peers referred to it as " Hamas's representative." Jonathan Schanzer, the executive director of the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, described the Qataris as both "the arsonists and the firefighters." But Doha had succeeded in establishing itself as an indispensable player in the region's politics. After October 7th, Qatar was vilified in Israel, but, as Uri Tuval, who has covered Qatargate extensively for the liberal magazine Telem, said, "Fast-forward three years—Qatar now has a foothold in the Mediterranean."

Two months after *Bild* published the secret document, Feldstein was jolted awake at four-forty-five in the morning by pounding on his door. "Police!" voices shouted. Feldstein told me that he opened the door in his boxers, shaking so violently that he barely managed to turn the lock. Masked men carrying M16s barged in, handcuffed him, and pinned him to the floor. They seized his phone and laptop, and warned his roommate not to utter a word to anyone. "You're suspected of harming national security," they told him.

"I said, 'I want an attorney,' " he recalled. "They said, 'There is no attorney.' " He ultimately spent almost six weeks in detention and seven months under house arrest.

Feldstein's arrest was kept under a sweeping gag order, for fear that disclosing it would compromise Israeli intelligence, but the *Haaretz* reporter Bar Peleg soon learned of it. Peleg had never before written about the Prime Minister's inner circle; he spent the early days of the war mostly covering the hostage families. But, as he looked into Feldstein, a tip led him to a Google Doc that had two listed authors: Jonatan Urich and Yisrael Einhorn. Written in 2022, it described Perception's pitch for Qatar's World Cup campaign. "There was even a suggestion that Qatar host a soccer friendly between Israeli and Palestinian youths," Peleg told me, with a laugh.

In November, 2024, Peleg exposed the connection between Netanyahu's advisers and the Qataris. The police were reluctant to investigate, he says; a law-enforcement source had told him that they were "afraid of touching the Prime Minister's office." But the Shin Bet began gathering evidence, and, in February, 2025, a criminal investigation was launched. The next month,

Feldstein, still on house arrest, was arrested again, as was Urich, on suspicion of contact with a foreign agent, bribery, fraud, breach of trust, and money laundering.

The revelations prompted renewed scrutiny of Israel's relationship with Doha. Some observers speculated that, if Netanyahu's closest aides were benefitting from Qatar, maybe he was, too. Among those who made accusations were several officials who had served at the highest levels of Israel's security establishment. One of them, Udi Levi, told me recently, "I will say it plainly: I claim that the Prime Minister received money from Qatar."

Between 2001 and 2016, Levi headed a division of Mossad that tracked terror-financing networks around the world. He worked closely with Netanyahu, and also voted for him, but has since become an impassioned, nearly obsessive critic. He is sixty-three, with the burly build of a former wrestler and the injuries to match. When I saw him, a bad back made him wince every few steps.

Levi's suspicions began in April, 2021, when an unusual news alert appeared on his phone. The article was titled "Qatar Connection," and Levi, a self-described "addict" of news about Qatari intrigue, clicked on it instantly. The report was from a French outlet called *Blast*, which publishes ambitious investigations in overheated prose. It included images of four documents from a decade earlier; three were on the letterhead of the Qatari finance ministry. They said, in Arabic, that millions of euros had been sent to prominent figures in France, including Bernard-Henri Lévy, a public intellectual who often commented on Middle Eastern politics, and Carla Bruni, the President's wife. Millions more were supposedly earmarked for Laurent Platini, the son of the president of the European Football Association—and were to be paid around the time that *FIFA* announced that Qatar had been chosen to host the World Cup. (Both Bruni and Platini deny receiving any payments. Lévy sued for defamation, calling the documents fake, but lost his case and a subsequent appeal; a French court noted, "The journalists acted with sufficient caution and factual basis.")

The reporters, Bernard Nicolas and Thierry Gadault, believed that the files had been hacked by Project Raven, a long-running surveillance operation

conducted by Emirati intelligence. Their report was the first in a series of articles that accused Qatar of making payoffs to more than a dozen figures. Udi Levi followed the installments with growing interest. He had recently been hired as a consultant for families of Syrian victims of terrorism, who were suing a Qatari bank in the U.K. for sponsoring the terror group Jabhat al-Nusra. But half of the claimants dropped their suit, and Levi maintained that they were being threatened or paid off. (The defendants denied any interference.) “I was caught up in a crazy cycle of Qatari bribery neutralizing the prosecution,” Levi told me. The alleged payoffs he was reading about in *Blast* “fit like a glove.”

That October, *Blast* published a piece suggesting that, in 2012, Qatar’s Prime Minister had ordered his finance minister to provide “financial-aid packages” to two Israeli politicians. Fifteen million dollars were to be paid to “Mr. Benjamin Netanyahu, Chairman of Likud.” Five million dollars were to go to Avigdor Lieberman, who headed the right-wing Yisrael Beiteinu Party. The two men ran on a joint ticket that year. The money, the order said, was for the “upcoming election campaign.” A subsequent letter, bearing the signature of the head of the Qatar Central Bank, seemed to confirm the transfer. (Both men have denied receiving funds from Qatar.)

As Levi examined the documents, he says, “a red light went on in my head.” The timing of the payments corresponded with unusual shifts in Netanyahu’s policies. The transfer from 2012 came a few days before Israel announced the end of a military operation in Gaza; not long after, Netanyahu effectively acquiesced to Sheikh Hamad’s visit. *Blast* also published documents detailing the alleged transfer of an additional fifty million dollars to Netanyahu in 2018. A letter from Qatar’s finance minister to the Emir’s office noted that the money “will be delivered in cash to the State Security Service.” This order came ten days before Qatar’s first cash transfer to Gaza.

Levi wondered whether the alleged payments had been reported elsewhere. He discovered that, two years earlier, the popular Egyptian newspaper *Youm7* had run a brief article. Citing “knowledgeable Arab sources,” it described a twenty- million-dollar transfer from Qatar to Likud for a campaign in 2012 and another fifty million dollars six years later—the same amounts in the *Blast* files.

Levi knew that the reports could easily have been based on forged documents. There was no shortage of state actors with an interest in discrediting Qatar and Netanyahu; it could have been the Egyptians, or the Emiratis, or Iran. Still skeptical, he conducted a forensic examination of the files. The Qatari names had the correct honorifics and salutations, he told me; the signatures matched the originals, though some looked digital. Perhaps most interestingly, the documents bore serial numbers. Levi later gained access to a cache of Qatari documents from roughly the same period, which Syrian hackers had taken from the offices of the Sheikh, among others. The serial numbers on those documents appeared to align with the sequence of the *Blast* files, forming a consistent chronological progression. “Everything seemed to match,” Levi recalls thinking.

The Qatari government adamantly denies making any payments. “The pattern is familiar: fake official documents are circulated to the media to support sensational claims about Qatar, only to fall apart when subjected to meaningful scrutiny,” the spokesman said. “We have strong evidence that, for several years, various parties, including elements of Israel’s far right, have been involved in circulating fabricated documents through the media in an effort to incriminate Qatar.”

A week after the first *Blast* piece ran, Qatar announced that its former minister of finance, Ali Sherif al-Emadi, had been arrested; he was subsequently sentenced to twenty years in prison for bribery and abuse of power. As news of the *Blast* allegations spread, Levi says, “I expected an earthquake.” For a time, Israeli journalists tried to follow up, but it soon became clear that there would be no conclusive proof of the documents’ authenticity. The files didn’t contain bank-account details, and, even if Qatar had ordered the transfers, there was no evidence that Netanyahu had actually received the money.

Still, some former security officials thought that the claims warranted a serious investigation. “You can’t *not* investigate it,” Roni Alsheikh, the former deputy director of the Shin Bet, told *Telem*. “These are suspicions of the highest level.” Yet there has been no official investigation related to the *Blast* files. Netanyahu dismissed the allegations, and is suing Levi and several other Israelis who have made similar charges. (His attorney has

postponed hearings in one case so frequently that a judge finally fined Netanyahu and forced him to settle on a date this December.)

In the immediate aftermath of the October 7th attacks, Levi urged the hostage families to pressure the Israeli government to threaten Qatar with war if their loved ones “were not returned within forty-eight hours.” Instead, he watched with outrage as the Qataris took the lead on negotiations. He was not alone in his alarm. Yigal Carmon, a conservative retired colonel in Israeli military intelligence and the founder of *MEMRI*, a research center that monitors media across the Muslim world, had spent years insisting that Qatar was a sponsor of terrorism. In December, two months after the attacks, he republished the *Blast* files as part of a report warning about Qatar’s expanding influence. (Netanyahu is suing him, too.) When I met Carmon at *MEMRI*’s office in Jerusalem, he gestured at a framed photograph showing a Hamas chief shaking hands with a Qatari Emir. “Hamas is Qatar, Qatar is Hamas,” he said.



Soon after Carmon published the report, he became embroiled in a peculiar fraud. He was introduced to a man named Matthew Cohen, who he was led to believe had C.I.A. connections. In the following months, Cohen arranged for a source to sell Carmon two batches of documents, from Qatar’s finance ministry and Jordan’s anti-fraud authority, that he claimed corroborated the

Blast files. Carmon raised a hundred and twenty-five thousand dollars to purchase the documents, then published them online.

Levi, who has known Carmon for years, says that he called him as soon as he saw the files. “Yigal, are you crazy?” he asked. The documents should have raised immediate suspicion: they lacked the appropriate letterheads and serial numbers associated with those offices. The cache also included a copy of a ten-million-dollar check purportedly written by a company with ties to Netanyahu to a company associated with Hamas—yet a simple Google search showed that the check had the same number as one on an online template.

Levi urged Carmon to take the post down, but the damage had already been done. In July, 2024, the financial newspaper *TheMarker* reported that there was a booming trade in forged documents in Israel. The article mentioned the *Blast* files alongside the Cohen trove, suggesting that all the documents were fake. Matthew Cohen—who has also gone by Jason Goose—played his own part in discrediting the files. He bragged to the press that the documents were forged and that Carmon didn’t care. When I spoke with Cohen recently, he didn’t seem to regret the scam. “The whole concept of espionage is deception,” he told me.

Last April, a similar operation targeted Eliad Shraga, a prominent lawyer associated with Israel’s anti-government protest movement. An ultra-Orthodox private investigator named Avi Lehrer called Shraga and claimed to have bank records showing that Netanyahu and his family held millions of dollars in offshore accounts. Lehrer arranged a meeting to sell him the files—then never showed up. Instead, a recording of their conversation surfaced on Channel 14, a pro-Netanyahu television network. Lehrer later posted the segment on social media, tagging Yair Netanyahu, the Prime Minister’s son.

Lehrer has boasted in private about his connections with the Netanyahu family. Last year, he and Cohen met in Miami. During the meeting, which was first reported by *TheMarker*, Lehrer said that he had done “favors” for both Yair and his father, and had got work in return. (Yair has disputed this.)

Levi argues that the *Blast* files were deliberately compromised to distract from their contents. “It’s a well-known method—flood the scene with a lot

of fake evidence until the entire investigation is contaminated,” he said. Alsheikh, the former Shin Bet deputy director, agreed: “Someone was interested not in strengthening the message but in shutting it down.”

A month after the *Bild* publication, Feldstein had a remarkable encounter with his employers. One night, Netanyahu’s chief of staff, Tzachi Braverman, summoned him to a parking lot underneath the I.D.F. headquarters, in Tel Aviv. When Feldstein arrived, around midnight, Braverman got into his car and asked him to surrender his phone to an aide standing outside. With the car secured, Braverman said he’d heard rumors that the I.D.F. had opened an investigation into a document leak. Braverman told Feldstein that he could “shut it down.” (Braverman denies this, and says that he can’t recall whether he met with Feldstein that night.)

It didn’t work. Feldstein was arrested three weeks later, and, in November, 2024, he was indicted for leaking the top-secret document to *Bild*, an offense that carries a maximum sentence of life in prison. Yet investigators have struggled to connect Einhorn and Urich with either the *Bild* case or Qatargate. A day after Feldstein’s arrest, Urich deleted his phone’s text history. (He said that he had bought a new phone.) Einhorn had relocated with his family to Serbia, and refused to return for questioning.

By this summer, prosecutors had finally added Urich to the *Bild* indictment and named Einhorn as a suspect in the case. But the progress of the Qatargate investigation remained uncertain. When Ronen Bar, the head of the Shin Bet, sought to expand the probe, Netanyahu moved to fire him. Bar resigned soon afterward, saying that he was being pushed out because of the investigation. (Netanyahu denies this.) The move was “particularly troubling,” Bar wrote in an affidavit, “given the extremely serious suspicions of harm to national security.” To replace Bar, Netanyahu selected a retired major general named David Zini—despite opposition from four former Shin Bet directors and hundreds of employees, who warned that Zini was a Netanyahu ally who would prioritize loyalty over the rule of law.

Israel’s attorney general cautioned that the appointment was mired in conflicts of interest, and insured that the Qatargate investigation would continue. But the investigation was completed months ago, and no indictments have yet been made. The Shin Bet has since circulated an

opinion among security officials, suggesting that the conduct of Netanyahu's aides did not amount to a national-security threat. A law-enforcement source told *Haaretz* that the serious allegations remain unchanged: "The only thing that changed was the person at the top of the Shin Bet."

In March, Netanyahu cleared his schedule to give public testimony about Qatargate. By all accounts, the aide he was most intent on protecting was Urich. He testified that he didn't know Urich had been working for Qatar. Even if he had known, he added, "There is nothing wrong with that. Qatar is not an enemy state." (Six months later, Netanyahu ordered a strike on Doha during a meeting of Hamas leaders, after which Trump forced him to make a public apology to the Qatari Emir.)

Urich is being represented by Netanyahu's personal attorney, and Likud is reportedly financing his defense. Netanyahu also staged a supportive photo opportunity: on a blustery evening, he embraced Urich outside his office in Jerusalem, and the two men walked away hand in hand, while cameras flashed. By then, Urich had gone back to work for the Prime Minister. He had also signalled a redemptive spiritual conversion. After his arrest, he began sporting a thick beard and a large black kippah associated with the Chabad-Lubavitch movement. He recently wrote on a Chabad site that the late Lubavitcher Rebbe had "delivered a message to me in prison."

But every day in Israel, it seems, brings fresh accusations against the Prime Minister's office. Even the right-wing daily *Israel Hayom* recently ran a front-page story alleging that Urich and the other advisers had passed classified information to Qatar (something they denied). The election, scheduled for October 27th, will be the first one since the Hamas attack and the war that has shattered Israel's standing in the world. Earlier this year, sixty-one per cent of Israelis described the Qatargate affair as "serious." Among voters of Netanyahu's Likud Party, less than a third viewed it that way.

Gadi Eisenkot, a former military chief who is Netanyahu's most serious competitor in the coming election, said he believes that the Prime Minister was aware of his advisers' connections to Qatar. When a voter asked about Qatargate during a campaign stop in August, he answered, "Netanyahu knows what [Urich] did. Anyone who engaged in criminal activity will pay a

very heavy price and, as far as I'm concerned, will sit in prison until their last day."

Feldstein told me that his time in prison was disillusioning. For the first nine days, he was barred from meeting with an attorney. At one point, guards brought a television into his cell, and Feldstein tuned in to "The Patriots," a talk show on Channel 14. He watched as the host displayed family photos of the Feldsteins and played a Hebrew song that he loved, one that his parents had requested. "It gave me a lot of spirit," Feldstein recalled when I met him, in July. "But then I understood that I wasn't the story for them—Bibi was. It was meant to serve his interests, not mine, and that hurt me a little."

We were sitting in his attorney's office on the thirty-sixth floor of a high-rise in the city of Ramat Gan, overlooking the Tel Aviv skyline. Feldstein appeared no different from any other young resident of Tel Aviv. He has a broad, animated face, and wore a T-shirt and jeans; the distinctive black kippah I remembered from photographs was gone. He is a fast talker who stuttered as a child; occasionally, during a three-hour conversation full of recrimination and regret, the stutter returned.

On the fifth day of Feldstein's detention, Netanyahu's office issued a terse statement: "No one from the Prime Minister's office has been arrested or questioned." In the days that followed, Netanyahu suggested that he barely knew who Feldstein was, and that he'd never worked for the Prime Minister. A few weeks later, as Feldstein's attorney was going on Israeli television to publicize the case, Netanyahu defended his former aide as an "Israeli patriot, an ardent Zionist." He later changed course again and described Feldstein as "a nothing."

Feldstein told me that his parents were offered the services of an attorney close to Netanyahu, free of charge, but they refused. Feldstein said that his father argued, "I need a lawyer who will defend my son, not the Prime Minister." The family instead hired Oded Savoray, a prominent litigator who has been outspoken in his opposition to the government. During their first meeting in prison, Savoray told Feldstein that Netanyahu and his advisers were not standing behind him, but Feldstein refused to accept it. Savoray returned the next morning with printouts of news articles showing that

Netanyahu was disavowing him. That day, Savoray recalled, “I saw a broken man.”

Feldstein still awaits trial in the leak case and may be indicted for his part in Qatargate. When I met him, however, he did his best to project confidence. Since his house arrest ended, he has started a strategic-consulting business. Though his notoriety had driven away some prospective clients, he said that his “experience in crisis management” had attracted others. Recently, he ran into a Channel 14 host, who yelled at him for breaking ranks with Netanyahu. “It’s been difficult for my family and also for me personally, because it’s not like I’m here for revenge,” Feldstein said. I asked whether he felt disappointed with Netanyahu. He rose from his chair and began to pace the room. “In some respects yes, and in some respects no,” he said eventually. “At the end of the day, Netanyahu cares about Netanyahu.” ♦

Shouts & Murmurs

- [Why I Free-Solo El Capitan](#)

Shouts & Murmurs

Why I Free-Solo El Capitan

By Mike O'Brien

September 21, 2026



I'm going live right now because I'm, well, about sixteen hundred feet up the side of El Capitan. I currently have no ropes or harnesses on me. Just a chalk bag on my waist belt and a mike pinned to my shirt.

This is my third time doing a free-solo pass at El Capitan. And some of you asked if I'd record my thoughts as I hang by my fingertips over my impending death. I thought, Why not?

And there they go . . . So I just lost my sunglasses. Wait for it . . . I always love that. Anything you lose up here takes ten to twelve seconds to hit the ground. Anyway, I'm rambling on this live stream so I can give people some explanation for why we do this. Maybe even inspire someone to live a better life.

But first, in order to get my next foothold, I'm going to have to rely solely on fingerholds as I swing my foot over to a crevice. I've got a half-crimp

hold with my left hand, and a mono with my right index finger. Aaand I got my toe in the crevice. O.K. Let's find the next one.

That was perfect, actually. Just now, every part of my body and brain was focussed on the task at hand. Otherwise, I'm dead. So it's very relaxing.

You have living, and you have dying. And zero time on life's drama, spam calls, bills . . . Thankfully, debt collectors don't tend to climb El Capitan, last I checked. And if they start to, all of us rock-jocks are in trouble! One second, I don't like this sloper. I'm gonna need to get a better grip. Gonna push off my right leg and see if I can find a pocket up above me. Got one. Feels solid enough . . .

It's the forced unplug for me. Like all of you, my inbox is filled with stressful e-mails, but those will have to wait. Like, "You took all our money blah blah your climbing school is a Ponzi scheme blah blah why did we have to get more students in order to pay the same thing we paid last year?"

O.K., this is a part of the wall I've never done. And I think that's very sick. Or, as some of my friends would call it, very dumb. Especially because some of the rocks are flaking off. Like that one. Damn it.

So all I'm focussed on is: How do I navigate a new path around this chossy area? Goes without saying that right now I'm not worried about some Karens complaining, "Oh, you never taught our kids anything. You were smoking outside while they climbed up a little fifteen-foot-wall thing." Or, "My son fell off your plastic wall and fractured his tailbone. I've informed the police." Well, which is it? Is my climbing wall too small, or are kids fracturing tailbones when they fall from its great heights? Can't be both.

And I hate to be that guy, but there's also no girlfriend when you're on El Cap. Trust me, I love Maya, but I think we both benefit from little breaks. Frankly, anyone would be open to taking a break from someone who lately just screams, "I hate youuuu . . . I've got evidence of what you did! I've got video evidence."

O.K., I'm navigating out of the looser rocks and over to the Dawn Wall, which I've done before. It's steeper, but there's better footing.

Again, present moment taking priority over outside noise. Like the girl I cheated on Maya with *one time*, mind you, texting me, “I deserve half of that climbing-school money because you used all my pillow-talk ideas. Don’t make me destroy you online.” I’m, like, Destroy me how? Ya too late.

And, in some ways, the most stressful text of my morning: “Bro, you know why I’m reaching out. You cheated on my little sister and I don’t need to remind you I’m a Triple O.G. in my set of the Crips. I’ll see you later today when you do your little rock-climb thing.” Top ten suckiest text I’ve ever gotten probably.

So, yeah, in some ways I’d rather be dangling by three fingers than dealing with life’s day-to-day headaches.

Thankfully, Crips don’t tend to climb El Capitan, last I checked. They tend to park at the top and play loud music. Next to the police, apparently. Funny to see those two getting along. Do I get a Nobel Prize for that? Kidding. I’m thinking more about toeholds than whether I’m going to get a Nobel. That’s why I free-solo El Capitan. To not worry about whether I’ll win a Nobel Prize. ♦

Fiction

- [Dark Horse](#)

Fiction

Dark Horse

By Sarah Anderson

September 20, 2026



In my mind, my father is fucking the horse again. From the front, you can hardly tell. She blinks slowly; she is still. A web of thick veins branches up and across her hind leg, tributaries rushing toward one vast river. Behind her is my father, pants around his ankles.

Over time, my brain has refined the loop, adding a warm evening light that silhouettes him as he moves, the rustle of Claudia's hooves against the sticky candy-cane wrappers all over the floor, cast off from the treats he was always giving her. The scene has played out in my head every day for almost three years.

The Thought has a way of sitting in the back of my mind—really sitting there, like it takes up physical space, and it is impossible not to touch it. I have tried, many times. But at least once a day I press it like a bruise, and if I don't it eventually starts to play anyway. The sound of their asynchronous

breathing: Claudia's a deep sigh, a snort, my father's a pant, quick and uneven.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

I believe the vision was born the day I went out to the barn to tell my father that it was time, that my mother was about to die. His hands were on Claudia's flank, his cheek resting against her. He didn't turn around. "I'll be there in a minute," he said, and didn't come. Not for hours, not until the coroner had arrived to take away the body.

My father acquired Claudia in the early nineties, when he worked for the Bureau of Land Management in Wyoming. It was there that he learned about the Horses and Burros Act of 1971, which declared wild horses "living symbols of the historic and pioneer spirit of the West" and made it a federal crime to kill them. In the years following the Act, the wild-horse population exploded, wreaking havoc on the land and leaving the horses to fight it out with one another or starve. Slaughterhouses in the U.S. shuttered, and the government contracted cowboys to round up the horses into pens, spending millions every year to keep them alive.

The act is a topic about which my father can speak at great length. The ways in which it has failed to do what it set out to—protect the horses—the ways it is not more humane at all, really, and its secondary sin: that it is carried out in *his* name; i.e., at taxpayer expense. "If I were President," my father often says, "the first thing I would do is overturn the Horses and Burros Act." And, gathering steam, "The real problem is that Americans can't look themselves in the face anymore. Everyone wants to be Jane fucking Goodall, but without getting their hands dirty."

All through the night in those years with the B.L.M., my father helped do population surveys from helicopters, counting the white-heat outlines on a screen in the dark—ghost horses, the ones that had escaped the gatherers. During the day, he inspected the government holding facilities.

The first time my father saw Claudia, she was one of hundreds of warehoused young horses in a crowded pen. She was never a particularly attractive horse, nor particularly charismatic, in my opinion. But while my

father was standing at the fence, back turned, she wandered up and bit him on the ear, and that was that. He offered to buy her at auction, but the manager gave her to him for free, since it would save the government thousands of dollars in food and upkeep.

My father named the horse after the model Claudia Schiffer, who had been in the news recently for dating a high-profile magician. He took the horse home to the house he had just bought with my mother, who was about to give birth to me. “You shoulda seen the legs on Claudia when she was young,” he would say wistfully, and I never could tell which Claudia he was talking about.

Podcast: The Writer’s Voice

[*Listen to Sarah Anderson read “Dark Horse.”*](#)

As a teen-ager, when I couldn’t sleep, I would spend hours looking at every photo of Claudia Schiffer I could find. When I think of her now, I see the 1991 Spanish *Playboy* cover. In the photo, she kneels in wet sand in a pair of unzipped shorts, breasts poised to break free of the arm across her chest at any moment.

My mother did not look anything like Claudia Schiffer. She was brunette, and thick in the calves. At the end, she had no breasts to speak of, and, if she had, no one would have wanted to look at them anyway.

Horses are easy to injure but difficult to kill. Occasionally, euthanasia doesn’t take—some alchemy in their huge bodies fighting sedation. It’s also expensive, and sometimes a horse will react poorly, stumble around and fall hard, tongue lolling.

The other option is a bullet. It is less expensive, because the cost is the cost of a bullet. But you still have to figure out what to do with the body. At a slaughterhouse, they will shoot the horse for free and pay you a couple thousand dollars for the meat. You can guess which option my father chose when the time came.

For a long while, my father did not acknowledge the fact that Claudia was in the twilight of her life. Not when the tendons in her legs started causing too

much pain for her to walk some days. Not when she shifted her weight back onto her heels, a telltale sign of hoof disease, from age and too much sugar. Not as her compulsions, which he called “her habits,” escalated and she began cribbing, a repetitive behavior in which she grasped the fence with her front teeth and yanked her head back, grunting. “Hey, lady,” my father would say softly. “Just relax.”

“The internet said we should try putting herbal tea in her feed,” he told me early one morning when I came into the kitchen to start the coffee, before my shift at the dentist’s office.

“Who?” I said, still half asleep.

“What do you mean ‘who’? Claudia. To help with her habits.”

He ordered camomile in bulk, but Claudia kept cribbing. The fence started to splinter, and her teeth started to wear. They had never been great to begin with. My mother had insisted on brushing them regularly, making me hold up Claudia’s rubbery top lip so she could reach every one of the yellowed, stonelike teeth. Even when my mother was too sick to go anywhere else, we went to the barn together once a week. The task seemed to soothe her. “Better?” she asked at the end of a session. “Much,” I said, in the affected mid-Atlantic accent she and I would use to channel Claudia. Lately, my father and I had been lax with the brushing.

In June, four months into the camomile regimen, a particularly loud plane from the military base flew overhead. The sound of it spooked Claudia so much that she ran the length of the fence back and forth for more than an hour, until she could no longer bear weight on her right front knee. At first, my father stood by the fence trying to calm her, calling to her and offering food, but eventually he went back into the house and sat in his armchair in front of the TV, without turning it on. “I can’t reason with her,” he said, shaking his head. A few hours later, when she finally lay down in the paddock, still shivering, skin rippling, I watched through the window as he went to her, wrapping his fingers in her mane and whispering something. He led her slowly back to the barn, and I didn’t see him again until the next morning, when I found him back in the armchair, slivers of hay clinging to his shirt.

That day, the day he finally realized he could no longer keep Claudia alive, my father declared that together we would drive her seven hundred miles to the Mexican border, where slaughterhouses abound.

“Please,” I said. “Please, can we just call the vet?”

“Claudia hates the vet, and I do, too,” he said. “He’s smarmy. I don’t want him to be the last thing she sees. And besides, I like the idea of her body being put to use. She would want that.” I felt the Thought coming on, felt myself drifting into the blurry space between thinking about the Thought and actually having it.

“You do it then,” I said. “You take her.”

“Dylan can come,” he said.

I paused. It felt like he was suggesting something drastic and incongruous. Taking our mailman on a cruise. Bringing a cat to a christening. My boyfriend, Dylan, existed in a different part of my brain from both Claudia and my father, and frankly I sometimes forgot him completely. But my father was right; Dylan loved both road trips and concrete tasks. He was an acts-of-service guy. My father sensed weakness in my pause and moved in for the kill. “You two can keep the money, make a vacation out of it. Should be almost three thousand dollars, for a horse like her.”

It was pointless to argue with my father when he was like this. And I needed the money, having spent all I had finishing the dental-hygiene program at the community college the previous year.

“Fine,” I said.

“We’ll leave Saturday,” he called as I stormed out of the kitchen. I made it to the porch before the Thought reared its head, my father and the barn and the click of his belt buckle, and I wished desperately that I could hate him the normal way.

In the five days before the journey, my father threw together his version of a hospice program. He fed Claudia all the things she liked most—red Skittles and candy canes and strawberries. Her favorite color was red, he explained.

“She’s glamorous like that.” Every January, for as long as I could remember, we’d gone to the post-Christmas sales at the dollar store and at Walmart and bought up all the candy canes on clearance. Only the peppermint. “None of those bullshit pussy flavors,” my father said, glaring at a pack of multicolored Sour Patch Kids-flavored canes.

He also sprayed my Calvin Klein perfume around the stable, because he had heard a radio story about how animals like it. I tried to explain to him that it was just big cats. “Because of civetone,” I said. “It’s a pheromone, from the anal glands of a civet.”

“You don’t think Claudia can appreciate a good smell?” he said. I started hiding my perfume in a Tampax box behind the mirror. He used what was left of my mother’s Chanel No. 5 instead.

My mother took up drinking when she became a lost cause, and I took it up with her, in solidarity. I didn’t have the balls to shave my head, or anything like that, so I did what I could. I did not let her get fucked up alone.

We spent most of her last months drunk on the porch together, me sneaking inside to get another bottle of gin without my father seeing. “Did you get it?” she’d whisper, and I’d whip it out from behind my back or from up my shirt and we’d crack up. At some point in the night, when we weren’t really talking anymore, just looking out at the fireflies glimmering in the throats of the plants, we would light up her chemo weed. She watched me smoke the jay down, and then, when the only thing I could hear was cicadas, I set the still-lit joint on a little blue plate we kept outside for that purpose and went into the house. She had so few private moments by then, her body everyone’s business. I could give her this: let her smoke it alone, like a secret.

Inside, I forced myself to stay awake and listen for her footsteps. Sometimes she fell asleep out on the porch, and I would half carry her to the bed, which was empty, my father having moved to the guest room. “She sleeps better that way, and she needs her rest now,” he said. “We both do.”

My mother stopped drinking when she died, but I kept going, for both of us.

The thing about constantly seeing the image of your father fucking a horse is that there are very few people you can tell about it. Practically none.

The summer after my mother died, I used some of the money she had left me to go to Australia. I went because it was as far away as possible and because I wanted to learn to scuba dive. I had just started having the Thought, and I was hoping it would go away with travel and new experiences, such as going to the bottom of the ocean.

My father thought it would be good for me to spend some time on my own. He had noticed that I had been acting strangely around him, struggling to make eye contact, and I suspected he had found my stash of empties in the cupboard under the bathroom sink. “Go,” he said. “Get right with God.”

“I will,” I said, though I didn’t know what he meant by that, or how to approach doing it. I had never known him to be religious.

In Australia, I met a man, a boy, really, twenty-one and insufferable. “I’m young, but I’ve just done so much with my life already,” he said to me at our hostel’s wine-and-cheese night, in a packed, dingy common room. “I hate you,” I thought with a little thrill of pleasure, washing down a sweaty cube of cheddar with red blend. The next morning, he caught me on my way to breakfast, and soon he began accompanying me on every excursion.

It wasn’t until the third day, as we waited for a bus on an island known for its wild koala population, that he revealed to me that he had been a child star on a popular TV show my mother had been a fan of. His character flaws suddenly crystallized in a highly satisfying way.

On our last day together, the former child star suggested we go to a nude beach, falling over himself to explain that it was not sexual in any way, merely an experience he wanted to have.

“Sure,” I said. Naked with the child star. My mother wouldn’t even believe it.

“If you’re not comfortable with it . . .” he said.

“I’m fine with it.” He seemed disappointed by my readiness.

At the beach, there was a sign with images of four jellyfish in order of escalating concern, from unpleasant sting to instant death. Next to it was a sign that read “Clothing Optional.” We walked to a small cove, stripped down without looking at each other, and waded awkwardly into the shallows, sitting down on the sandy bottom. I was lulled by the heat and the shifting patterns of sunlight in the water. As often happened when I began to relax, I felt the Thought shift restlessly in a corner of my brain.

“Do you ever have really fucked-up thoughts?” I found myself saying to the former child star, before I could stop myself.

“Probably,” he said. “Like what?”

“Like sex stuff.”

“Like choking?”

“Maybe,” I said. “Or, like, fucking animals.” I said it in a weird voice that was meant to be jokey but wasn’t.

“Not really, but people do all kinds of shit. My friend showed me a whole website of it. Really sick stuff.”

“Were there horses?”

“Oh, yeah,” he said. “Sheep, too. Everything.”

We fell silent, and I closed my eyes. When I opened them, his face was close to mine. He gazed at me a moment, then leaned in.

“What are you doing?”

“Can I kiss you?” he asked.

“No,” I said. “Why would you ask that?”

“We’re at a nude beach together,” he said. “We’ve spent the past four days hanging out. You asked me for a piggyback on the way here.”

“I’m sorry,” I said, but I wasn’t. “There’s been a misunderstanding.”

He looked out at the horizon for a moment, then abruptly stood. “Well,” he said. “At least I’m not a fucking pervert.” He splashed back to shore, pale ass shining in the sunlight.

That night, I attended a free sound bath at the hostel, run by a thin British woman, who had given me a towel at check-in. The child star was already there, in butterfly position, ostentatiously meditating.

“Feel the rise and fall of the breath entering and exiting your body,” the British woman said, as she began to work the bowls. “If any thoughts do arise, allow them to pass through you like clouds in the sky.”

At the sound of its name, the Thought rolled over but remained silent. Instead, I found myself thinking over and over, “The antidote to jellyfish is vinegar.” I wished it was my own original thought, but I was fairly sure it was just from that cautionary sign at the beach. To my right, the child star was taking very loud, deep breaths and emitting low “om”s.

“You will likely find yourself feeling a bit raw for the rest of the night,” the woman said, when the bowls quieted, as she opened a beaded tip box. “And experiencing strange dreams.” I wished she had mentioned this beforehand.

That night, as I fell asleep, I thought I had finally done it. Escaped the Thought for an entire day. That maybe telling the child star had done something after all. Purged it. But then I dreamed it instead.

For the first time, it wasn’t happening inside the barn but on the nude beach, little sprinkles of sand in Claudia’s mane and stuck in the hairs around her prehensile lips, as if she had been grazing at the water’s edge. Dead jellyfish littered the shoreline, a pile of them at my father’s feet.

I did not tell anyone about the Thought again.

The morning of the drive, Claudia did not want to get into the trailer. My father went through the last two boxes of candy canes trying to coax her in, step by step. Dylan stood off to the side watching YouTube how-tos and offering nuggets of wisdom. “This guy says the issue is either about fear or

lack of respect,” he said. “We’re supposed to act as much as possible like the trailer isn’t there.” Eventually, I sent him to the garage to look for the extra set of jumper cables, which we kept in the barn.

When Claudia finally climbed into the trailer, my father jumped down and turned to me. “We need to be prepared to ask them to shoot her in front of us. So that—” He broke off midsentence. “Stop doing that,” he said sharply.

“Doing what?”

He gestured at his chest, cupping his hands in the universal symbol for tits. Lately, my right hand had developed a mind of its own, wandering up my body and across my chest, gently palpating my breast tissue in moments of distraction. Two fingers pushing inward, seeking abnormalities. The worst part was that I didn’t even notice it anymore. Like nail-biting. I dropped my hand back to my side. “Sorry,” I said. “Go on.”

“To make sure they do it right,” he said, and walked back toward the house.

For the first two hours, Dylan drove, and we were quiet, the sun climbing higher and warming the car as I drifted in and out of sleep in the front seat, twitching awake every so often to check the trailer in the mirrors. My father sat in the back, staring out the window, an odd, blank look on his face.

At hour five, Dylan turned on a podcast about sustainable building practices and tiny homes, put the car in cruise control, and started eating pistachios, cracking them open and dropping the shells into his empty coffee cup. Sleep became impossible. I knew he was thinking about what we could do with Claudia’s blood money.

“Are you listening to this?” Dylan said. “It’s a lot easier than people think to build your own house. It’s actually really intuitive.”

“Can we stop soon?” I asked. “I have to pee.”

“Already?” my father groaned from the back seat. As we whizzed past several promising exits, I distracted myself by making a themed playlist, which I could only hope might nip the podcasts in the bud and discourage conversation.

At a 7-Eleven on the border of Colorado and New Mexico, I peered into the trailer's little upper window to check on Claudia. She was sweating, her muscles twitching slightly. "We're almost there," I told her. "Keep your shit together for a few more hours and you're home free." I pictured her in Heaven, a silent, peppermint-scented place. "God loves horses," I added.

Inside, I bought a cherry Slurpee, then quickly went back to the truck to locate the two airplane bottles of vodka Dylan kept in the glove compartment. They were tucked next to the first-aid kit, as though he thought he might one day need to perform a field surgery. I poured both through the straw hole of my cup to create a delicious cocktail and returned the empties to their place.



My father emerged shortly afterward with a rope of bison jerky, Dylan with three oversized Rice Krispies bars.

"Are you kidding me?" I said, as Dylan climbed back in.

"What?"

"Do you even know what those are made of?"

He started the car.

“Horse!” I said. “Hooves or some shit. Everybody knows that’s what marshmallow is made of.”

“There’s no way,” Dylan said.

“Gelatin,” I said once he was driving again. “Look it up.”

“You look it up.”

“I don’t need to. I know I’m right.”

“I really don’t think Claudia cares,” Dylan said.

“Gelatin is an extremely useful product,” my father said. “And versatile.”

“Have some respect,” I said, and went back to my playlist.

“A Horse with No Name.” “Black Horse and the Cherry Tree.” “Wild Horses,” by the Rolling Stones, Natasha Bedingfield, and Garth Brooks. “The Funeral,” by Band of Horses. That one was going to hit hard closer to the border.

Less than an hour later, my father asked where we would be stopping for lunch.

“We’re not stopping,” I told him. “We just stopped. You got food.” I sucked on my straw, hitting the vodka slush at the bottom of the giant cup, each sip a different combination of metallic and sweet.

“I’m hungry,” he said. “I had one piece of jerky. We have at least five hours left.”

“No.”

“Dylan, keep an eye out for an exit,” my father said. “Jesus, what’s the rush? Claudia gets carsick. She could use a break. Horses can’t vomit, you know. So she has to just suffer through it.”

“We’re not stopping,” I said.

Twenty-five minutes later, I was sitting across from my father at a Red Lobster. He was thoughtfully paging through the menu and trying to persuade Dylan to go in on a Shrimp Your Way with him.

“Do you like coconut?” he asked.

“Just a Bahama Mama for me,” I told our server, a pallid young man called Zachary.

“And to eat?” he asked.

“That will be all,” I said.

“Don’t they have cheesecake here?” my father asked, frowning at the last page of the menu. “Isn’t that their thing?”

“I think you’re thinking of the Cheesecake Factory,” I told him.

“Do not patronize me,” he said. “I mean it.”

When my drink came, my father dipped his fingers into it without asking, to fish out the cherries for Claudia. I slapped his hand away. When his food came, the Thought and I watched him bite into the veiny pink flesh of the shrimp, discarding the tails into a little pile, and I excused myself from the table. I had resisted the Thought all day, and pressure was building in that corner of my mind. In the parking lot, I opened the side hatch of the trailer to let Claudia stick her head out. She nuzzled my face, an act of tenderness quite unlike her. Her breath was atrocious.

Around hour seven, my father finally fell asleep, chin tucked to his chest like a giant toddler. Dylan checked the rearview mirror to insure he was out before asking if we could please talk about the money now. He was of the opinion that we should use it to seed a joint savings account, with which we would one day buy a tract of land somewhere, on which we would build our own homestead by hand. He had attempted some version of this with his first wife. It had not gone well. We had been fighting proxy wars about this plan since he first presented it, mostly through opposing allegiances with halves of the couples who tour houses on “Property Brothers.”

Dylan had been married twice before, and the second marriage was still in the process of dissolution, from a legal standpoint. He talked about the marriages as if some act of God had ended both of them. Like they were casualties of an earthquake, or a drunk-driving accident. "Sometimes it makes me so sad that I'll never see her again," he once said, on the topic of his first wife.

"Why can't you see her again?" I asked. "Doesn't she still live really close to us?" He ignored me.

"You go from knowing a person so well. To, all of a sudden, nothing. Hard to grasp the permanence of it all, really."

"Gee, I can't even imagine."

"It's tough," he said, without any sense of irony. "Hard to even find the words."

In the car, he fiddled with the air-conditioning. "Did you hear me?" he asked.

"No," I said.

"Well, what do you want to do with it?"

"Stop scraping teeth," I said. "And live alone." He dropped it.

I wondered if, once we were rid of Claudia, the loss would feel permanent. If I might finally be free of the Thought, of my father's pistoning hips. Outside, the landscape was opening up, drying out, turning from trees to scrub. My tongue was still red from the Slurpee, like a slab of raw meat inside my mouth. I guess that's basically what a tongue is, technically speaking. I saw it in the side mirror while I was singing: "At every occasion, I'll be ready for the funeral." The song ended and started over, and I became aware that it had been on repeat for a while, that my hand was on my breast. I had lost track of time.

I palpated clockwise, like the internet told me to. Imagine the face of a clock over your breast, or the slices of a pie, it said. If my tits were a pie, I think

they would be one of the nutty ones. Pecan. Or maybe Key lime. If my tits were from a state, they would definitely be from Florida.

“Dylan,” I said.

“Unh,” he said, just a sound at the back of his throat. He was pouting.

“Dylan.”

“What,” he said, not like a question.

“Dimpling, puckering, or skin that looks like an orange peel.”

“What?”

“Dimpling, puckering, or skin that looks like an orange peel. That’s what you should look for. Not just lumps.”

“Cool.”

“Could you maybe not be sarcastic when I’m telling you I might have cancer?”

“You don’t have to indulge the behavior, son,” my father piped up from the back seat, apparently awake now. “You can tell her no.”

Dylan sighed and ignored him. “I’m not being sarcastic, babe. We just checked last night.”

“No, really,” I said. “It’s dimpling. Give me your hand.”

He centered his left hand on the wheel then gave me his right, feeling my breast for the obligatory minute. “Nothing,” he said. “I don’t feel anything. There’s nothing there.” I squeezed the flesh again, then pinched it, trying to make the dimple reappear, the skin growing red and angry. But I couldn’t.

“Christ,” my father said.

Once, I had made my mother check a red bump on my vulva. She had grown tired of listening to me try to describe it. “Just show me,” she said. I sat on the closed toilet seat and opened my legs. “Ingrown hair,” she said immediately.

“Are you sure?”

“I’m sure.”

“Sorry,” I said. “For making you look.”

“Oh, sweetie,” she said. “I changed your diapers.”

Out the window, scrub had given way to desert. The ground was a deep orange now, the color of thirst. I thought about a world where my mother sat on the toilet seat instead of me, where I stood in front of her, or my father did, and we told her to raise her arms above her head, and we put our hands where she told us to and said, “Yeah, I feel it.”

To understand horses, you must start by understanding that they are always afraid. I was never able to love Claudia, but, as a creature driven by fear, I could understand her.

“A horse is all about flight,” my father often said, when he was railing against the Horses and Burros Act. He was always quoting from this book about how animals make us more human, or something to that effect. He was especially proud of himself for reading it, because the author had autism.

Around the eleventh hour of our journey, as the sun was beginning to set, an unsettling banging started coming from the trailer. Claudia hitting her face against the wall, maybe, or cribbing on the metal window bars. I checked the mirrors, then the back seat. My father was asleep again, having exhausted all delay tactics. Asking to stop for a Coke, to check the trailer hitch, to see the World’s Largest Pistachio. I suspected that he, too, had ordered something to take the edge off at the Lobster, after I had left.

Dylan and I both tried to ignore the sound, but it got louder and more regular. “Pull over,” I said.

“We’re so close,” Dylan said. “It’s going to get dark soon. She’s fine.”

“Pull the fuck over,” I said, and something in my voice made him listen. He pulled into a gas station six miles from the border. He slammed his door and headed for the convenience store with long, angry strides. My father stirred, mumbling something and frowning.

I went around to the back. One of Claudia’s wild eyes was pressed to the window, like how I imagined a squid might peer into a submarine. The eye rolled slightly. My father appeared at my side. “What’s going on?” he asked, his voice rough with sleep, then turned to Claudia without waiting for an answer. “Hey, lady,” he said, softening his tone. “I’m here. I’m right here.” His voice broke, and I saw tears on his cheeks. This man who had stood dry-eyed as we put his wife in the ground.

He opened the door and Claudia started backing up frantically, then became frightened by the sound of her own feet clanging on the metal. “Whoa,” my father said. He jumped up behind her and pushed hard against her hindquarters to get her back in. He grunted with the effort of it, put his hips into it, and Claudia gave a snort. “Good girl,” he said, as she took a step forward. “Just like that.” I felt a wave of nausea as he slammed the door and turned to me. “I’m going to see if they have peppermint candies in there,” he said. “Keep talking to her. Make sure she knows she’s not alone.” As he walked away from us, Claudia started cribbing again, biting down on the metal bars and throwing her head back, grunting with pleasure or pain. Blood on her lips. Another name for cribbing is windsucking. It sounds nicer that way. Something you do because you want to, not because you have to. The Thought had hardened to a knot behind my eyes. It pulsed with the sound of her teeth against metal. Bite, grunt. Bite, grunt.

Finally, the pulsing gave way to a rushing in my head, like I’d stood up too fast, and then I was back in the barn. It was night, lit only by the floodlights at the back of the house, flickering in a storm of moths. The smell of dust and wood, cut with some animal thing. My father thrusting behind Claudia, a moving shadow. In front, asleep at Claudia’s feet, was my mother in a nightgown, her body as small as a child’s. When my father emerged, he stood over her, trying to rouse her, to get her to stand. “Good girl,” he said. “Just like that,” as she awoke, rolling clumsily onto her knees.

As I came out of it, I found myself standing with one hand curled around the warm metal of the trailer's door handle, the other on my breast. The sun was bleeding now, too, color pooling in every crevice of the sky, and Claudia was still going at it. Bite, grunt. Bite, grunt. *Make sure she knows she's not alone*, my father said.

I flung the door wide open. Claudia released the metal bars and looked suspiciously over her shoulder at the open door.

"Go," I told her. "Go. Get out of here." She blinked.

"We're trying to kill you," I said. "You have to save yourself."

Still, she refused to move.

And so I climbed in with her. I put my lips next to her hollow, pointed ears, two furred halves of a papaya, and screamed. She bolted, stumbling backward out of the trailer and running across the parking lot. At the Mobil sign, she tripped, steadied herself, and turned right, galloping down the center of the empty road.

The door to the convenience store burst open, and Dylan emerged, the glint of a blue-foil Rice Krispies Treat in his hand and my father on his heels. Dylan froze a few feet from the door, squinting at the scene. My father pushed past him and charged toward me, his face contorted in a way I had only ever seen in my mind. We locked eyes for the second that it took for him to process the empty trailer and then Claudia, at least a hundred yards up the road now and fading fast. Her body so quickly becoming silhouette. In that second, I saw the future: the long white grin of a horse skull picked clean, smiling with all of its teeth. The strange siren call of coyotes gathering in the night. My father, on his knees. Alone.

I screamed again, with the fury of some kind of visionary, some kind of witness, as he took off after her. He looked, for the first time I could remember, old. I stopped only when I was sure he could never catch her.

"I will think of you often," I said, as Claudia disappeared over the horizon. And I did. ♦

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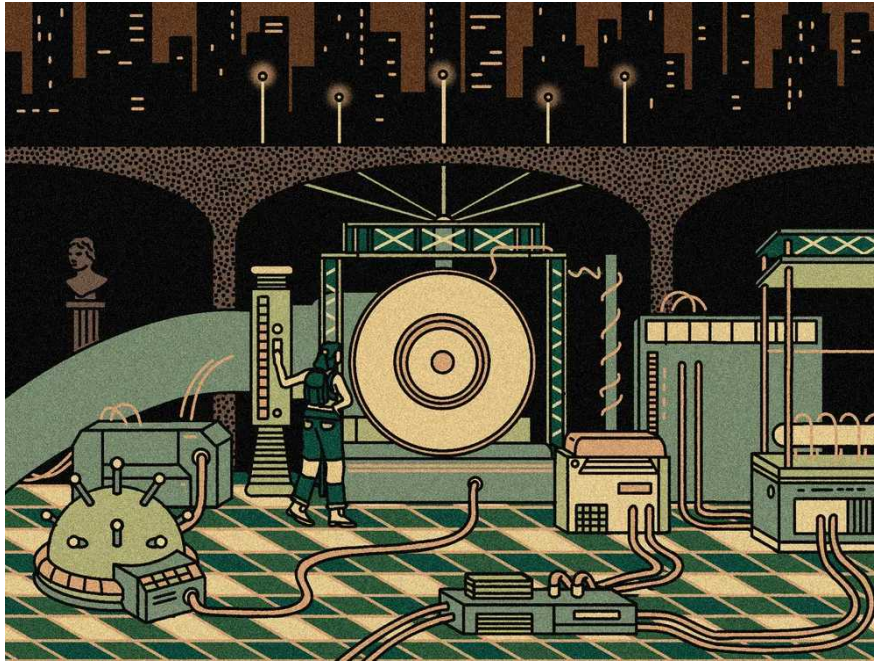
Books

Hernan Diaz's Grand Experiment

In the novel “Ply,” the Pulitzer Prize winner imagines a ruined New York, a fractured society, and the ultimate structure of existence.

By Kathryn Schulz

September 21, 2026



Twenty-five hundred years ago, the Greek philosopher Zeno set about making the case for the counterintuitive claim that all motion is an illusion. Imagine a footrace, he said, between a tortoise and Achilles. As everyone knows, tortoises are gelatinously slow, whereas Achilles, at least per Homer, is famously fleet. So let's grant the tortoise a head start, Zeno declared—say, a hundred yards. Off it lumbers. When it reaches the hundred-yard mark, Achilles starts running and rapidly reaches it, too. By then, however, the tortoise is ten yards farther along, so Achilles must close the new gap. Zeno's point was that this process will never end: to pass the tortoise, Achilles must first get to where it was, but the tortoise will always have moved on, however incrementally—by one yard or 0.1 yard or 0.01 yard, and so on in an infinite sequence. Since you can't complete an infinite

number of steps in a finite amount of time, Zeno concluded, Achilles can never catch up, even though common sense suggests that he swiftly will.

This famous paradox appears twice in “[Ply](#)” (Riverhead), a new novel by the acclaimed Argentinean American writer Hernan Diaz. In a startling departure from his previous two books, which were set in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, “Ply” takes place hundreds of years hence, in a version of New York City rendered almost unrecognizable by the collapse of the United States and the demise of modern democracy. We first hear about Zeno’s paradox when the book’s unnamed protagonist is a child, traumatized by the murder of her father for his alleged role in an incipient political uprising. When her mother tells her the story of Achilles and the tortoise, the girl experiences it less as philosophy than as lullaby—her mother’s way of saying that, although they live in a world without legal or political protections, “no one, no matter how hard they tried, would ever be able to reach us. We would always be a step ahead.”

Years later, when the protagonist is grown, she encounters a scientist named Pola, who pauses while explaining some complex theoretical physics to ask, “I don’t suppose you are familiar with the paradox of Achilles and the tortoise?” Pola recounts that paradox the way the philosopher originally conceived it—as a puzzle about the nature of reality. Although Zeno was wrong about the mathematics of infinity, his hypothetical footrace still captures a fundamental question about the universe: Can space-time, that four-dimensional weft in which all of existence unfolds, be endlessly subdivided? Or is it made up of some ultimate, indivisible particle, like an atom as the ancients imagined it, only unimaginably smaller?

Scientists don’t know the answer, for an intriguing reason: once you divide space-time into small enough units, quantum mechanics and the theory of relativity start contradicting each other, and our understanding of the universe falls apart. In Diaz’s novel, Pola is aware of this, but she believes both that a fundamental particle exists and that she is on the verge of discovering and controlling it, thereby acquiring world-altering powers. Here she is, standing beside a D.I.Y. particle accelerator that she has rigged up in the basement of an abandoned uptown art museum, waxing abstrusely grandiose about her plans:

By accessing this seemingly indivisible, final, discrete unit, we will be able to manipulate the popping bubbles that make up the effervescence of spacetime. Because, to use that other imperfect image, we would be in control of the very knots in the threads that weave the fabric of spacetime itself.

Good luck to her. It's hard enough to be in control of the very knots in the threads that weave the fabric of a novel, and you might as well know up front that this one unravels. On the plus side, unravelling is what "Ply" is about: what is lost, what is gained, and what possibilities emerge when all of our usual laws, societal as well as physical, break down.

Lawlessness is familiar terrain for Diaz. His first novel, the magnificent "[In the Distance](#)," follows one Håkan Söderström, the younger of two brothers growing up in rural Sweden around the eighteen-forties. Diaz sets the plot in motion in three efficient pages: when Håkan's father earns some unexpected money, he buys his sons passage to New York. Their transatlantic journey is slated to begin in Portsmouth, but once there Håkan loses sight of his brother in the crowds along the wharf. Alone and increasingly desperate, the boy goes from pier to pier, asking for a boat that is headed to "Nujårk," a word no one around him understands. Then he tries "Amerika" and is waved onto a ship that sets sail for its destination: San Francisco.

The rest of "In the Distance" is an inverted and eviscerated Western. Hoping to make his way back to his brother, Håkan disembarks in California and immediately heads East, against the flow of all the homesteaders and forty-niners streaming West. As he travels through the United States, he occasionally encounters kindness or wisdom, but he never encounters anything like the rule of law; preëemptive or retaliatory violence is the chief recourse of everyone from prospectors and pioneers to Mormon vigilantes, and the sole sheriff to appear in two thousand miles of wilderness is vicious and corrupt. Eventually, Håkan is forced to participate in this omnipresent bloodshed, at a terrible cost to his soul and his reputation. Soon, he is turned into a myth, wanted across the West for crimes he didn't commit. Now known as the Hawk, a mangling of both the name and the nature of this singularly unpredatory man, he goes into hiding, the dream of New York receding as he is consigned, like an American Moses, to endlessly traversing the desert without entering the promised land.



When Diaz wrote “In the Distance,” he had no agent; he submitted the manuscript in response to a call for new work by Coffee House Press, a nonprofit publisher in Minneapolis. The book came out in 2017; six months later, it was a finalist for the Pulitzer Prize. Diaz won the prize for his second novel, “[Trust](#),” which recounts, in four ways, the story of an astronomically wealthy Roaring Twenties-era financier and his enigmatic wife. The first version is a compact novel-within-a-novel in which this fictional couple is further fictionalized, to an uncertain degree but scandalous effect. The second is the financier’s incomplete autobiography, which he intends as a riposte to the novel but which reads as the kind of boastful yet vacuous legacy burnishing beloved of powerful men in their waning years. The third is a memoir by a woman—part secretary, part ghostwriter—whom the financier hired to help him with the autobiography, while the fourth is a fragment of the final journal of his wife, the largely invisible force who sets the whole story spinning.

If “In the Distance” is about the lawlessness of a region that has not yet cohered into a nation, “Trust” is about a lawlessness more familiar to us today: the exploitable anarchy of the financial markets—in this case during the early twentieth century, when checks on financiers were minimal to nonexistent. Diaz’s main character sees the crash of 1929 coming and shorts the entire stock market, so that, when the economy collapses, his private

fortune soars. It is unclear whether he is lucky, brilliant, or abetted by a keener mind, just as it is unclear whether he is amoral or immoral, or whether he believes his own self-justifying pabulum. (“Profit and common good are but two sides of the same coin.”) As that pervasive uncertainty suggests, “Trust” is also about a kind of literary lawlessness—about whether this novel and its several narrators can be relied on to follow the rules of storytelling.

Despite this thematic overlap, you could read “In the Distance” and “Trust” back-to-back and never guess that they shared an author. Diaz’s first book is simultaneously mythic and intimate; it stays close on Håkan and the vast landscape that he moves through—seldom has the American West been written about more gorgeously—and you are always inside the story, right at its tragic hero’s heels. By contrast, “Trust” is cool and distant; you don’t enter it so much as peer into it, as into a skeleton clock, watching the turning of its gears.

“Ply” continues this trend: although it, too, is concerned with the breakdown of laws, it reads nothing like its predecessors. This is partly because its future setting makes it feel like science fiction, even though the world it depicts has backslid from the scientific standards of today. In fact, it has backslid from every standard of today: in a sort of ultimate triumph of Project 2025, centralized government is a thing of the past, which means there are no public services in this future New York—no public health, no public education, no public utilities.

One consequence is that life expectancy has plunged. Without affordable medical care or social welfare, people die of tooth decay and childbirth and exposure to the cold come winter. Fertility has also collapsed for reasons no one understands—maybe an unknown disease, maybe environmental toxins, maybe a genetic mutation. The demographic impact is drastic: late thirties is the new old age, reaching fifty is almost unheard of, and the over-all population has plummeted.

As a result, much of “Ply” has a distinct “World Without Us” feel. In Diaz’s version of New York, dolphins arc through the East River, black bears browse on acorns from SoHo’s abundant oak trees, and whole avenues’ worth of buildings, their tops caved in, have turned into “massive planters.”

Even island biogeography is having its way; the moose that dwell in the Bronx are unusually small, the feral cats of Manhattan strangely large. The human residents of this de-urbanizing city live a hybrid life, part modern, part ancient. They watch things called projections and possess iPhone-like devices called stells, but they get around mainly on foot and by bike, barter goods and services, gather to gossip at water stations, and settle down after sunset into an almost primordial darkness.

That's because electricity, like every other commodity in this new New York, is privatized, under the control of a company called Tensor. Since few people can afford power bills, almost everyone relies on the thriving black market for "bricks," portable batteries whose charge is illicitly siphoned from the grid. The people who do that siphoning are known as "pinchers," and our unnamed protagonist is one of them. That puts her in the crosshairs of CTS, a private security company that has taken over another former function of the state: public safety. The difference is that, like early insurance companies, CTS extinguishes only the fires it is paid, including by Tensor, to put out.

It was CTS that murdered the pincher's father, in an Argentinean-style disappearance of anyone who agitated against this privatization: no trials, no Gulags, just gone. When her mother dies some years later, the protagonist, then age eleven, is left adrift. Eventually, she makes her way to a man named Acevedo, a prominent tinker in a city that is full of them because "nothing new is ever really available and nothing old is ever really thrown away." Acevedo's workshop looks like a junk yard and functions like a food pantry, but, in a familiar trope of science fiction, it operates like a religious order, with shaved-headed apprentices expected to be silent, selfless, and entirely without need.

Acevedo himself functions as both the book's moral authority and its political theorist. In a lecture to his apprentices, he explains what brought about the long-ago collapse of liberal democracy: basically, an unchecked continuation of everything filling the op-ed pages today. Social mobility gave way to impermeable class divisions; the idea of inalienable rights withered on the vine; a profound skepticism of government replaced an understanding that some problems are too large or challenging or unremunerative for any other entity to solve; and artificial intelligence

undermined the belief that humans are unique and extraordinary—the very conviction that had undergirded all those other ideals since the Renaissance.

Many books about the future are ways of thinking through the problems of the present. One of the difficulties with “Ply” is that it seems to want to do this but never quite settles on what to say. It doesn’t really mourn the lost world order; at one point, Acevedo lists the superior qualities of his own times, from the decline of the patriarchy to the end of the carceral state. Only reluctantly does he acknowledge all the misery around him, which both he and the pincher choose to regard as a sign that they are living through the painful birth of a better era. Elsewhere, however, the book suggests that the present lawlessness is itself that better outcome. “There was freedom in dissolution, joy in disorder,” Diaz writes, as if advocating for anarchy, though most of his characters appear to subscribe only to the political philosophy known as making the best of a bad situation.

If the book has one consistent political sentiment, it is a kind of Occupy Wall Street-style anti-capitalism. In “Ply,” as in Zuccotti Park circa 2011, people with different and sometimes incompatible views have exactly one thing in common: anger over the untrammelled greed of the private sector, its steady hijacking of public services, and its ruinous impact on everyday citizens. A similar sentiment lay at the heart of “Trust,” where its fictional treatment was clear and spare, but in “Ply” it is both more emphatic and more confusing. Somehow, we are to believe that New York is no longer a monument to commerce and consumption, yet also that it is controlled, down to matters of life and death, by private corporations.

To further muddy these waters, our protagonist abandons Acevedo, the strongest critic of capitalism in the book, when she falls in love with a fellow-apprentice named Sol, who craves a different life. “I want to be free to want,” she declares, and the two run off together to begin their careers as pinchers. Acevedo regards pinching as pure theft, and thus “the ultimate affirmation of private property.” But Sol thinks of it as “profit . . . and fun,” and, for a while, she’s right, especially because the two women settle into a particularly glamorous niche of the business—powering concerts for the city’s thriving music scene.

Music is a constant presence in “Ply,” as it was in “Trust”: proof that the arts can flourish even in a culture seemingly too preoccupied with other things—wealth accumulation, survival—to care about them. Diaz, who is gifted at describing sound, packs “Ply” with bands both new and retro, some of which arguably represent a different sort of anti-capitalist impulse, although only in that vague way best summarized as Fuck the Man. But, the more time we spend with them, the more the book’s inchoate political energy dissipates. Moreover, the pincher herself gets something else from the music scene. A literal purveyor of power, she finally feels like a figurative one, too, and the sensation is exhilarating. “It was short-lived,” she tells us, “but while it lasted it was a long, pure now.”

What shatters this high is the slightest of accidents: Sol cuts her hand on a nail. Two days later, she is dead of sepsis, and our heartbroken protagonist takes a hard turn toward suspicion and solitude. Functioning now mostly as a lone wolf, she spends her time tinkering with a new model of brick she’s designed, twice the size of the typical version but capable of holding forty times the charge. When others grow interested in it, she senses danger and decides to stop pinching. But then along comes Pola, the scientist, who is ready to begin her world-altering experiment, except for one hitch: she needs electricity.

A curious thing happens at the start of the second half of “Ply.” The narration switches, not from one character to another but from the first person to the third. Having spent two hundred pages following along inside an “I,” we are suddenly kicked out and find ourselves reading about “the pincher.” That shift coincides with two others. First, Diaz turns his attention from the nature of society to the nature of the self and the universe. Second, we swap mentor figures, with Acevedo the tinker replaced by Pola the scientist—an austere and ethical fixer of real objects for the benefit of the people replaced by a volatile, drug-addicted, possibly crazy theoretical physicist. (Diaz has a fondness for maybe-mad scientists; “In the Distance” has one, too, who is more consistently kind than Pola but similarly single-minded.)



At the beginning of this second half, the pincher agrees to help Pola acquire the electricity she needs. This turns out to be all of it: the two plan to drain Tensor's main power grid and store its energy for use in Pola's experiment. To do so, they develop a heist-y plan, promising to hand over prototypes of the pincher's new brick to a couple of interested parties in exchange for staging a riot that will distract CTS when Tensor most needs it. First, though, they must build a battery capable of storing the power they intend to steal. As they work on it, the women grow close, despite Pola's sometimes difficult personality and despite the outrageousness of her experiment. This involves not only the particle accelerator but a mysterious golden disk that Pola believes can manipulate space-time and therefore reshape the universe.

You either do or don't have a taste for this sort of thing. The pincher, for one, does not, but she falls under Pola's spell anyway, coming to see her as a mother figure. Soon, the pincher also acquires a surrogate daughter—a young orphan named Ines, whom she takes in after finding her badly beaten outside their museum turned laboratory. Ines takes a shine to both women, and the time the trio spends together, like the time the pincher and Sol shared in the first half of the book, forms a temporary idyll.

Eventually, though, the moment arrives to implement their plan—which, like many such plans, works until it doesn't. The heist appears to go off without

a hitch, but the experiment does not: when a fire engulfs the lab, the pincher rushes to put it out and, in the process, stumbles into the golden disk. She survives but suffers serious burns, and before long starts showing signs of radiation sickness. Yet she is more consumed by what she saw when she looked into the disk—a vision, as difficult to re-create as dreams by day, of merging with space-time.

Soon, the pincher floats free of her consciousness, briefly inhabiting the mind of Pola or Ines before flickering back into herself. Accordingly, the narration starts flickering as well, between “the pincher” and the “I” of firsthand experience. Meanwhile, the other characters grow unstable, too, seeming to become alternate versions of the pincher or her mother. The pincher attributes this loosening of the boundaries of the self to her contact with the disk; the reader wonders if it’s just part of the process of dying. In the end—I’m not spoiling anything; I am doubtful, for many reasons, that the concept applies to this book—there is a great betrayal, and a great explosion, and a great many unanswered questions.

Partway through “Ply,” a minor character named Anton launches into an irritated monologue about the saying “I am here for you.” As a non-native English speaker, he finds these words meaningless, and he has a point. “I,” “here,” and “you” are all examples of indexical words, those whose meaning changes depending on their context.

Much of the second part of “Ply” is a meditation on those words, too. I, here, you—we change in relation to one another and to where we are, including, Diaz suggests, on a map of coördinates we cannot even fathom. His book is interested in not only whether the universe is composed of some fundamental particle but whether we are: whether there is an irreducible essence of selfhood or whether that is just an illusion, as Zeno claimed motion was—a local experience of reality that occludes another one, so hidden or vast or mysterious that it falls almost entirely outside our comprehension.

You can’t fault Diaz for lack of ambition. As a title, “Ply” is a slippery, clever choice, a word that means “layer” while containing other layers of meaning. So, too, the book itself, which is preoccupied with many things at once: what people are made of, what society is made of, what the universe is

made of. And the whole of Diaz's career is similarly ambitious. As different as his three books are, together they form a kind of new "U.S.A." trilogy—or, more aptly, an "N.Y.C." trilogy. "In the Distance" features a New York that is both a longed-for destination and an imagined locus of civilization; in "Trust," it has become the heart of an all-devouring financial industry and its ethos of pure greed; in "Ply," that ethos has been fulfilled, turning the city into a site of radical decay and, potentially, the birth of something new.

Regrettably, the grand intellectual ambitions of "Ply" finally overwhelm the other desiderata of fiction. One of these is storytelling. Diaz excels at this, as his previous books attest—"In the Distance" is genuinely impossible to put down—but the narrative energy of "Ply" keeps getting derailed, not least because two of its main characters exist mostly to lecture us. This sort of works with Acevedo, the proxy political theorist, but doesn't work at all with Pola, the proxy cosmologist, whose ten-page discourse on space-time fails not only to clarify the relevant particle physics (admittedly a tall order) but also to provoke our awe or pique our curiosity about her character.

That last problem is not limited to Pola. Although some bit players in this book are wonderfully drawn—especially Anton, a bombastic but bighearted black-market kingpin—the pincher herself seems as if she exists only to do the author's bidding. Learning about her is more like reading a personnel file than meeting a person, which proves fatal for the novel's stakes. I understood what Diaz was doing with all those chameleon pronouns near the end, but it is difficult to care about the dissolution of a character who never quite felt real in the first place.

Still, there is something in Diaz that wants to be reckoned with, something that brings to mind those black bears in SoHo, startling and powerful and rare. At one point, the pincher comes across an old Hawthorne story and is struck by how effectively it does what Pola can only dream of doing centuries later: set someone loose on multiple chronologies simultaneously. The reference is heavy-handed, but the idea is the right one. With due respect to the innovations of science, fiction remains the most powerful microscope, telescope, seismograph, X-ray machine, and particle accelerator we've ever discovered—a way to examine the world at every scale, to reverse causality, to alter time, to identify fundamental properties, to reveal our inner workings and control the conditions of the universe. Best of all,

and happily for Diaz, you can run as many experiments as you want, and no one is harmed when the odd one fails. ♦

Books

Tom Brady's Endgame

A new biography argues that the star quarterback's divorce was his biggest fumble.

By Jennifer Wilson

September 21, 2026



There is a certain YouTube clip that I watch from time to time, when I need a pick-me-up, or when I'm in a giddy mood and want to push it further—to the upper reaches of euphoria. The video, from 2018, is titled “Eagles strip sack on Tom Brady - Local Announcers / Multiple Languages,” and it captures seven seconds from the fourth quarter of Super Bowl LII, as witnessed by stunned sportscasters across the globe. On one side were the New England Patriots, led by the clutch quarterback Brady and coached by Bill Belichick, a partnership that had produced five Super Bowl rings. On the other were the hobbled Philadelphia Eagles, my home team, with a second-string quarterback named Nick Foles (Carson Wentz, the team's top draft pick from 2016, had been sidelined by a torn A.C.L.) and a coach, Doug Pederson, who had previously only ever been in charge of a high-school team (which never won a state championship during his tenure). As

Brady gets ready to throw, in what most presumed would be a game-winning drive, it happens. The Eagles defender Brandon Graham fends off a Patriots offensive lineman, reaches his left hand out, and knocks the ball loose from Brady's grip. "Fuhmble! Fuhmble!" the announcers in Germany scream. "*Incroyable*," the French commentators say. "Tom Brady bereft on the turf," the Australians observe of the legendary quarterback, who by then was sitting on the field in shock.

It is a testament to Brady that whenever I watch this clip I feel a touch nervous. If anyone could break open the space-time continuum to retrieve a loose ball and connect with the tight end Rob Gronkowski for a first down, it would be him. By the time he retired, in 2023, Brady had seven Super Bowl rings, the most of any player in the game's history; his first came in 2002, his last, two decades later. He seemed immune from time itself, as though he were part god. That the quarterback who first found the Patriots' Achilles' heel in a Super Bowl was Eli Manning—the younger, bumbling brother of football's true prince, Peyton Manning—added to the sense that Brady could only be taken down by an accident of fate. After Super Bowl LI, when Brady's jersey was stolen from a locker room, the Patriots' owner, Robert Kraft, compared the heist to "taking a great Chagall or Picasso."

As if all that weren't enough, in 2009, Brady married Gisele Bündchen, a woman for whom the moniker "supermodel" was deemed insufficient. *New York* magazine dubbed the Brazilian glamazon, who has a reported net worth of four hundred million dollars and twelve hundred magazine covers on her résumé, an "*Über-model*." She frequently posted photos of herself on social media doing yoga on the beach, like *Forbes*'s richest water sprite. After the Eagles converted Brady's fumble into the franchise's first Super Bowl victory, she congratulated every player in green she saw on her way out, leaving them so awestruck it was a wonder that the Patriots hadn't sent her into the tunnel before the game instead. And she wasn't just beautiful; she was warm and whimsical. Bündchen, who had two children with Brady, told *People* magazine, "My kids never got sick when I was breastfeeding. If they had something in their eyes, I'd put milk in their eyes." She was, you might say, the ultimate catch.

And so it has fascinated observers of football and celebrity marriages alike that, when Bündchen nudged her husband to retire, after he won his fifth

Super Bowl ring, in 2017, he did not go one further and set Gillette Stadium on fire. Brady did eventually retire, in February of 2022, only to “unretire” forty days later. By August, the couple were living apart, according to tabloid reports. By October, they were divorced. That winter, Brady said that he was retiring “for good.”

Since then, his image has taken a harder hit than any he endured on the field. He popped out of a coffin in a cheesy W.W.E.-inspired skit at Fanatics Fest. He appeared in a Pizza Hut commercial shouting, “Hut!” (Get it?) His attempts to be an on-air sports analyst have underwhelmed. “As a broadcaster, Tom Brady isn’t just Capt. Obvious,” the former Fox Sports commentator Skip Bayless tweeted. “He’s the Commander in Chief of Obvious.” Brady has become a punch line, and the jokes always seem to circle back to his split with Bündchen. One fan referred to his post-retirement antics as “divorced dad side quests.” In Netflix’s 2024 “Roast of Tom Brady,” the comedian Kevin Hart said, of Brady’s final season, “When you got a chance to go 8–9, and all it will cost you is your wife and your kids, you gotta do what the fuck you gotta do.”

Still, I didn’t expect “Brady: An American Story and the Price of Greatness,” a new biography by the former *Sports Illustrated* journalist Lars Anderson, to tell the story of Touchdown Tom’s life through the prism of his divorce. The book—surprisingly intimate despite the fact that Anderson didn’t have access to the golden couple—reads like “Scenes from a Marriage” with a lot more blitzing. It opens with Bündchen and Brady’s first date, in 2006, at the West Village wine bar Turks & Frogs. Anderson writes with exactly the amount of restraint you’d expect of a man whose subjects are a football legend and a Victoria’s Secret model, which is to say—he leaves every metaphor on the field. That night, Bündchen’s eyes were “the mossy green of a primeval forest” while Brady’s were “the glacial blue of a winter sky.” Over drinks, he tells her that he intends to play for ten more years and would be happy to win just one more Super Bowl. Anderson tries to understand why, in the end, Brady couldn’t stick to the game plan, even when the woman whose teeth “glistened with the flawless geometry of freshly fallen snow” asked him to.

The quarterback who averaged a 64.3-per-cent completion rate over his career was almost never born. His father, Tom Brady, Sr., had studied to

become a priest. Born in San Francisco's Haight-Ashbury neighborhood in 1944, he left home at fourteen to attend a seminary in Chicago, but, Anderson forewarns, he had "wandering, lustful eyes." A Latin instructor urged him to reconsider his path: "Mr. Brady, you ought to propagate the faithful, not propagate the faith." Brady's mother, Galynn Johnson, had grown up on a dairy farm in Minnesota; in high school, she was a cheerleader. In 1968, Johnson was twenty-two, working as a flight attendant for Trans World Airlines, and living in San Francisco, when, one day, there was a knock at the door. It was Brady, Sr., then a travelling insurance salesman. The two soon married and moved to San Mateo, where they had three girls—Maureen, Julie, and Nancy—and then a boy, Thomas Edward Patrick Brady, Jr., born on August 3, 1977.

By most measures, Brady's childhood was idyllic. (On Google Street View, the home where he grew up resembles, fittingly, the house from "The Brady Bunch.") But Anderson paints a picture of a boy living in the shadow of his athletic-superstar sisters. Maureen made the U.S. Junior Olympic softball team, Julie was a starter on her college's soccer team, and Nancy won a softball scholarship to Berkeley. In contrast, Brady was scrawny, slow, and repeatedly picked last for games. Maureen later recalled to the *Eagle-Tribune* a time when "some boys were throwing a football around our street and they told Tommy to go deep. He ran all the way down the street waiting for the football and they turned around and left."

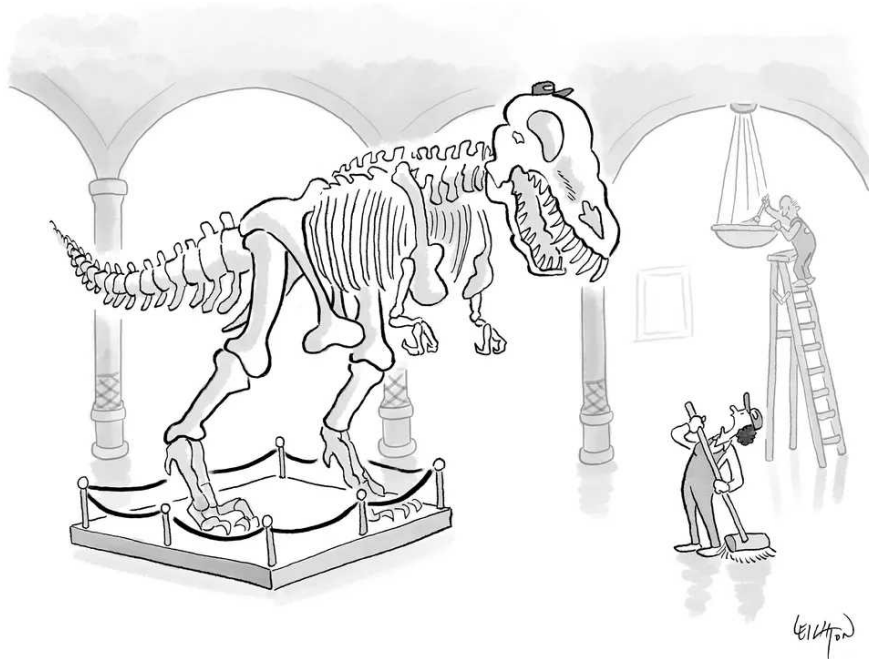
Tom, Sr., stepped in. When Brady began playing football in high school, his father hired the head coach at the College of San Mateo to train him. He also enlisted a video editor to create a sizzle reel for college scouts. In December of 1994, Billy Harris, who was on the coaching staff at the University of Michigan, noticed a "mystery tape" on his desk. He was used to receiving film from high-school coaches, but this had been mailed from a residential address. Harris hadn't heard of Brady. "Nobody on the recruiting trail was mentioning him," he told the *Athletic* in 2020. The university recruited Brady only after its top pick, Bobby Sabelhaus, pulled out at the last minute. (Sabelhaus, who never played in the N.F.L., is now a real-estate agent in Nantucket.)

At Michigan, Brady began as the seventh-string quarterback. "The coaches don't believe in me," he told Greg Harden, a counsellor in the athletic

department. “You’re right, they don’t,” Harden said, before offering a mantra: “If it was to be, it was up to me.” Brady became a relentless preparer. He did one drill, wherein he would drag his planted foot after throwing the ball, so many times that the nail on his big toe came off. His senior year, during a nationally televised game against Notre Dame, Michigan was trailing at halftime. The coach, Lloyd Carr, replaced the team’s hot-shot sophomore quarterback with Brady. The crowd let out a “wave of boos,” Anderson writes, “the instant his cleats hit the grass.” Brady responded with a fourth-quarter, game-winning comeback.

His ability to produce in big moments was one of the “intangibles” the newly hired Patriots coach Bill Belichick kept seeing in scouting reports. The tangibles were less stellar. At a scouting combine ahead of the draft, Brady had registered the second-slowest forty-yard dash for a quarterback in the event’s history; one coach complained that he looked “more like a damn aluminum siding salesman than a professional quarterback.” The night of the 2000 N.F.L. draft, as the sixth round began, Brady was lying in bed beside his father in his childhood home, realizing that he might never play professional football. Then a call came. The Patriots were selecting him in that round, at No. 199. (Only one Super Bowl-winning quarterback had ever been drafted lower.)

According to Anderson, a key part of the Patriots’ winning formula was Brady’s sense that Belichick had plucked him from obscurity. Anderson quotes Lee Smith, who briefly played alongside Brady in 2011; if Brady had been a first-round pick, Smith suggested, “he could have told Belichick to kiss his ass whenever he’d jump on him. But instead Tom had to impress Belichick.” He went on, “And when your star player is walking on eggshells around the head coach, everyone on the team is doing the same thing, which is what Belichick wanted.” Brady’s history of being undervalued helped him bond with the offensive linemen, who are often treated more like equipment than people, bodies there to protect the brains, i.e., the quarterback. “He’s one of us,” the offensive tackle Clint Oldenburg said during Brady’s first season.



It helped that Brady's teammates saw him put in the work. One morning, the Patriots safety Rodney Harrison thought that he had finally beaten Brady to the gym by arriving at 5:30 *a.m.*, only to find him watching film in a meeting room and jotting down notes. "Good afternoon. Did you enjoy sleeping in?" Brady asked Harrison, grinning. In Anderson's hands, scenes like this read as foreshadowing the marital discord to come, as does a sound bite he includes from the documentary "Tom vs. Time": "If you compete against me, you better be willing to give up your life, because I'm giving up mine," Brady says.

In 2002, during his second season, Brady became the youngest quarterback to win a Super Bowl, leading the Patriots to a 20–17 finish over the St. Louis Rams. They won again in 2004, and yet again in 2005. (I watched the latter game, against a Donovan McNabb-led Eagles team, through tears.) With fame came curiosity about his personal life—"His favorite color was blue. He really, *really* loved onion rings," Anderson writes—and new opportunities. He shadowboxed Muhammad Ali at a charity event. He made a cameo in the Farrelly brothers' film "Stuck on You" at the urging of the Patriots fan and Boston native Matt Damon. He judged the 2002 Miss U.S.A. pageant in Gary, Indiana. Donald Trump, the pageant's owner, told the press, "Let me tell you, if one thing stands out about Tom Brady, it's that he loves those women. And guess what? They love him, too." That hadn't

been true before; Brady's teammates, who recalled his failed attempts to pick up women at Boston bars, were taken aback when, during a flight on a private jet to Hawaii for the Pro Bowl, a call came from the "American Pie" actress Tara Reid's personal assistant, asking whether Brady would like to take Reid out on a date.

Fame also brought out Brady's quirks. He began working with a "body coach" named Alex Guerrero, whom his teammates referred to as "Mr. Miyagi" from the film "The Karate Kid." The two developed a strict diet-and-exercise regimen that became known as the TB12 Method. Brady abstained from sugar, caffeine, refined flour, dairy, and "nightshades," a food group that includes tomatoes, peppers, and eggplant. He began to experiment with fashion. When mocked in the locker room for carrying what looked like a woman's purse, he yelled back, "It's a European handbag!" He filled his locker with cologne and aromatic emollients. "I've never seen too many Caucasian brothers with cocoa butter," his teammate Deion Branch told *USA Today* at the time. The Patriots wide receiver Wes Welker said, at a press conference, "He's probably the toughest metrosexual I've ever come across."

Like David Beckham before him, Brady needed a partner who could understand highlights and the spotlight. In December, 2006, Brady, freshly broken up with the "Sex and the City" actress Bridget Moynahan, received a call from Ed Razek, the chief marketing officer of Victoria's Secret. (Razek was the subject of a 2020 investigation by the *New York Times* into sexual harassment at the lingerie company; he denied all wrongdoing.) Razek told Brady that he had a "girl version" of the star quarterback. Razek also called Bündchen—whose five-year, on-and-off relationship with Leonardo DiCaprio had come to an end—to say that he had a "boy version" of her. By January, Bündchen was smitten enough to attend her very first game of American football, a playoff matchup with the San Diego Chargers. (In the 2021 ESPN+ documentary "Man in the Arena: Tom Brady," she admitted, "It was the most boring thing I've ever seen in my life. I was, like, 'What are they doing? Why do they stop all the time? Where is the goal?'") A month later, they were vacationing together in France. While there, Brady received a call from Moynahan. She was pregnant. Anderson takes pains to back up Brady's claim that things were over with Moynahan by the time he met Bündchen at Turks & Frogs, writing, "A certified obstetrics nurse estimated

that, based on the infant's being born at forty weeks, the date of conception would have been close to November 29, 2006, at least two weeks before Brady's blind date with Gisele." That summer, Brady's first child was born.

Bündchen and Brady were married in a small ceremony in Santa Monica in February of 2009, followed by a vow renewal two months later in Costa Rica. "Each guest was gifted a copy of Don Miguel Ruiz's pop-psychology guide *The Mastery of Love* about overcoming emotional wounds," Anderson notes.

Brady was completely under her spell. "You're lucky you married a witch," she told him. She gave him "protection stones," altars for his locker, and new mantras to chant. She "concocted special liquid drops he'd release into his mouth," Anderson recounts. (We never learn what's in them.) Brady's enemies were hers, and, unlike him, she could drink on game day. After the Patriots lost to the New York Giants in Super Bowl XLVI, she was heckled by fans who shouted, "Eli owns your husband!" Bündchen, "emboldened by a glass or two of wine," Anderson writes, shot back, "My husband cannot fucking throw the ball and catch the ball at the same time." Her retort made headlines around the world. "I thought I was, like, mild—what I said," she recalls in "Man in the Arena." "I mean, it's true."

She stood by her husband through Deflategate—Brady's only major scandal, in which it was discovered that the Patriots were using balls with less air than N.F.L. guidelines required—even when it drew unwanted attention to her. The New York *Post* ran a front-page story titled "COVERUP!"; alongside a picture of Brady, it featured a paparazzi photo, allegedly of Bündchen disguised in a burqa as she entered a Parisian plastic-surgery clinic. Like him, she could stay calm in the pocket. "She is always looking at, you know, the positive side of everything," Brady's oldest sister, Maureen, said. "She always says, 'Why is this happening *for* me?,' not 'Why is this happening *to* me?'" She also helped in material ways. The Patriots were able to surround Brady with an unusual level of talent because he could accept a salary below that of other elite quarterbacks. "My wife makes a lot of money," he told Jimmy Kimmel.

I'm a fan of books about sports. (I once almost created a podcast on the subject; I planned to call it "The Bookie.") The best ones situate athletes in

history. Buzz Bissinger's "Friday Night Lights" is about high-school football the way that the documentary "Hoop Dreams" is about basketball. Both capture the shrinking aperture of opportunity in a country founded on the idea of limitless possibility. David Maraniss's "Path Lit by Lightning: The Life of Jim Thorpe" considers how the Native American football legend wrestled with what it meant to be "all-American."

The ambitions of Anderson's book are slight by comparison, its stakes those of a preseason game. Brady is a man who began playing professionally at the dawn of a new millennium, but you wouldn't know it here. In his era, the football field became the site of a bold act of protest against racial injustice, yet the name Colin Kaepernick does not appear once. (In 2017, Brady did not join his teammates who kneeled during the national anthem, though he did lock arms with others, in a small show of solidarity.) Anderson rushes through Brady's relationship with Donald Trump. In 2015, a week after a *MAGA* hat had been spotted in Brady's locker by reporters, he said that he hoped Trump would win. "There would be a putting green on the White House lawn," he quipped. (The next year, when an Instagram user asked if Bündchen and Brady supported Trump, she responded, "NO!," and Brady skipped the Patriots' White House visit after winning the Super Bowl in 2017, citing "personal family matters.")

We hear about Brady's teammate Aaron Hernandez being arrested for homicide, but Anderson doesn't bring up the player's subsequent suicide or the autopsy finding of Hernandez's severe case of chronic traumatic encephalopathy. The closest we get to any discussion of C.T.E. comes from Bündchen. "He had a concussion last year," she said to Charlie Rose in 2017. "He has concussions pretty much every—I mean, we don't talk about it, but he does have concussions. And I don't really think it's a healthy thing for your body to go through. . . . I'm planning on having him be healthy and do a lot of fun things when we're, like, a hundred, I hope." It was a shocking claim, as there was no record of head trauma on any of Brady's injury reports, which would have required that he comply with the N.F.L.'s concussion protocol; her allegation prompted an inquiry by the league.

There's no sense in Anderson's book that Brady is a man of our age, except in the worst possible ways. Brady could choose when to retire, but some of his own fans were deprived of that option. Michael Livieratos, a Patriots

supporter, put his life savings into FTX after seeing his hero promote the cryptocurrency firm. (Sam Bankman-Fried paid Brady fifty-five million dollars for sixty hours of promotional work, and Gisele eighteen million to appear alongside her husband.) No, the big question of the book seems to be this: Can a man really claim that he's won it all if he fumbled Gisele? I must confess I took some pleasure in seeing a man subjected to the narrative that the end of his marriage is a life-defining moment, his most important story. If he were a woman, this book would be a best-selling memoir.

Anderson, noting that Bündchen's star sign is Cancer, quotes an astrological report from the summer before their divorce that appeared in *Cosmopolitan*: "Honest, raw conversations will be necessary as power struggles and hidden agendas are exposed. This is your opportunity to transform the dynamics in your closest ties." When Brady arrived at training camp ahead of that year's season, the coaching staff found him "gaunt and cadaverous," Anderson writes. In 2025, a little more than three years after their split, it was reported that Bündchen had married her jujitsu instructor, Joaquim Valente. Soon after the news broke, Brady posted a selfie on Instagram from a car, wearing a sweatshirt that read "*Forever Young*," with the song "1-800-273-8255," by Logic, playing in the background, the title a reference to the national suicide-prevention hotline.

In the end, it's Bündchen's objections to Brady's insatiable desire for more—more rings, more wins, more record-breaking—that give the book its heft. Brady retired at forty-five, when he was the oldest starting quarterback in N.F.L. history. He played his final seasons with Tampa Bay, which I could understand; perhaps he hoped to prove that he could win a Super Bowl without Belichick, and he did. But he wanted another, and another—which does, one could argue, tie him to this moment in our country, when no quest for more feels out of bounds. In "Tom vs. Time," Bündchen tells the camera that football was her husband's first love. "And I think it's, like, his main love, really," she adds. Brady jokes that if she had it her way, after his Super Bowl LI victory the pair would have moved to Costa Rica, where as of late she has been photographed walking hand in hand along the beach with Valente. She was done with this "American story." How many more times could she say, *Enough, you already have enough*. ♦

Books

What's Really Behind the Baby Bust?

People say they want more children than they're having. Is modern life stopping them—or have our ideas about a good life changed?

By Margaret Talbot

September 21, 2026



If you've followed the debate over falling birth rates in the United States, you could be forgiven for thinking that most of the fretting comes from the anti-feminist right. In recent years, Vice-President J. D. Vance has emerged as a cranky pro-natalist, deriding "childless cat ladies," blaming "secular global liberalism" for population decline, and, in happier moments, as at an anti-abortion rally last year, declaring, "I want more babies in the United States of America" and more "beautiful young men and women" eager to make and rear them. A report from the conservative Heritage Foundation earlier this year sounded the alarm over the drop in U.S. fertility, linking it to "second-wave feminism" and other familiar culture-war culprits: "casual sex, abortion, childlessness by choice, and no-fault divorce," all of which menaced "the natural family," which was helmed by a heterosexual husband and wife. Many of these voices agree with the determinedly fecund Elon

Musk (at least fourteen kids and counting), who has said, “Population collapse due to low birth rates is a much bigger risk to civilization than global warming.” Recent polling shows that, among the growing percentage of Americans who think we should be at least somewhat worried about the birth rate, men worry more than women, and Republicans more than Democrats.

Running through this conversation is a theory about what people want. A big reason people have fewer children, the argument goes, is that they no longer want them enough. Feminism, secularism, individualism, and sexual freedom have weakened the old attachments to marriage and family. In this account, the explanation is largely cultural.

Another story about falling fertility, however, begins from almost the opposite premise: plenty of people still want children, often more than they wind up having. What has changed are the social and economic conditions people need to create the families they’d hoped to have. Housing is ruinously expensive. Child care is costly, too. Jobs are demanding and insecure. Finding a reliable partner can feel harder than ever. From this perspective, the fertility slump is a record of frustrated longing.

Anna Louie Sussman, the author of “[Inconceivable: The Impossibility of Family in an Age of Uncertainty](#)” (Dey Street), forcefully makes this second case. She is not a social conservative or a soapbox pro-natalist. The censorious baby boosters at Heritage would not be fans of the way she chose to reproduce. Sussman, a single journalist in New York, travelled to Bologna to retrieve eggs that she’d frozen there six years earlier, when she was thirty-four (egg freezing was cheaper in Europe), then flew to another European city, charged about three thousand dollars to her credit card for an embryo-transfer procedure (it would have cost about fifteen thousand dollars in the U.S.), and got pregnant. Her gay best friend, Anthony, became her daughter’s adoptive father, and his parents joined a small, devoted community of caregivers for their child.

Sussman nevertheless shares Vance and Musk’s conviction that something has gone seriously wrong when so few babies are being born. She just views the shortage as symptomatic of societal woes that conservatives have little to say about: the costs of housing, health care, and higher education; fear of a

climate-changed future; feelings of precarity, immediate and anticipated; and obstacles to finding a potential co-parent. She largely attributes these phenomena to the workings of modern capitalism on our bank accounts and psyches. She is less concerned with the birth rate per se than with the experience of forgoing children. She is not, she writes, “arguing for people to have more or fewer children, or about the importance of children for economic purposes”—shoring up tax bases, saving pension systems, and the like.

What troubles Sussman is the gap between how many kids people say they want and how many are born. A 2025 U.N. study asked fourteen thousand people across fourteen countries how many children they wanted and how many they expected to have. Most wanted two; not even four in ten expected to achieve that. A Gallup poll that year showed something similar among Americans surveyed: forty per cent said that having two children was optimal, and twenty-seven per cent said three. (That’s roughly in line with results from previous decades.) But at current rates many families won’t get there.

“When so many people hesitate to have children,” Sussman writes, “what is lost is not simply future taxpayers or consumers. We miss out on the rich relationships that bond us across generations, on the flood of love and tenderness that caring for children, or simply being around them, can unleash.” She adds that the “retreat from parenthood also encapsulates a dissatisfaction with our present so extreme it has become a vote against the future.”

The scale of the fertility decline makes the issue hard to dismiss. Global fertility rates fell from an average of about five births per woman in the nineteen-sixties to 2.2 in 2024. Most countries, representing about seventy per cent of the world’s population, have rates below the replacement level of 2.1 births per woman. In the United States, the rate is now 1.6. In South Korea—where dog strollers outsell baby strollers, and playgrounds and elementary-school classrooms can be eerily empty—it is below one. In the U.S., almost half of women aged thirty are childless, compared with eighteen per cent in 1976.

So who has the better analysis of what is happening? Have people's priorities changed, or has building the families they hoped for become more onerous? If millions still want children but are discouraged from having them, then the fertility slump marks a substantial social failure. And there is plenty in contemporary life to bolster Sussman's case.

Consider what parenthood now asks of people. A big part of the story is the shift toward what the economists Melissa Kearney and Phillip Levine describe as "much more resource and time-intensive" parenting. Many young adults who started families in the past twenty years were raised this way, which shaped their own conceptions of how to rear children. If families want to invest in extracurriculars and a college education for their children, while lavishing time and attention on them, then doing so for five, rather than, say, one or two, may seem impossible.

Time-use studies have shown a steady increase since the nineteen-seventies in the hours that parents in rich countries devote to child care. Millennial mothers and fathers in the United States spend more time tending to their offspring than Gen X-ers did. Recently, as I was reading research papers on declining birth rates, an unfamiliar finding glinted up at me like a penny on the sidewalk. In countries where male involvement in child care and housework is highest—Norway, for example—male parents tend to oppose having additional children. You might see this as a bummer: Mr. Moms overwhelmed by ordinary domestic duties. Or you might see it, as I did, as evidence that men who participate more actively in such tasks develop a healthy respect for what they require.

Turning to South Korea, contemporary demographers' favorite example of a reproductive desert, Sussman examines one particularly punishing form of souped-up child rearing: the culture of *hagwon*, or afternoon and evening cram schools. These institutions are de rigueur for children hoping to reach university in a hypercompetitive system, and they require parents, almost exclusively mothers, to collect their exhausted, fact-stuffed kids late at night, up to six days a week. People in Seoul told Sussman that the system had turned them against parenting: they felt unable to avoid *hagwon* and unwilling to subject future children to it.

For many would-be parents, the demands of child rearing are not the first hurdle. Before having kids, they want to find someone to raise them with. Here, too, Sussman assembles a formidable catalogue of impediments. Dating apps are too much like online shopping. (There's some overlap here with the Heritage Foundation's critique of dating apps, which similarly targets their profit-driven, algorithmic incentives for "continuous scrolling and swiping," as its family report puts it.) Plastic surgery and inflationary beauty standards impose dizzying upkeep. A surfeit of online porn scrambles young men's expectations of sex. And social media encourages "relentless packaging and marketing of the self." A 2020 Pew Research Center survey found that thirty-five per cent of never married, single American adults hadn't ever been in a committed romantic relationship. In a 2024 survey, eighty per cent of singles reported "emotional fatigue or burnout" from online dating. The research shows, Sussman says, that the biggest reason women choose to freeze their eggs is that they haven't found the right partner. "At a time when we have more social and sexual freedom than at any point in history," she writes, "it can feel harder than ever to find genuine connection."

Sussman's portraits both illustrate and complicate these diagnoses, as individuals tend to. In a chapter about dating, she introduces Michaela, who, in her late thirties, is dating "more diligently than anyone I know," mostly through apps. Michaela is multilingual, outgoing, and, Sussman tells us, "tall and voluptuous, with lush, dark eyelashes." She is an Ivy League graduate and business owner who wants a partner and a child but has gone on some two hundred dates without luck. By the book's end, though, she does find a partner, IRL, and has a baby with him. She told a stranger on a train that she was single, and the woman introduced her to an American living in the South of France. It would have been fan service to tell us more about the romance, but this is all we get. Another subject in the book, Marwan, also wants to be a parent, and gets many online matches when he lists his job as a McKinsey consultant. But when he quits to start his own firm and makes time for friends, reading, sports, and volunteering, his profile draws much less interest. He is still "tall and handsome, with a gregarious smile," and an Oxford Ph.D., according to Sussman—but "self-employed" is evidently a turnoff. (Message to Marwan: I know some delightful women for whom "McKinsey" would be the turnoff.)

Yet the closer you look at the gap between desired and actual fertility, the harder it is to know what it measures. Some parents probably change their minds without much regret after one or two children—content with the family they’ve created, persuaded by the solidity and particularity of its configuration that it, not some theoretical alternative, is right, or sobered by child rearing’s demands (perhaps a child has special needs). The South Korean example suggests a related possibility. *Hagwon* culture is a grim version of a more benign, mutually rewarding form of cultivated, small-batch parenting—one in which adults and children know one another well because they’ve spent time trying to, parents foster their kids’ interests and eccentricities, and people find in family life what the historian and social critic Christopher Lasch called a haven from the heartless world.

More tellingly, wanting two or three children already represents a domestic vision far removed from the teeming households of pioneer families, “Cheaper by the Dozen,” or even “The Brady Bunch.” The fact that people want smaller families than they once did isn’t necessarily a vote against the future. It’s a vote against past family sizes, from eras when more people relied on children for labor, expected extras to make up for ravaging child mortality, or felt religiously bound to multiply bountifully. (These motivations persist even in affluent countries, such as among Orthodox Jewish families in the United States and Israel. But Mormons are having fewer children; Utah’s birth rate has declined more than any other state’s, by thirty-seven per cent since 2007.) In the 2025 Gallup poll, only eleven per cent of Americans surveyed said that four kids was ideal, and just four per cent said five.

“Inconceivable” is not a policy book; it’s a reported social critique sauced with stories. Inevitably, though, Sussman touches on what societies might do, or have tried to do, in order to arrest falling fertility. As she suggests, and as recent studies demonstrate, interventions aimed at boosting birth rates—such as tax credits or baby bonuses—tend to have modest or short-term effects. Eleven Swiss cantons have introduced birth allowances over the years, and one study found that the payments increased fertility, mainly among lower-income immigrants, but the effect quickly faded. When Hungary, under Viktor Orbán, devoted about five per cent of its G.D.P. to an elaborate system of family subsidies, the spending seemed to stabilize the average age at which women first gave birth. But it had little effect on over-

all fertility; mainly, it nudged people into having the children they would have had anyway, just a little earlier.

Other policies that might be expected to hike the birth rate by making it easier to combine work and family life often have transitory or relatively small effects, too. In the nineteen-eighties, Sweden extended a provision in its family-leave system that rewarded parents for having another child relatively soon after the previous one, and many did so. The result, as the economists Kearney and Levine report, was “a temporary baby boom, that was subsequently offset by a baby bust.” Of all the family-friendly policies, spending on early-childhood education and child care appears to do the most to goose birth rates—especially when aligned with the right leave policies. But, according to a U.N. report, child-care provision is “more likely to influence the fertility behavior of highly educated women, who are more active in the labor market.” And, for those of us still capable of being surprised at how hard and costly it can be to budge human behavior, the numbers are a little underwhelming: in one study, every extra percentage point of G.D.P. spent on early-childhood education and child care was “associated with 0.2 extra children per woman.”

The unfettered free market of the U.S. certainly hasn’t boosted birth rates—but neither have Scandinavia’s generous social guarantees. Birth rates have plunged in social democracies and capitalist autocracies alike. Norway and the U.S. are about equally fecund. “Strong family policies and social supports,” Sussman writes, “are just a baseline. They should ensure that if and when someone would like to become a parent, they do not face job loss, financial ruin, or catastrophic health bills, and that children and their parents have enough to eat and quality child care if parents want to work. But they are no longer themselves capable of producing the conditions under which people want to, or choose to, have children.”

That qualification seems significant. If making parenthood materially easier does little to restore birth rates, perhaps some part of the fertility decline reflects a change in what people want from their lives. Fewer people consider marriage and children indispensable to a rewarding adulthood. In a 2023 Pew poll, seventy-one per cent of American adults said that an enjoyable job or career was very important to a fulfilling life, whereas only

twenty-six per cent said children and twenty-three per cent marriage. (Sixty-one per cent said close friends.)

Sussman is inclined to see such preferences as further evidence of capitalism's moral failings. I'm sympathetic. Loving your work is great, but career obsession can be its own form of sterility; corporations aren't people, and most employers would sooner lay you off than understand your ineffable you-ness. Sussman cites one study in which women who had substantial student-loan debt were around forty per cent less likely to have kids than those who didn't carry debt. That seems bleak, too.

But the poll's answers can also point to a genuinely enlarged sense of what a satisfactory life might contain. People can experience love and tenderness for younger generations without biological parenthood, as any devoted aunt or teacher can attest. They can build lives around friendship, work, art, travel, activism, or community, in ways less constrained by old ideas about virtuous adulthood. Some changes associated with lower fertility are plainly gains. Teen-pregnancy rates have dropped dramatically, women have far more educational and professional opportunities, and social norms that stigmatized childlessness have loosened. (For a horrified laugh, check out [a 1968 episode](#) called "Spinsters" from the BBC documentary series "Man Alive," on YouTube. Sample line of narration, about an unmarried woman in her thirties: "She fills her life with activities which some might call substitutes—she paints and is learning the classical guitar.")

So it makes sense to be cautious about treating peoples' stated preferences about children as a kind of buried truth, and the gap between what people say they want and what they wind up having as chiefly a measure of the obstacles placed in their way. Having a child is the most overdetermined of choices: intimate, nearly instinctual, and yet deeply embedded in cultural norms and social structures. That makes the birth rate a particularly inadequate barometer of whether a given family policy is worthwhile. The reason to institute strong family supports—for example, to have a national policy offering paid leave for new mothers and fathers in the United States, the one wealthy country that does not do so—isn't because they act like levers to push out more babies. It's because they make people's lives better, and societies kinder, more equitable, and more forbearing.

Every time I read about declining fertility—whether it’s a right-wing pro-natalist screed about permissive, secular culture; an earnest, progressive account of how contemporary capitalism constrains our most fundamental choices while presenting a simulacrum of infinite options; or, for that matter, a sober statistical analysis from the O.E.C.D.—I realize that I can’t quite imagine the combination of forces that would reverse the worldwide trend toward fewer babies and smaller families. So many modern humans seem to want many things at once: children, autonomy, absorbing work, a certain standard of parenting, and a particular sort of romantic partner. The fertility rate reflects the priorities that emerge when decisions have to be made. Economic factors play a role, but culture plays a larger one and is less amenable to policy interventions. Culture encompasses ideas about what adulthood should entail, what parents owe their children, how much sacrifice family should require, how parents and other caregivers should divide their child-rearing duties, and whether having children makes a life bigger or smaller.

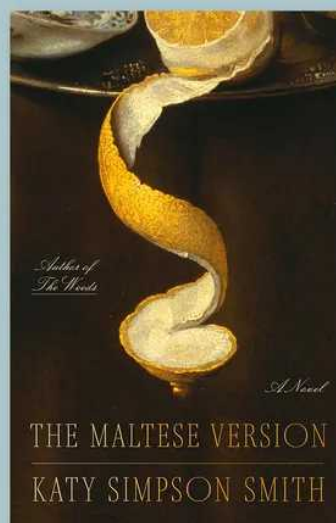
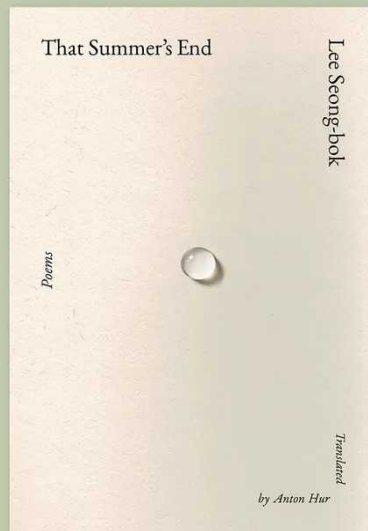
Those ideas can’t be legislated into existence, yet institutions, social movements, customs, and habits can shape them over time. Norms do shift, sometimes unpredictably, as people watch one another live. If smaller families arose partly from changing ideas about a good life, we can’t assume that those ideas have reached their final form. The postwar American baby boom itself reversed a century-long decline in family size. Whether or not we see another baby boom, my vote is for giving up on policies aimed at coaxing or prodding people into having children, and for making family life easier for the people—and they will always be with us—who dearly want them. ♦

Books

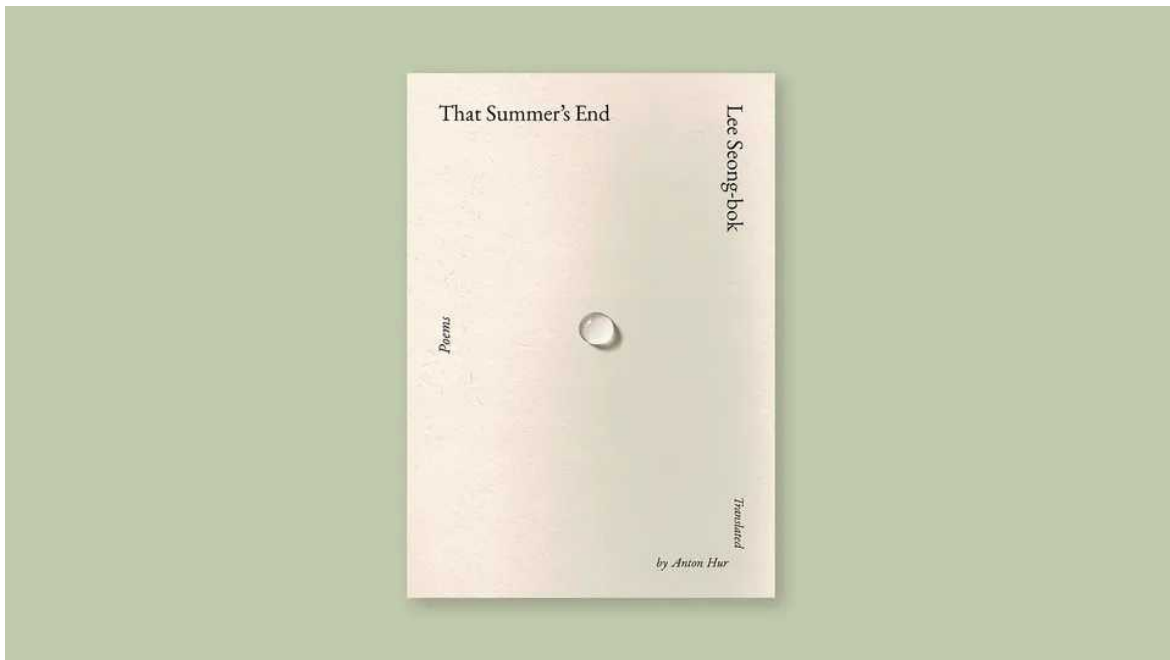
Briefly Noted

“The Maltese Version,” “That Summer’s End,” “Berlin Before and After,” and “Jean Toomer.”

September 21, 2026

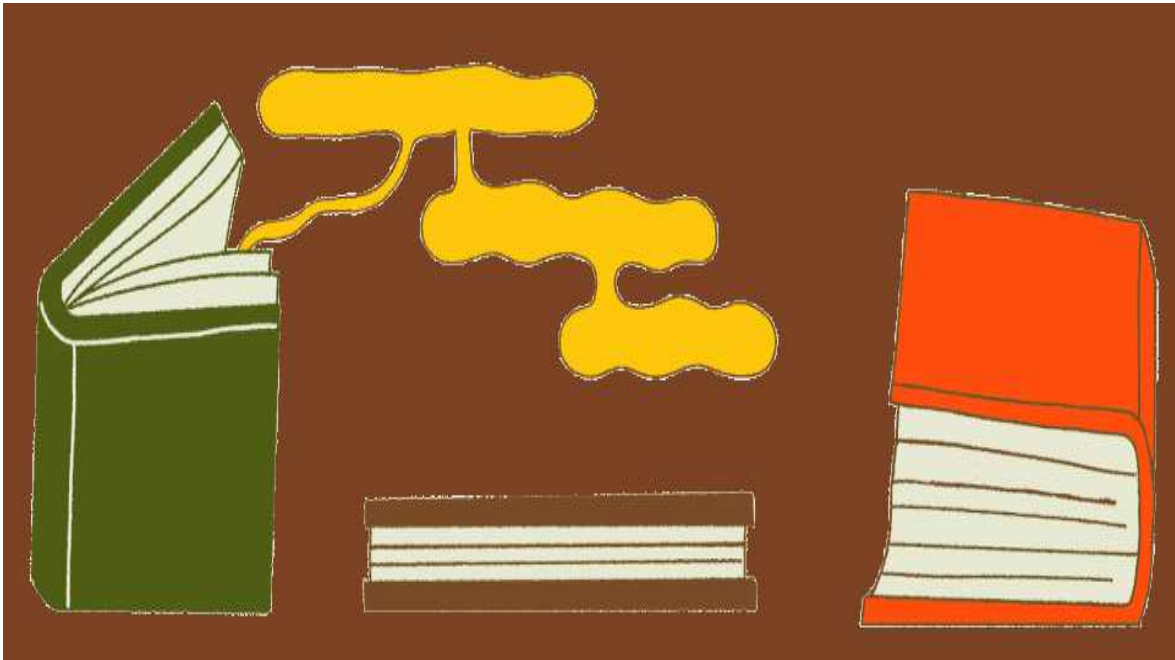


The Maltese Version, by Katy Simpson Smith (*Farrar, Straus & Giroux*). The timeworn saying about there being two sides to every story gains new dimension in this probing novel, which posits that “two sides means there are two stories.” Here, readers are presented with four sides, each belonging to a different woman connected to the same man: Max, a literary translator. One of the women, Max’s mentor, Herschel, induces him to go to Malta, to work on a collection by a local poet, Ana. When his girlfriend, Leonie, can’t get ahold of him, she deploys her friend Rhoda to investigate. As their lives intersect, Smith asks, How do we make meaning, and how do we convey it?

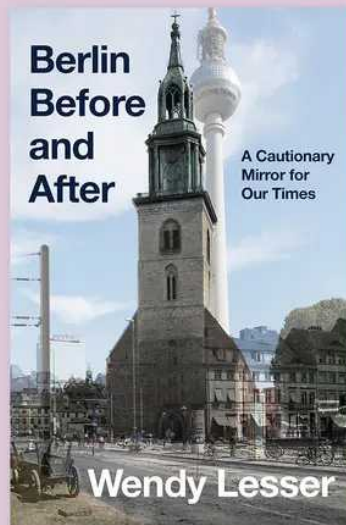


That Summer's End, by Lee Seong-bok, translated from the Korean by Anton Hur (*Knopf*). Nature, loss, and longing inspire these quiet verses, which conjure a sense of the immense mysteries governing the observable world. “How do feelings come / a bough first blossoms,” the book’s opening poem, “Feeling,” begins. “Is that how feelings come / a bough first drops its blossoms / Is that how feelings fall.” Lee’s lines have the intimacy and metaphysical heft of prayer; their elegant recursions and repetitions call to mind the cycles of life, death, and rebirth. Many of his poems are titled simply, in reference to the people, objects, animals, and abstractions on which he trains his attention—“Sea,” “Mountain,” “Cat,” “Child.” Throughout, Lee’s invocations imbue his subjects with an air of divinity.

What We're Reading

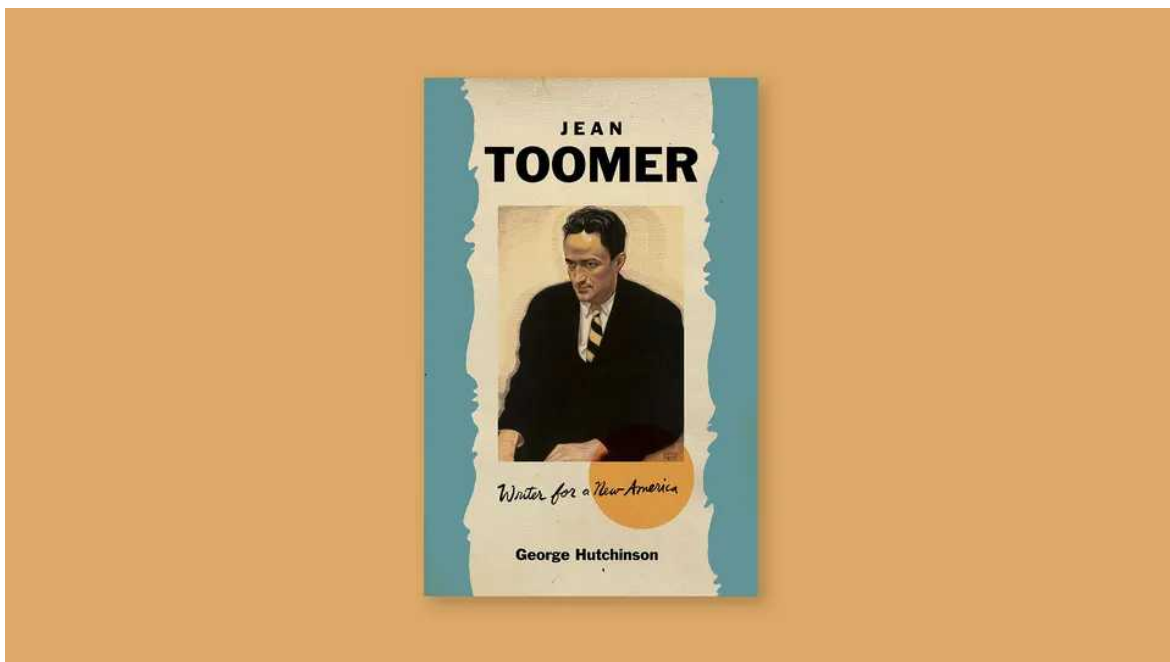


Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.



Berlin Before and After, by *Wendy Lesser* (Harper). This adoring tribute to Berlin considers the city's history as a "cautionary mirror" for the present.

Lesser, as a secular Jew born in California in the shadow of the Second World War, confesses to having once possessed an “ingrained distaste” for Germany. Yet when she began travelling there, in 2003, she developed an intense fondness for its capital. As her narrative moves from the vivid cultural ferment of the Weimar Republic to the era of Berlin’s division and on to today, it touches on figures such as Bertolt Brecht, Gerhard Richter, and Jenny Erpenbeck, and examines how Germany has memorialized the crimes perpetrated by the Nazis and the German Democratic Republic. Ultimately, Lesser’s goal is to show what other cultures can learn from the fact that, there, “the desire to wipe out the disparaged past did not prevail.”



[Jean Toomer](#), by *George Hutchinson (Yale)*. This illuminating biography focusses on the Harlem Renaissance writer, best known for the experimental work “Cane,” from 1923, which has since become a highlight of modernist and African American literature. As Hutchinson makes clear, Toomer had a complex relationship to Blackness; his grandfather was the mixed-race son of an enslaved woman—a heritage that Toomer embraced, before pretending ignorance of it. He also rejected the overtly racialized way that his work was categorized, a view that sprang from his belief that all people belong to the same “basic human stock,” and that, as Hutchinson writes, “the so-called separate races were products of false labeling.”

A Critic at Large

The Curious Power of Punctuation

Commas, dashes, semicolons, and spaces have shaped how we read for centuries. What happens when machines start crafting the sentences?

By Louis Menand

September 21, 2026



Do you know the first sentence of “[Pride and Prejudice](#)”? You probably think you do, but I bet you don’t. The answer is “It is a truth universally acknowledged, that a single man in possession of a good fortune, must be in want of a wife.” Did you remember to put in the commas?

What are those commas doing there, anyway? By modern usage, they should mark off a non-restrictive clause, but they don't. Nor are they marking items in a series or natural pauses in speech. Did Jane Austen even write them? Probably not. Judging by her few surviving manuscripts, Austen didn't much use commas (or paragraphs). She used dashes.

Here is a passage from the manuscript of her last finished novel, “**Persuasion**”:

“To see you, cried he, in the midst of those who could not be my well-wishers, to see your Cousin close by you—conversing & smiling—& feel all the horrible Eligibilities & Proprieties of the Match!—to consider it as the certain wish of every being who could hope to influence you—even, if your own feelings were reluctant, or indifferent—to consider what powerful supports would be his !”

Here is the same passage from the published book:

“To see you,” cried he, “in the midst of those who could not be my well-wishers, to see your cousin close by you, conversing and smiling, and feel all the horrible eligibilities and proprieties of the match! To consider it as the certain wish of every being who could hope to influence you! Even if your own feelings were reluctant or indifferent, to consider what powerful supports would be his!”

And so on. The published version replaces five dashes and three ampersands, and lowercases four capitalized nouns. It sounds more like Austen, but maybe Austen really sounded like Virginia Woolf.

Austen must have made some of these revisions herself, but it is believed that the grammar and punctuation in her later novels were cleaned up by a man named William Gifford, who was an editor at Austen’s publisher, John Murray. (“Pride and Prejudice” was an early novel, published by a different house.) Which might mean that the polished, quasi-epigrammatic sentences we find so Austenian may not be sentences Austen actually wrote.

Florence Hazrat, the author of “[On the Mark: From Periods to Interrobangs, How Punctuation Remade the World](#)” (Basic), would wish to point out that the difference for the reader in these two versions of “Persuasion” is entirely a function of the punctuation. Change dashes to commas, smooth out the prose, and the whole Austen experience is altered. What was pell-mell and excited becomes thoughtful and decorous.

Hazrat’s book is a history of punctuation—or some punctuation, since it barely mentions the apostrophe, the serial comma, or quotation marks. “On the Mark” is a “the X that changed the world” book, which is a popular

genre. Its claim is that “the history of punctuation is the history of humanity.”

This ambition inevitably leads to overreach. If punctuation played a role in everything, what about, say, the war in Gaza? Hazrat finds a link. “Punctuation marks in Hebrew,” she explains, “are relics of a brutal colonial system that is far from over.” Adding punctuation turned Hebrew into a spoken language, “paving the way for an artificial sense of unity among Jewish people from all over the globe, encouraging them to move to the land that already had people—a people made to suffer and bear the brunt of European anti-Semitism in the most horrendous ways for generations.” It seems (the reason is not altogether clear) that, had Yiddish been the official language of Israel, atrocities might have been avoided.

Zionist complicities aside, Hazrat is a punctuation enthusiast, though there are a few marks that she is not very fond of. The semicolon is one. She calls it “a dreamy kind of mark for meandering minds.” I would have said that the comma splice is the dreamy mark for meandering minds, not the semicolon, whose function is to replace the comma splice. But she doesn’t seem to know the semicolon’s correct usage. She thinks it’s a big comma, when it’s actually a small period.

On the other hand, she can’t get enough of the parenthesis, which, she says, dates to antiquity. I had always thought of parentheticals as subversive, a teasing or skeptical interpolation, the equivalent of a raised eyebrow. Hazrat understands them in pretty much the opposite way. “The parenthesis is a gentle kind of interruption, stable and predictable and balanced,” she says. “The parenthesis in word and deed is an ethical way of life.” (Since I use a lot of parentheses, this was encouraging.)

She tells us that the sentence-ending period was invented by Aristophanes of Byzantium, the head of the Library of Alexandria, in the second or third century B.C.E.; that the earliest known question mark is in a fifth-century document written in Syriac, a language close to Aramaic, which Jesus spoke; and that the exclamation mark dates from the mid-fourteenth century. The invention of the printing press, around 1440, let loose what she describes as “a flurry of signs,” including the semicolon, quotation marks,

the dash, and the ellipsis. No new marks have been added since 1600 (unless you count emojis, which we will get to).

In Hazrat's view, the greatest changed-the-world punctuation mark of all time is the space. She tells us that it was invented in the eighth century by Irish monks to separate the words in a sentence. She calls this hack "revolutionary." "Perhaps," she says, "it would be a stretch to say that the Irish monks' invention led to the liberations of classes and genders, caused wars and peaceful pacts, and paved the way for economic booms and busts, literary masterpieces from *Hamlet* to *Les Misérables*, and the development of the internet. Perhaps that's going too far, and perhaps not far enough."

I would say too far. But she has a point. The history of punctuation *is* the history of humanity in the sense that changes in the technology of writing—changes in how we write and how we make what we have written available to readers—correlate with changes in the distribution of social power. The purpose of punctuation is to make writing easier to read, and making writing easier to read means giving greater and greater numbers of people access to the written word. Literacy is no longer the monopoly of a privileged class. Today, even the gatekeepers are gone, or have turned into paywalls.

The excitement that Hazrat feels about punctuation—little marks that make a big difference—is a lot like Sarah L. Kaufman's enthusiasm for verbs. Verbs, Kaufman tells us in "[Verb Your Enthusiasm: How to Master the Art of the Verb and Transform Your Writing](#)" (Penguin Press), "can leap off the page and land in our bodies. They tickle the senses. They delight the instinct for movement. At times, they may tell you something true about yourself. All that in a word." Verbs are infinitely adaptable, she says. They are "the Cate Blanchetts of language."

The book is about how to use and misuse the different parts of speech (there are nine), with an emphasis on the verb. Kaufman has a favorite sentence that serves as a touchstone. It's the last sentence of "[The Great Gatsby](#)," and I bet you do know this one: "So we beat on, boats against the current, borne back ceaselessly into the past." She grows eloquent on the magic of F. Scott Fitzgerald's diction. "You might feel his verbs in your body, so delicately you're not quite aware of it," she says. "The repeated *B* sound—beat, boats, borne back—is percussive. The physical resonance of the verb *beat* may

echo internally in many ways, as you feel a soft drumbeat, as your heart beats. Reading ‘borne back’ may light a brief, indistinct flickering inside, a sense of how your own consciousness can whoosh backward in time.”

Apart from the fact that I have never understood what Fitzgerald is trying to say here— isn’t the whole point of the book not that Gatsby is doomed to return to the past but that he can’t?—I think that “beat” and “borne” lack visual concreteness. Shouldn’t it be “paddle”? “Paddle” sounds a little silly, but that’s the metaphor Fitzgerald is using. (Those boats must be canoes, not steamboats. A steamboat wouldn’t care that much about a current.)

Kaufman spent many years as the chief dance critic for the *Washington Post*, a job that must demand novel and unexpected ways of saying “leaping,” “lifting,” and “pirouetting”—hence her verb fascination. But she has thoughts about other parts of speech as well, and she offers a good deal of usage advice. Basically, “Verb Your Enthusiasm” is a style guide for newspaper writers: cut down on adjectives and adverbs, avoid the passive voice, prefer monosyllabic words, always say “he said” (not “he shouted,” “whispered,” “stated,” “averred,” and so on).

These tips make for good newspaper writing, but unless you are Ernest Hemingway, who began his career as a newspaper reporter and credited the *Kansas City Star*’s style guide with forming the basis of his style, they do not define good writing per se. Newspaper writing differs from most other writing because print-newspaper space is finite. The fewer words you use, and the more recognizable they are, the more you can say and the faster you can say it. That is where this modern minimalist verbal style comes from. Joan Didion, the mistress of concision and a Hemingway admirer, began her career writing captions and sidebars to fit around pictures in women’s magazines. Most writers don’t have those constraints, real or imaginary.

Still, Kaufman thinks that, if we are looking to speed the eye and save space, one part of speech we should be happy to throw overboard is the adverb. Her point is that if you have picked the right verb it won’t need to be modified. And many adverbs (“really,” “truly,” “literally”) do seem to be empty intensifiers. “Adverbial crutches are everywhere and misused in the extreme,” she warns (or, if you prefer, “says”). Her particular *bête noire* is

“actually,” which she calls “one of the most annoying and overused words in the English language.”

Microsoft Word doesn’t like “actually,” either. It tells me that “more concise language would be clearer for the reader.” I know this because I have already used “actually” twice in this piece, and I set off a Word alarm both times. Did they annoy you? Wouldn’t it have been more annoying if I had used, for example, italics, as in “sentences Jane Austen *wrote*”? Adverbs and italics often do the same work, but unless you are J. D. Salinger, who had a genius for them, italics can seem like an artificial pumping up of significance, verbal Viagra. Still, I have used italics in that manner once in this piece. And adverbs, even the intensifiers, can add shading and tone to a sentence. I can see giving them up for directness, but it is a trade-off. Writers have a toolbox. Why not use the whole kit?

E-mail, text messaging, and the internet have swamped us with new signifiers. I no longer need parentheses; I can use a raised-eyebrow emoji instead. I don’t write to someone anymore; I e-mail or D.M. them. “E-mail” is a denominalization, a noun turned into a verb. E-mail was a thing before it was a thing you did.

Denominalizations are not new. They happen constantly, and Kaufman, as a verb person, has an attraction to them. She says that Fitzgerald used “to cocktail” as a verb, as in “*Cocktailest thou? Dost cocktail? Wilt cocktail?*” But she notes that the coinage dates from the eighteen-sixties. Much of denominalization amounts to a brand war. Today, we say “I Googled it,” but not “I Binged it” or “I DuckDuckGo-ed it,” just as we say “I Ubered to the restaurant,” but not “I Lyfted to the restaurant” or, God forbid, “I Hertzied to the restaurant.” I can FedEx a package, and maybe UPS one, but at the post office it’s always “I mailed the package.”

It is, of course, all a corporate plot to insinuate commercial products into our everyday lives, a strategy that has been colossally successful for brands like Scotch Tape, Band-Aid, and Kleenex. Someday, “I Ubered” will just mean “I used a car service”; maybe it does already. There are also what I guess could be called deverbalizations: “the reveal,” “the ask.” But Kaufman doesn’t get into those. (A super-annoying and omnipresent related usage is “weaponize.” Use of that non-word must stop, today.)

These books are reminders that we are in the middle of a revolution in the phenomenology of reading, a major change in what it is like to consume writing. Many written texts we simply decode—instruction manuals, advertising copy, legal boilerplate. But, when we read for pleasure or for edification, we imagine a person “behind” the words. We treat writing as substitute speech. We say “That’s Jane Austen” or “That’s Virginia Woolf.” We feel we get to know writers by the sound of their words. More grandly, we experience writing as a way of transmitting an author’s state of mind, or set of emotions, to our own.

But, today, digital systems can generate Austen-like and Woolf-like sentences. We had feelings about our imaginary Austens and Woolfs; we “knew” them. But we are starting to realize that it is pointless, or stupid, to have feelings about sentences that a program spews out at an alarming rate. At some point, we will stop anthropomorphizing the words on the page or on the screen and start treating them the way we treat numbers, as marks to decode. When that happens, what will be left of the reading experience?

Hazrat and Kaufman subscribe to the theory of embodied cognition. They want us to understand reading as a somatic experience. “Verbs ignite emotions, transform our thoughts, and stimulate our bodies,” Kaufman says. That’s why she hears a heartbeat in Fitzgerald’s famous sentence. Hazrat puts it this way: “Punctuation enables us to access a text as a multidimensional full-bodied, full-mind experience.” Their books are therefore, in some respects, elegies to a conception of reading and writing which seems to be nearing an end.

We talk back to our G.P.S., and we say rude things to Siri. But that’s because we are mainly still living in a pre-A.I. world. The A.I. world itself still feels foreign. There is a creepy fascination with stories about people who fall for their chatbots, lawyers who submit A.I.-generated briefs, students who hand in ChatGPT-ed writing assignments. But we will adapt. Soon, people will no longer make a distinction between writing made by a human and writing made by a machine. It will all simply be writing. In that world, reading will no longer be the kind of embodied experience that Hazrat and Kaufman memorialize.

Hazrat complains about the disembodied feel of text messaging, and the fact that, as she reports, ninety-one per cent of Americans believe they can express themselves better in emojis than in written words. “No video conferencing or instant text messaging can replace presence,” she says, “and so we cling to the make-believe of technology.” What we are experiencing, she thinks, is not an ordinary shift in language use: “Generative AI confronts us with the possibility of a near-total abandonment of thinking work, that is, reading and writing. The surface engagement (if it can be called even that) of having ChatGPT read articles for us is already impacting our cognitive faculties negatively.”

She admits that chatbots have all sorts of personalized features, but they’re all fake. The conversational tone keeps us “talking” to the computer “because it feels like a real person,” she says. “Feedback functions like the typing awareness indicator and feel-good marks like emojis keep us online, keep us sending one more message, and another, and another, trying to finally get what we crave, connection, through something that simply cannot provide that, technology.”

Texting has virtually eliminated punctuation, undoing the centuries of innovation that gave sentences rhythm, shape, and meaning. Texters often forgo capitals and question marks (although they do overuse exclamation marks), and the period is avoided. “The polite way to be rude now is to use correct punctuation,” Hazrat says.

Kaufman is less apocalyptic. “No bot—so far—can craft poetic physical language that makes us feel something,” she assures us. Surely it’s only a matter of time. L.L.M.s already write poetry; the question is how good they can become at it. Right now, there is little money to be made from making them better poets. When there is, or even if there never is, they will keep improving in much the same way human beings do: by reading lots of poetry and learning what works. In the end, writing is just a technology. There is nothing magical about it. The usual worry is that we will mistake a machine’s poem for a person’s. The more dispiriting prospect is that we will dismiss a person’s poem as A.I. slop. We admire the person who can make good sentences, like Austen or Fitzgerald. Can we admire the makers of a generative A.I. that can do the same? ♦

Pop Music

Waiting for Jay-Z

In a sold-out run at Yankee Stadium and an eight-part documentary on HBO, the rapper makes the latest case for his own singularity.

By Hua Hsu

September 21, 2026



It was nearing midnight on a balmy Sunday in July, and there was still no sight of Jay-Z. This was the last of three sold-out concerts at Yankee Stadium, and somehow the tens of thousands of fans gathered inside didn't appear too aggrieved, peaceably bopping along to old soul tunes on the P.A. and eating chicken tenders out of souvenir boxes shaped like Timberland boots. We take the magnitude of Jay for granted. "I made the Yankee hat more famous than a Yankee can," he once rapped, a boast that's come to seem less outlandish with time. No other artist has withstood hip-hop's changing winds over such a long span, let alone won so many of the bets he placed on himself. Rap shows aren't known for being tidy, punctual affairs anyway—what was another hour?

Then again, this was a crowd over-indexed in forty- and fiftysomethings, a demographic that would really feel the consequences of a late night come Monday morning. What drew so many people to these concerts, as well as to recent stadium shows in London and Paris this fall, was a sense of nostalgia and a perception of scarcity. Jay-Z's previous solo tour was in 2017, after the release of "4:44," an absorbing, stripped-down record full of post-therapy insights meant to repair his image after rumors of infidelity—transgressions that might have been bad enough even if his wife was not Beyoncé. The following year, the couple released "Everything Is Love," a renewal of vows in album form, and toured Europe and North America as a double bill. In the near-decade since, Jay-Z has chosen his moments of visibility sparingly, appearing mostly as a power broker playing in one-per-center sandboxes. Although his gravitational effect on how people dress, what they sip at the club, and how they structure their bars has weakened, his presence is felt. "We tote guns to the Grammys, pop bottles on the White House lawn," he rapped on "So Ghetto," and it was a good, mischievous line back in 1999. But he has since become someone who texts Barack Obama, and who curates the most high-profile concert in the world, the Super Bowl halftime show.

The first night of the Yankee Stadium residency celebrated the thirtieth anniversary of Jay-Z's début album, "Reasonable Doubt," which he performed in its entirety, bringing out guests such as Beyoncé, Nas, and Alicia Keys. The following night, he did "The Blueprint," from 2001, again with high-wattage support. Neither of these victory laps was preordained: hip-hop is a young person's sport, and when "Reasonable Doubt" was released there was little reason to believe that Jay-Z, then twenty-six years old, would end up one of the greats. In the mid-nineties, the genre was dominated by prodigious, fully formed young talents such as Nas and the Notorious B.I.G. Jay had emerged a few years earlier, as the sidekick to a playfully spry Brooklyn rapper named Jaz-O, and had returned to selling drugs when both of their careers stalled. He eventually began to release his music through Roc-A-Fella, an independent record label that he'd started with some friends.

Jay-Z was early to realize that New York's influence on hip-hop was waning, and that the lines dividing styles, regions, and genres were no longer as important as they once were. After "Reasonable Doubt," a soulful,

bruising masterpiece inspired by his native Brooklyn, he proved to be a shape-shifter and a shrewd collaborator, working with rappers from the South when this still seemed like a daring thing for an East Coast artist to do. In the five years between “Reasonable Doubt” and “The Blueprint”—which was released on September 11, 2001—he went from being yet another New York rapper scrapping for relevance to being hip-hop’s undisputed king. And then he somehow kept ascending, sanding down the edges of his persona until he became the quintessential celebrity of the Obama era, back when the notion of doing unprecedented things and entering off-limits rooms felt transgressive enough. He invested in restaurants, created beverage and clothing lines, and became a part owner of the New Jersey Nets, helping oversee the team’s relocation to Brooklyn. In 2005, he rapped, prophetically, “I’m not a businessman, I’m a business, man.”

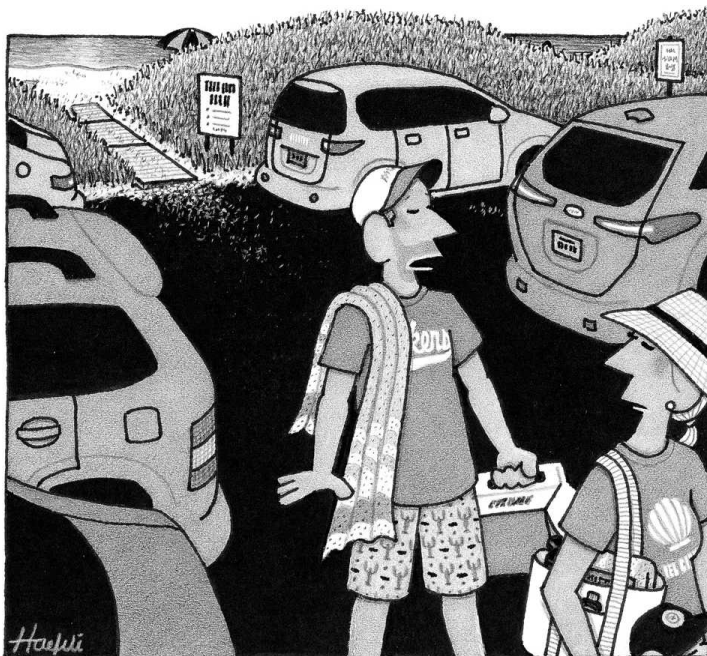
This last concert of the Yankee Stadium run promised to be a career-spanning revue—an enticing pitch, as the later albums have felt more like exercises in brand management. “Magna Carta Holy Grail,” released in 2013, was initially a free download exclusively for Samsung customers; “4:44” seemed partly an attempt to boost subscriptions to Tidal, a streaming company that he owned. Maybe, for Jay-Z, these were the only victories worth pursuing anymore. Perhaps after years of fending off challenges from rival New York rappers, there was a novelty to hanging out with Bono and Chris Martin—or Ivanka Trump and Jared Kushner—instead. This was as plausible an explanation for the delay as any: a guest on the level of a world leader. With Jay, anything seems possible.

When Jay-Z first announced his return to the stage, he sat for an extended interview with *GQ*, complete with a photo shoot by the artist Rashid Johnson, whose work he collects. His comments illustrated the unique burden of the hip-hop superstar, straining to stay in touch with the grimy realism of his earliest rhymes. He wondered aloud if rap’s hypercompetitive battle culture, as recently embodied by Kendrick Lamar and Drake, had become too much of a liability. (“I don’t know if it’s worth it at this point.”) He called the rising tide of anti-billionaire sentiment in America a “cop-out,” sounding slightly defensive. His wealth hasn’t changed his sense of morality, he explained. “A person with more money can do more good. . . . This is the system that we have. And with the system that we have, what are you going to do?” The elephant in the room was a lawsuit, filed in 2024 and withdrawn

in 2025, in which an anonymous woman had accused him and Diddy of sexually assaulting her when she was a teen-ager. “That shit took a lot out of me,” he said. “I was angry. I haven’t been that angry in a long time.”

Jay-Z opened the first night at Yankee Stadium with a kind of State of the Union freestyle. He hinted that Colin Kaepernick, the former N.F.L. quarterback, whom many believe to have been blackballed by the league for his advocacy against police brutality, wasn’t as righteous as we thought. Jay argued that he had chosen a less showy way to make change, advocating for criminal-justice reform out of the spotlight. “I’m the one they can’t control,” he rapped, suggesting that Kaepernick had taken an unreported payout from the N.F.L. and dismissing the “Twitter activists” who didn’t see the long game of his backroom advocacy.

The backroom becomes literal in “Jay-Z in 8,” a new eight-part documentary series on HBO featuring the rapper in conversation with the producer Rick Rubin, who has been anointed a mascot of sorts for the notion of creativity. Each episode shows the two men sitting in the Palais Brongniart, in Paris, listening to Jay’s songs on a very nice sound system, and talking about them. “This is like elder wisdom,” Rubin says excitedly, after playing “Don’t You Know,” a preternaturally mature track from 2002. “It’s really wild,” Jay agrees. “I don’t know where it was coming from.”



Their conversations drift from Jay's memories of his late, long-estranged father to his experience with therapy, measuring the distance between the brash playboy of then and the fifty-six-year-old family man of now. The series ends up being the latest retelling of a story that fans know well at this point—I still prefer “Fade to Black,” from 2004, a behind-the-scenes film about the making of “The Black Album,” and “Decoded,” from 2010, an autobiography co-authored with the journalist dream hampton. What distinguishes this new project is Jay's obvious delight in having Rubin, the eccentric naïf, as his interlocutor and audience. (Rubin played the same role for Paul McCartney in “McCartney 3,2,1,” a six-part documentary from 2021.) “You knew so much,” Rubin effuses about the early music. “It's amazing.”

The pair's narration of Jay-Z's life doubles as a history of America in the past half century, beginning with the economic collapse of New York in the seventies, running through the rise of rap, the crack epidemic, and the war on drugs, and landing on the eventual pathbreaking successes of the hip-hop generation. Jay has always skillfully folded each turn into his larger mythology, going from drug dealer to rapper to label boss to executive with an air of inevitability, every choice subsumed into the glory of the hustle. “Have you been the same person the whole time?” Rubin asks innocently. No, Jay replies. He was constantly becoming someone different.

It was Monday by the time Jay-Z took the stage. As the introduction to “The Dynasty: Roc La Familia” pulsed through the Stadium, he stepped out wearing a Yankees cap and a bespoke pin-striped workwear suit, looking like the most elegant handyman on Earth. His band turned the song into a headbanger's delight; Jay remained steady and regal over the crunching guitar chords and cathartic drum kicks. When it was over, he took a moment to explain the delay. Some fans had breached one of the entrances without paying, leading security to shut down the entire Stadium. Jay had insisted on waiting until every ticket holder was allowed in before performing. But he promised that he would not be shortchanging us.

Jay was limber and cocky, unhurried as he prowled the stage. We had been waiting for four hours, desperate for a release, yet he was assured and deliberate with every move. His strength in the late nineties was a kind of calm under pressure, and his power in the next decade was translating that

swaggering cool for ever-larger stages. Songs that felt tense and claustrophobic on the records—such as “Where I’m From,” a track from 1997 about the Marcy Projects—became seismic events when performed live.

At one point, Jay removed his jacket and revealed what appeared to be a bulletproof vest—a nod to the “Streets Is Watching” video, from 1998, when his paranoia toward his rivals was at its highest. The delirium of the late hour only deepened as the guests came out: Jeezy, Teyana Taylor, Jermaine Dupri, Usher, Swizz Beatz, Rihanna (who briefly out-swaggered Jay), Pharrell, and Beyoncé, backed by the Mayyas, a Lebanese dance group. These were all stars he could either claim credit for making or consider of equal stature. Even more impressive was how they had all stayed hours past their presumed call times. I felt silly for thinking that the evening’s guests might have been fellow nineties stalwarts such as M.O.P. or Cam’ron. The legacy that Jay wanted to broadcast was not one in which he acknowledged his generational peers, many of whom are more likely to feature on back-in-the-day podcasts than on new tracks.

For a couple of hours, it was easy to forget who Jay had become, and to instead marvel that he was still here at all. So many of the supporting characters of his rise were absent, whether they had lost their place in his inner circle, such as his Roc-A-Fella co-founder Damon Dash, or died before their time, as with the Notorious B.I.G. and DMX. Of course, there was no Diddy or R. Kelly, both incarcerated for sexual misconduct. The most auspicious absence was Kanye West, Jay’s estranged former protégé, who is arguably the only other solo rapper who could draw crowds of this size.

An elevated subway train rumbled by in the distance, just past the outfield, a reminder of the city beyond. How could Jay-Z possibly stay connected to the world that his music was designed to escape? Standing in the audience, I thought about hearing “Hard Knock Life (Ghetto Anthem)” for the first time, recognizing that it was sampling the musical “Annie,” and finding this both absurd and totally irresistible. I remembered how effortlessly Jay took to hip-hop’s evolutionary turns in the late nineties and early two-thousands, moving from New York’s stoic classicism to the squeak and space-age funk of producers like Timbaland and the Neptunes. I thought about the hours I’d

spent in the d.j. booth trying to figure out how to mix in and out of “Big Pimpin’ ” or admiring the blunt simplicity of “Money, Cash, Hoes,” which still sounds to me like someone getting frustrated with a keyboard and throwing it down a stairwell.

I looked around and imagined everyone was similarly adrift, all of us in our own orbits, with Jay the common gravitational center. Yankee Stadium felt small and intimate. My friend and I left during the encore, as he began “Empire State of Mind,” a song that became so ubiquitous during the Knicks playoff run this spring that I never need to hear it again. It seemed more sensible to beat the traffic. ♦

Poems

- [Garden](#)
- [Debt](#)

Poems

Garden

By Melissa Broder

September 20, 2026



I was in Eden. God's light
Tongued the leaves. How
Did anyone live? Shame
In wanting to die
In Eden. I didn't
Understand
Sun. I was under
Frost. Frosted.
In the mornings
The frost was so great
A devil I needed
Prayer. If god
Was there then where
Was god? If god
Was there then what
Was god? Paradise

Felt far. There is nothing
Like okayness. I would have
Loved a softer soil. I would
Have loved not to want
To go under it

Debt

By Daniel Poppick

September 20, 2026



What debt is this whose currency is sleep?
What clued me in

To your delay? What's the content of a leaf?
Who's fool enough

To commune in them? What choice poisons
Commingle with chlorophyll

To chase us to the other end
Of decay?

To what address can we send the flowers
Or in lieu of flowers

What fund should we invest with this thousand-mile
Stare through flaming

Fields of aster, star-torched tendrils of our
Vision insisting

In pale ashy patterns to leave some room
For the ghost's donation?

Can I ask who's calling? Aren't you
Sleeping in?

When will I wake, erased by a glacial gaze
Frozen out

Like a convex plinth of air's obsession
With a pyramid?

What's a poem compared to a mouth?
Who's there to hear it?

Why are all your texts written in
Invisible ink

At this late hour? To whom
Do I owe the pleasure?

This is drawn from "Lines and Circles."

Puzzles & Games

- [The Crossword: Wednesday, September 16, 2026](#)

Crossword

The Crossword: Wednesday, September 16, 2026

A beginner-friendly puzzle.

By Erik Agard

September 16, 2026

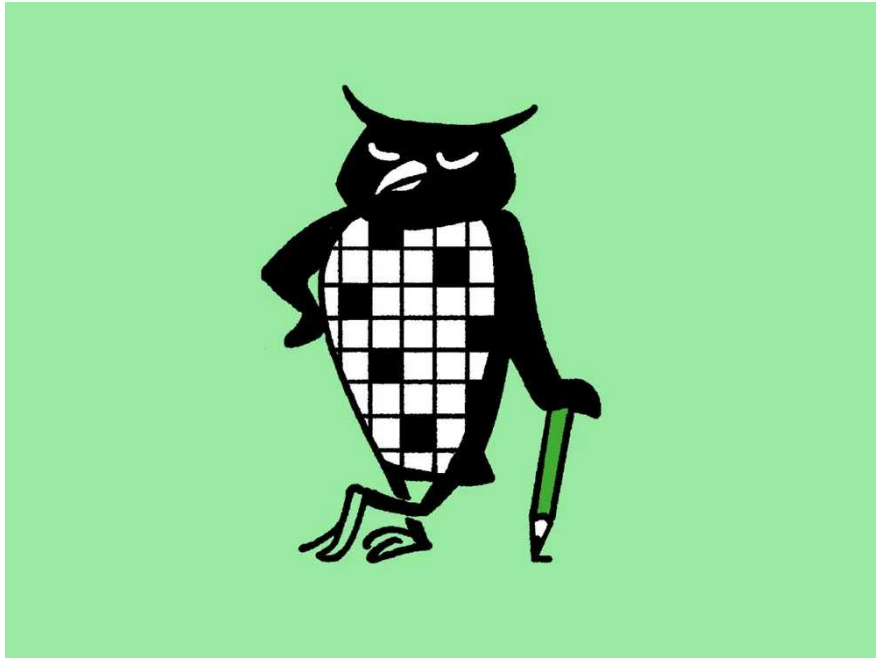




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